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Revelation

Revelation - Introduction

Part 1: General Introduction

Outline of Revelation

1. Opening (1:1–20)
2. Letters to the seven churches (2:1–3:22)
3. Vision of God and the Lamb in heaven (4:1–5:14)
4. The seven seals (6:1–8:1)
5. The seven trumpets (8:2–13:18)
6. Worship of the Lamb and judgment against Babylon (14:1–20)
7. The seven bowls (15:1–18:24)
8. Worship in heaven (19:1–10)
9. The destruction of the beast (19:11–21)
10. The thousand years, destruction of Satan, and final judgment (20:1–15)
11. The new creation and the new Jerusalem (21:1–22:5)
12. Closing (22:6–21)

Many interpreters believe that a phrase in 1:19, "what you have seen, and what is, and what is about to happen after these things," describes three main divisions of the book. "What you have seen" would describe John's vision of Jesus in chapter 1. "What is" would describe the current situation of the churches, addressed in chapters 2 and 3. "What is about to happen after these things" would describe the visions of the future in the rest of the book.

Who wrote the book of Revelation?
The author identifies himself as John. Many interpreters believe that this means he was the apostle John. However, other interpreters believe this was a different man named John, a prophet who had a ministry among the seven churches described in chapters 2 and 3. In either case, this man wrote the book while on the island of Patmos. The Romans had exiled him there for teaching people about Jesus.

What type of writing is the book of Revelation?
John used a special style of writing to describe his visions. John described what he saw by using many symbols. This style of writing is called symbolic prophecy or apocalyptic literature, and a book written in this style is called an apocalypse.

No other book of the Bible is written entirely in apocalyptic style like the book of Revelation. However, some passages in the books of Ezekiel, Zechariah, and especially Daniel are similar in content and style to Revelation. It may be beneficial to translate Revelation at the same time as Daniel since those two books have a similar style and some shared imagery. (See: Symbolic Prophecy)

How should we translate the title of this book?
Translators may choose to call this book by one of its traditional titles, such as "Revelation," "The Revelation of Jesus Christ," "The Revelation to Saint John," or "The Apocalypse of John." Or they may choose a different title such as "The Things that Jesus Christ Showed to John." (See: How to Translate Names)

What is the book of Revelation about?
John wrote the book of Revelation to encourage believers to remain faithful even when suffering persecution. In the book, John describes visions he had of Satan and his followers fighting against and killing believers. In these visions, God causes many terrible things to happen on earth to punish wicked people. In the end, Jesus defeats Satan and his followers. Then Jesus comforts those who were faithful. Those believers will live forever with God in the new heavens and earth.

Does one need to understand the book of Revelation in order to translate it?
The book provides the reader with some idea of how to understand its symbols by interpreting a few of them at the beginning (1:20) and near the end (19:8). But one does not need to understand all of the symbols in the book of Revelation in order to translate it properly. Translators should not suggest possible meanings for the symbols in their translations. (See: Symbolic Prophecy)

Are the events of Revelation past or future?
Since early Christian times, scholars have interpreted Revelation differently. Some scholars think John described events that happened during his lifetime. Other scholars think John described events that happened throughout history, from his time until the return of Jesus. Still other scholars think John described events that will happen in a short period of time just before Christ returns.

Translators do not need to decide about the time reference of the visions in this book in order to translate it, and they should be careful not to let their own beliefs influence how they translate. They should leave the prophecies in the tenses that are used in the ULT.

Revelation - Introduction

Part 2: Important Religious and Cultural Concepts

Angels

People in this culture recognized that God uses created spirits called angels to carry out his purposes. In the book of Revelation, John describes seeing visions of angels announcing and executing God's judgments.

In chapters 1–3 there may be some special uses of the word "angel." That word can also mean "messenger," and so the "angels of the seven churches" (1:20) could mean messengers whom those churches had sent to John or whom John was sending to those churches. The word might also refer symbolically to leaders of those seven churches. In 1:1, John says that either God or Jesus "sent through his angel" to make this revelation known. If John is saying that it was God who sent, the "angel" could figuratively mean Jesus as a messenger of God. If John is saying that it was Jesus who sent, the "angel" could mean the actual angel with whom John speaks in 19:10 and 22:9.

In any event, translators should use the word "angel" throughout the book, wherever it appears in the ULT, and not offer interpretations of the word in their translations. (See: angel, archangel)

Part 3: Important Translation Issues

Language that would be figurative in other contexts

If your language does not generally use figures of speech, and if you have previously translated other books of the Bible, you may be accustomed to using literal language to translate figurative language. However, that would not be appropriate in this book, since John is describing what he actually saw and heard in his visions. For example, John says in 16:7, "I heard the altar saying." In other contexts, this might mean that John heard someone standing at the altar saying something. But within the world of these visions, the altar itself could have spoken. In 16:14, John speaks of "the kings of the whole world." In other contexts, this might be a generalization for emphasis, and it might be appropriate to translate it as "kings throughout the world." But in this book, this kind of generalization applies to everyone John saw in his vision, so it can be translated literally. In other contexts, the phrase "the throne of God" might refer figuratively to the presence of God (as it does in Hebrews 4:16, for example). But here it literally means the royal throne upon which God sits as the ruler of the universe. It would be appropriate in all such cases to retain John's actual language and not translate it as if it were representing something else.

Verb tenses

As John describes his visions, he sometimes changes back and forth between the present and past tenses or between the present and future tenses. You can make these verb tenses consistent in your translation. For example, in 16:21, where John says, "And great hail, about a talent, comes down from heaven upon men, and men blasphemed God because of the plague of hail, because that plague is exceedingly great," you could say, "And great hail, about a talent, came down from heaven upon men, and men blasphemed God because of the plague of hail, because that plague was exceedingly great." In 21:24, where John says, "the nations will walk by the light of her, and the kings of the earth bring their glory into her," you could say, "the nations will walk by the light of her, and the kings of the earth will bring their glory into her."

Singular and plural "you"

Many languages have separate forms for singular and plural "you." In most contexts in the book of Revelation, it is clear whether one person or a group of people is being addressed and so it is obvious what form to use. Notes will specify which form of the word the book is using when this may not be clear.

Periods of time

John refers to various periods of time in Revelation. For example, there are references to three and a half days, ten days, 1,260 days, and forty-two months. Some scholars think these time periods are symbolic. Other scholars think these are actual time periods. The translator should translate these expressions as referencing actual periods of time. It is a matter of interpretation, not translation, to determine their significance or possible symbolic reference.

"Saints"

John often uses the term "saints" to describe people who believe in Jesus and obey him faithfully. John uses the term by association with the way these people are set apart as holy for God. You language may have a term or expression of its own that would convey this meaning. In your translation you could also express the meaning plainly by using a phrase such as "disciples of Jesus" or "believers in Jesus." (See: Metonymy)

"Amen"

John uses the word "Amen" many times in this book. This is a Hebrew word that people used to express agreement and the wish that something someone said would actually happen. John spells out the word using Greek letters so that his readers will know how it sounds. In your translation you could also spell this word the way it sounds in your language, especially

Revelation - Chapter 1 Introduction

if people in the churches in your area use the word and your readers are likely to understand its meaning. If the word would not be familiar, you could translate it with a phrase that expresses its meaning, as the UST does by translating "Amen" as "May it be so." However, in 3:14, where Jesus describes himself as "the Amen," it would probably be most appropriate to spell the word the way it sounds, rather than have Jesus call himself "the May It Be So." (See: Copy or Borrow Words)

"Behold"
As John describes what he saw in his visions, he frequently uses the word "behold" to focus the attention of his listeners on what he is about to say. Jesus also uses the word that way in his letters to the seven churches, and characters in the visions that John sees also use the word in the same sense. The word literally means "look!" or "see!" However, in this usage, the expression means to "see" in the figurative sense of giving notice and attention. If it would be helpful in your language, in your translation you could express the meaning plainly by using an expression such as "listen carefully!" (See: Metaphor)

"Keep"
In this book, John uses the word "keep" many times to mean "obey." If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. For example, in 1:3 you could say "obeying" rather than "keeping." However, there are two places, 3:10 and 16:15, where the word means "preserve" instead. In 3:10, Jesus actually contrasts these two meanings. He says, "Because you have kept the word of my steadfastness, I will also keep you from the hour of testing." This means, "Because you have obeyed the word of my steadfastness, I will also preserve you from the hour of testing." In 16:15, the phrase "the one keeping his garments" means "the one preserving his garments," that is, keeping them in good repair, "so that he might not walk around naked." Notes will address these specific uses; in other contexts, translators may find that "obey" is a good way to translate the term "keep." (See: Idiom)

"Certainly not"
In many places throughout the book of Revelation, the ULT uses the expression "certainly not" to translate a double negative that John uses for emphasis. The second negative does not cancel the first to create a positive meaning. If for emphasis your language uses double negatives that do not cancel one another, it would be appropriate to use that construction in these places. (See: Double Negatives)

"the ones living on the earth"
John uses the expression "the ones living on the earth" in a specific sense in several places in the book (3:10, 6:10, 8:13, 11:10, 13:8, 13:12, 13:14, 17:2, 17:8). In these places John is not referring in general to humans who live in the world. He means specifically people who will disobey God and worship idols at the time of the events that the book of Revelation describes. You may have an expression in your language that you could use in these places with this meaning, such as "worldly people."

Revelation - Chapter 1 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter explains how the book of Revelation records the vision that John received on the island of Patmos.

- Prologue (1:1–8)
- Preface (1:1–3)
- Address and Doxology (1:4–6)
- Theme (1:7–8)
- John's Vision of Christ (1:9–20)

Some translations set quotations from the Old Testament farther to the right on the page to make them easier to read. The ULT does this with the words quoted in verse 7.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Language that would be figurative in other contexts
To describe the way he saw Jesus in the opening vision that this chapter relates, John uses much language that would be treated as figurative in other contexts. For example, John says in verse 16 that Jesus had "a sharp, double-edged sword coming out of his mouth," and yet Jesus was still able to speak. Since Hebrews 4:12 describes the word of God as like a double-edged sword, we might therefore think that this image actually indicates that Jesus speaks the very words of God because he is God himself. But as the General Introduction to Revelation discusses, it would not be appropriate to use literal language like that in your translation to explain the meaning of what John saw. John is describing what he actually saw and heard in his visions, and you should simply translate his descriptions rather than interpreting them.

Seven churches
John wrote this book to seven actual churches in the Roman province of Asia. That province was located in the western part of what is now the country

of Turkey. The churches themselves would be found in the southwestern area of Turkey. The list of the churches in verse 11 follows a particular order. The list begins with Ephesus, the most important city at the time, and moves clockwise around the cities, ending with Laodicea, which was the southernmost city. The letters in chapters 2 and 3 follow this same order.

Revelation 1:1 (#3)

τοῖς δούλοις αὐτοῦ

"to his servants"

Here, **his servants** refers to people who believe in Jesus Christ and accordingly serve him as their Lord. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate that explicitly. Alternate translation: [those who believe in him]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 1:1 (#6)

Ἰωάννῃ

"John"

The word **John** is the name of a man. See the General Introduction to Revelation for a discussion of who this man may have been.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 1:1 (#2)

ἀποκάλυψις Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ

"The revelation of Jesus Christ"

This phrase could mean: (1) that this book is a **revelation** that came to Jesus from God. Alternate translation: [The revelation to Jesus Christ]; (2) that this book is a **revelation** that came from Jesus to John, the author of the book. Alternate translation: [The revelation from Jesus Christ]

See: Possession

Revelation 1:1 (#5)

τῷ δούλῳ αὐτοῦ, Ἰωάννῃ

"to his servant John"

John is speaking about himself in the third person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [to me, John, his servant]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Revelation 1:1 (#1)

ἀποκάλυψις Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ, ἣν ἔδωκεν αὐτῷ ὁ Θεὸς

"The revelation of Jesus Christ, which God gave to him"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **revelation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [The things that God revealed to Jesus Christ] or [The things that Jesus Christ revealed, which God gave him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 1:1 (#4)

ἐσήμανεν

"he signified"

The word translated **signified** could mean implicitly (1) that Jesus used signs or symbols to communicate this **revelation**. Alternate translation: [he showed this by signs]; (2) that Jesus made known **what must happen soon**. Alternate translation: [he made this known]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 1:2 (#3)

τὸν λόγον τοῦ Θεοῦ

"the word of God"

John uses **word** figuratively to refer to the message that God spoke by using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to the message that God spoke]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 1:2 (#1)

ὃς ἐμαρτύρησεν

"who attested"

Although John uses the past tense and says **attested**, he means that he is testifying to what **he saw** by sending this written record of his visions to the believers in the seven churches. You could indicate this in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [who is attesting, by sending you this written record of his visions,]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

Revelation 1:2 (#4)

τὴν μαρτυρίαν Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ

"the testimony of Jesus Christ"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **testimony**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to the things about which Jesus Christ testified]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 1:2 (#2)

τὸν λόγον τοῦ Θεοῦ, καὶ τὴν μαρτυρίαν Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ

"the word of God and the testimony of Jesus Christ"

These two phrases mean similar things. John is using them together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [to what God told Jesus Christ to disclose]

See: Doublet

Revelation 1:3 (#1)

ὁ ἀναγινώσκων

"the one reading"

In this context, the word **reading** implicitly means "reading aloud." In John's culture, a message to a church, such as the message he is sending to the seven churches in this book, would have been read aloud to the assembled believers. You can indicate this in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. (Revelation is not simply declaring a blessing upon any believer today who would read the book out loud in private.) Alternate translation: [the one reading aloud] or [the one reading for others to hear]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 1:3 (#3)

τηροῦντες

"keeping"

See the discussion of the term "keep" in the General Introduction to Revelation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning of this expression plainly here and elsewhere throughout the book. Alternate translation: [obeying]

See: Idiom

Revelation 1:3 (#2)

ὁ ἀναγινώσκων

"the one reading"

Here, **the one reading** does not refer to a specific person. It refers to anyone who reads the words of the prophecy aloud. Express this in the way that would be most natural in your language. Alternate translation: [anyone who reads aloud]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Revelation 1:3 (#5)

ὁ γὰρ καιρὸς

"for the time"

Here, **the time** refers specifically to the appointed time when God will make the prophecies in this book come true. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this meaning explicitly. Alternate translation: [for the time for the fulfillment of what is written in this book]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 1:3 (#4)

τὰ ἐν αὐτῇ γεγραμμένα

"the things having been written in it"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could state this in active form. Alternate translation: [the things that I have written in it]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 1:4 (#8)

ἃ ἐνώπιον τοῦ θρόνου αὐτοῦ

"who {are} before his throne"

If these are individual **spirits**, is not entirely clear who they are, but they would be seven individual spiritual beings who had important responsibilities serving God. John indicates this by association by noting that they are **before his throne**, that is, in God's presence and ready to serve him whenever needed. Some interpreters believe that they may be the "seven angels" whom John describes in 8:2. Alternate translation: [who are always ready to serve him in important ways]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 1:4 (#7)

τῶν ἑπτὰ πνευμάτων

"the seven spirits"

The **seven spirits** could refer to: (1) the Spirit of God, that is, the Holy Spirit. The Bible can use the number **seven** as a symbol for completeness and perfection, for example, it describes the Holy Spirit with seven at-

tributes in Isaiah 11:2. If this phrase refers to the Holy Spirit, then John is giving a Trinitarian benediction by mentioning God the Father and the Holy Spirit in this verse and Jesus Christ in the next verse. Alternate translation: [the Holy Spirit]; (2) seven individual spirits who serve God. Alternate translation: [the seven spirit beings] or [the seven angelic spirits]

See: Symbolic Language

Revelation 1:4 (#2)

ταῖς ἑπτὰ ἐκκλησίαις ταῖς ἐν τῇ Ἀσίᾳ

"to the seven churches in Asia"

In this culture, after giving their own names, letter writers would then say to whom they were writing, naming those people in the third person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the second person. Alternate translation: [to you who are members of the seven churches in Asia]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Revelation 1:4 (#3)

χάρις ὑμῖν καὶ εἰρήνη, ἀπὸ ὁ ὢν, καὶ ὁ ἦν, καὶ ὁ ἐρχόμενος, καὶ ἀπὸ τῶν ἑπτὰ πνευμάτων, ἃ ἐνώπιον τοῦ θρόνου αὐτοῦ

"Grace to you and peace from the one being and the one having been and the one coming and from the seven spirits who {are} before his throne"

In this culture, letter writers would offer a good wish for the recipient before introducing the main business of the letter. Use a form in your language that makes it clear that this is a greeting and blessing. Alternate translation: [May the one who is and who was and who is coming and the seven spirits who are before his throne give you grace and peace]

See: Blessings

Revelation 1:4 (#5)

ὑμῖν

"to you"

The word **you** is plural here because it refers to all of the believers to whom John is writing. So use the plural form here in your translation if your language marks that distinction, and use the singular or plural form in the rest of the book as the context indicates. (As the General Introduction to Revelation explains, these notes will generally only identify forms as singular or plural if that might not be clear from the context.)

See: Forms of 'You' — Singular

Revelation 1:4 (#1)

Ἰωάννης

"John"

In this culture, letter writers would give their own names first, and they would refer to themselves in the third person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the first person. If your language has a particular way of introducing the author of a letter, you could also use that. Alternate translation: [From John] or [I, John, am writing this letter to] (with no comma following)

See: First, Second or Third Person

Revelation 1:4 (#4)

χάρις ὑμῖν καὶ εἰρήνη, ἀπὸ ὁ ὢν, καὶ ὁ ἦν, καὶ ὁ ἐρχόμενος, καὶ ἀπὸ τῶν ἑπτὰ πνευμάτων, ἃ ἐνώπιον τοῦ θρόνου αὐτοῦ

"Grace to you and peace from the one being and the one having been and the one coming and from the seven spirits who {are} before his throne"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the ideas of **grace** and **peace**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [May the one who is and who was and who is coming and the seven spirits who are before his throne treat you kindly and make you peaceful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 1:4 (#6)

ὁ ὢν, καὶ ὁ ἦν, καὶ ὁ ἐρχόμενος

"the one being and the one having been and the one coming"

These three phrases do not describe three different people. They all refer to God. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate this explicitly. Alternate translation: [God, who is and who was and who is coming]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 1:5 (#8)

λύσαντι ἡμᾶς ἐκ τῶν ἁμαρτιῶν ἡμῶν

"having released us from our sins"

John is speaking of **sins** as if they were something that had held him and his readers captive and from which they needed to be **released**. He means that

Jesus obtained forgiveness from God for people's sins. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one having obtained forgiveness for us for our sins]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 1:5 (#2)

ὁ μάρτυς ὁ πιστός, ὁ πρωτότοκος τῶν νεκρῶν, καὶ ὁ ἄρχων τῶν βασιλέων τῆς γῆς

"the faithful witness," "the firstborn" from the dead and "the ruler of the kings of the earth"

In this verse, John is alluding several times to Psalm 89. In that psalm, God speaks of King David as his "firstborn" and says that he will make him "the most exalted of the kings of the earth." God also says that he will establish David's throne forever like the moon, "the faithful witness" in the sky. Psalm 89 as a whole is a meditation on the promises that God gave to David in 2 Samuel 7. So all of these allusions indicate that Jesus Christ is the one who fulfills God's promises to David. You may want to explain this in a footnote. You may also want to mark the phrases that are Old Testament allusions by putting them in quotation marks, as the ULT does.

See: Quote Markings

Revelation 1:5 (#6)

τῷ ἀγαπῶντι ἡμᾶς

"To the one loving us"

Here, **the one** refers to Jesus Christ. If this is not clear to your readers, you can say this explicitly. Alternate translation: [To Jesus Christ, who loves us]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 1:5 (#7)

ἡμᾶς & ἡμᾶς & ἡμῶν

"us & us & our"

By **us** and **our**, John means both himself and his readers. So use the inclusive form of those words in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Exclusive and Inclusive 'We'

Revelation 1:5 (#3)

ὁ πρωτότοκος τῶν νεκρῶν

"the firstborn" from the dead"

John is speaking as if Jesus was literally "born" when he became alive again after he died. Since Jesus was the first person to do this, John says that he is the **firstborn**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the first person to become alive again after dying]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 1:5 (#9)

ἐν τῷ αἵματι αὐτοῦ

"by his blood"

John is using the word **blood** to refer by association to the sacrificial death of Jesus, since Jesus shed his blood when he died for **our sins**. Alternate translation: [by his sacrificial death]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 1:5 (#4)

τῶν νεκρῶν

"from the dead"

John is using the adjective **dead** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [from among people who have died]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 1:5 (#5)

τῷ ἀγαπῶντι ἡμᾶς, καὶ λύσαντι ἡμᾶς ἐκ τῶν ἁμαρτιῶν ἡμῶν ἐν τῷ αἵματι αὐτοῦ

"To the one loving us and having released us from our sins by his blood"

A new sentence begins here that continues through the rest of the next verse. This sentence praises Jesus. To make this clear for your readers, you could create a verse bridge for verses 5–6 and begin with John's wish that would Jesus receive glory and power. A verse bridge might say something like this: "May the glory and the power forever be to Jesus because he is the one who loves us and who has released us from our sins by his blood and who has made us a kingdom, priests for his God and Father. Amen."

See: Verse Bridges

Revelation 1:5 (#1)

καὶ ἀπὸ Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ

"and from Jesus Christ"

The first half of this verse continues the sentence from the previous verse. It may be helpful to indicate this by repeating some of the information from the previous verse. It may also be helpful to begin a new sentence here. Alternate translation: [And may grace and peace also be to you from Jesus Christ]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 1:6 (#3)

τῷ Θεῷ καὶ Πατρί αὐτοῦ

"to God and his Father"

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two words connected with **and**. The phrase **his Father** tells who **God** is. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase that does not use "and." Alternate translation: [to God, who is his Father]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 1:6 (#1)

ἐποίησεν & αὐτοῦ— αὐτῷ

"he has made & his & to him"

The pronouns **he**, **his**, and **him** all refer to Jesus. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Jesus has made ... his ... to Jesus]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 1:6 (#7)

ἀμήν

"Amen"

See the discussion in the General Introduction to Revelation about how to represent the word **Amen** in your translation here and in its other occurrences throughout the book.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Revelation 1:6 (#5)

αὐτῷ ἡ δόξα καὶ τὸ κράτος

"to him {be} the glory and the power"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for **glory** or **power**, you could express these ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [may all of creation acknowledge how glorious and powerful he is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 1:6 (#6)

εἰς τοὺς αἰῶνας

"to the ages"

This expression refers to endless future time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [forever]

See: Idiom

Revelation 1:6 (#4)

Πατρί

"Father"

Father is an important title that describes the relationship between God and Jesus. Be sure to retain this title in your translation.

See: Translating Son and Father

Revelation 1:6 (#2)

βασιλείαν, ἱερεῖς τῷ Θεῷ καὶ Πατρί αὐτοῦ

"a kingdom, priests to God and his Father"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of a **kingdom**, you could express the same idea in another way. The phrase **a kingdom, priests to God** is an allusion to Exodus 19:6, where God tells the Israelites, "You will be to me a kingdom of priests." This means that the Israelites will have the God as their king and that they will lead the other people of the world to worship God. Alternate translation: [people who obey God, the Father of Jesus Christ, as their king and who lead others to worship him]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 1:7 (#7)

ναί! ἀμήν

"Yes, Amen"

The terms **Yes** and **Amen** mean similar things. John is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [It will certainly be so!]

See: Doublet

Revelation 1:7 (#1)

ἰδοὺ, ἔρχεται μετὰ τῶν νεφελῶν, καὶ ὄψεται αὐτὸν πᾶς ὀφθαλμὸς, καὶ οἵτινες αὐτὸν ἐξεκέντησαν, καὶ κόψονται ἐπ' αὐτὸν πᾶσαι αἱ φυλαὶ τῆς γῆς

“Behold, he is coming with the clouds,” and “every eye will see him, even those who pierced him,” and all the tribes of the earth “will mourn because of him”

Behold, he is coming with the clouds is a quotation from Daniel 7:13. The phrases **every eye will see him, even those who pierced him** and **will mourn because of him** are quotations from Zechariah 12:10. It may be helpful to your readers to indicate this by setting off these Old Testament quotations with quotation marks, as the ULT does, or with whatever other punctuation or convention your language uses to indicate a quotation.

See: Quote Markings

Revelation 1:7 (#2)

ἰδοὺ

“Behold”

As the General Introduction to Revelation discusses, here John is using the term **Behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, in this instance and throughout the book. Alternate translation: [Listen carefully!]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 1:7 (#5)

ὄψεται αὐτὸν πᾶς ὀφθαλμὸς

“every eye will see him”

John is using one part of a person, the **eye**, to mean all of a person in the act of seeing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [every person will see him]

See: Synecdoche

Revelation 1:7 (#6)

οἵτινες αὐτὸν ἐξεκέντησαν

“those who pierced him”

John is using one thing that people did to Jesus when they killed him, they **pierced** him, to mean all that they did when they killed him. (Jesus’ hands and feet were pierced with nails when he was hung on the cross, and later a soldier pierced his side with a spear to see whether he was dead.) If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who killed him]

See: Synecdoche

Revelation 1:7 (#4)

ἔρχεται μετὰ τῶν νεφελῶν

“he is coming with the clouds”

John is referring to Jesus returning from heaven through the sky by association with the **clouds** that are in the sky. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he will return visibly in the sky]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 1:7 (#3)

ἔρχεται μετὰ τῶν νεφελῶν

“he is coming with the clouds”

The pronoun **he** here refers to Jesus Christ. If this is unclear to your readers, you could express the meaning explicitly. Alternate translation: [Jesus is coming with the clouds]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 1:8 (#1)

ἐγώ εἰμι τὸ Ἄλφα καὶ τὸ Ὦ, λέγει Κύριος, ὁ Θεός, ὁ ὢν, καὶ ὁ ἦν, καὶ ὁ ἐρχόμενος, ὁ Παντοκράτωρ

“I am the alpha and the omega,” says the Lord God, “the one being and the one having been and the one coming, the Ruler of All”

The phrase **says the Lord God** indicates that the clauses before and after this phrase are quotations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could move this phrase to the beginning or end of the verse. Alternate translation: [The Lord God says, “I am the alpha and the omega, the one being and the one having been and the one coming, the Ruler of All]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Revelation 1:8 (#6)

ὁ ὢν, καὶ ὁ ἦν, καὶ ὁ ἐρχόμενος

“the one being and the one having been and the one coming”

See how you translated this phrase in 1:4.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 1:8 (#3)

τὸ Ἄλφα καὶ τὸ Ὦ

“the alpha and the omega”

The first and last letters of the Greek alphabet are **alpha** and **omega**. When God says that he is these letters, he means that he is the one who was at the beginning of all things and who will be at the end of all things. If you wish to retain this image in your translation, you could use the first and last letters of your own alphabet. Alternatively, you could use plain language. See the next two notes for further possibilities. Alternate translation: [the A and the Z] or [the one who was at the beginning of all things and who will be at the end of all things]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 1:8 (#2)

τὸ Ἄλφα καὶ τὸ Ὦ, λέγει Κύριος

"the alpha and the omega," says the Lord"

Some versions add the phrase "the Beginning and the End" after this statement. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to follow the reading of the ULT and not include the extra phrase.

See: Textual Variants

Revelation 1:8 (#5)

τὸ Ἄλφα καὶ τὸ Ὦ

"the alpha and the omega"

God may also be using the first and last letters of the alphabet to represent two extremes of time, the beginning and end of time, in order to mean those extremes and all of the time in between. In that case, this expression would be equivalent to what God says in the rest of the quotation in this verse. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the one who has always existed]

See: Merism

Revelation 1:8 (#4)

τὸ Ἄλφα καὶ τὸ Ὦ

"the alpha and the omega"

The implication of God having been at the beginning of all things may be that God created all things, and the implication of that fact that God will be at the end of all things may be that God will bring all things to their appropriate end. In other words, God may be asserting his identity as the creator of the world and the ultimate judge of the world. Alternate translation: [the creator and the ultimate judge of the world]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 1:9 (#5)

τὸν λόγον τοῦ Θεοῦ

"the word of God"

John is using the term **word** to mean the message from God that he had shared by using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the message from God]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 1:9 (#4)

τῇ νήσῳ τῇ καλουμένῃ Πάτμῳ

"the island called Patmos"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the island that people call Patmos]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 1:9 (#3)

ἐν Ἰησοῦ

"that are} in Jesus"

Alternate translation: [that people who follow Jesus experience]

Revelation 1:9 (#6)

τὴν μαρτυρίαν Ἰησοῦ

"the testimony of Jesus"

In this possessive form, **Jesus** is the object rather than the subject of **testimony**. This does not mean **testimony** that Jesus himself gave; it means **testimony** that John gave about Jesus. Alternate translation: [the testimony that I proclaimed about Jesus]

See: Possession

Revelation 1:9 (#2)

συνκοινωνὸς ἐν τῇ θλίψει, καὶ βασιλείᾳ, καὶ ὑπομονῇ, ἐν Ἰησοῦ

"partner in the suffering and kingdom and endurance {that are} in Jesus"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **suffering**, **kingdom**, and **endurance**, you could express these ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [someone who is patiently enduring while

suffering just as you are because we are loyal to Jesus as our king]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 1:9 (#1)

ὁ ἀδελφὸς

"brother"

John is using the term **brother** to indicate that he has the same faith as the people to whom he is writing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [fellow believer]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 1:10 (#4)

φωνὴν μεγάλην

"a loud voice"

John is referring to someone speaking by association with the **voice** that the person is using to speak. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [someone speaking loudly]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 1:10 (#2)

ἐν τῇ Κυριακῇ ἡμέρᾳ

"on the Lord's day"

Here, **the Lord's day** means the first day of the week, which was the day on which believers gathered to worship because that was the day on which Jesus rose from the dead. In your translation, you could use the term in your language for the first day of the week. Alternate translation: [one Sunday]

See: Idiom

Revelation 1:10 (#1)

ἐγενόμην ἐν Πνεύματι

"I was in the Spirit"

Here, **in the Spirit** could mean: (1) God's **Spirit**, the Holy Spirit, influenced John so that he could receive divine revelation. Alternate translation: [The Holy Spirit influenced me]; (2) God caused John's spirit to be in a state in which he could perceive revelation. Alternate translation: [God influenced my spirit]

See: Idiom

Revelation 1:10 (#3)

φωνὴν μεγάλην ὡς σάλπιγγος

"a loud voice like a trumpet"

The point of this comparison is not that the sound of the **voice** was like the sound of a **trumpet** but that the voice was **loud** like a trumpet. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [a voice as loud as a trumpet]

See: Simile

Revelation 1:11 (#1)

λεγούσης

"saying"

The word **saying** introduces a quotation. What follows is what the voice that John described in the previous verse said. Consider natural ways of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may be helpful to start a new sentence here. Alternate translation: [That voice said]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Revelation 1:11 (#2)

Ἔφεσον & Σμύρναν & Πέργαμον & Θυάτειρα & Σάρδεις & Φιλαδέλφιαν & Λαοδίκιαν

"Ephesus & Smyrna & Pergamum & Thyatira & Sardis & Philadelphia & Laodicea"

The words **Ephesus**, **Smyrna**, **Pergamum**, **Thyatira**, **Sardis**, **Philadelphia**, and **Laodicea** are the names of cities. See the introduction to this chapter for more information.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 1:12 (#1)

τὴν φωνὴν ἥτις

"the voice that"

John is referring to someone speaking by association with the **voice** that the person is using to speak. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what person]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 1:13 (#2)

καὶ περιεζωσμένον πρὸς τοῖς μαστοῖς ζώνην χρυσᾶν

"and a golden sash wrapped around {his} chest"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. Alternate translation: [He had wrapped a golden sash around his chest]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 1:13 (#3)

ζώνην χρυσᾶν

"a golden sash"

A **sash** was a strip of cloth that someone would wrap around the chest to keep a robe closed. Your language may have a term of its own for such an article that you can use in your translation, or you could use plain language. Alternate translation: [a wide strip of golden cloth]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 1:13 (#1)

ὅμοιον Υἱὸν Ἀνθρώπου

"one} like a son of man"

The expression **like a son of man** is an allusion to Daniel 7:13. It means "like a human being." The point of this comparison is that the figure whom John saw looked like a human. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a figure who was human in form]

See: Simile

Revelation 1:14 (#5)

φλὸξ πυρός

"a flame of fire"

It might seem that the expression **a flame of fire** contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you can shorten it. Alternate translation: [a flame]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Revelation 1:14 (#2)

λευκαὶ, ὡς ἔριον λευκόν ὡς χιών

"were} white as wool—white as snow"

If your readers would not be familiar with **snow** or **wool**, in your translation you could use the names of things they would be familiar with, or you could use a general expression. Alternate translation: [were white as cotton, white as egret feathers] or [were brilliantly white]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 1:14 (#1)

ἡ & κεφαλὴ αὐτοῦ καὶ αἱ τρίχες

"his head and hair"

John is not saying that both the **head** (that is, the skin of the head) and the **hair** of this person were while. Rather, this phrase expresses a single idea by using two words connected with **and**. The word **head** tells where this **hair** was. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase that does not use "and." Alternate translation: [his hair]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 1:14 (#3)

λευκαὶ, ὡς ἔριον λευκόν ὡς χιών

"were} white as wool—white as snow"

The phrases **white as wool** and **white as snow** indicate the same thing. John is using the two phrases together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [as white as the whitest things on earth]

See: Doublet

Revelation 1:14 (#4)

οἱ ὀφθαλμοὶ αὐτοῦ ὡς φλὸξ πυρός

"his eyes {were} like a flame of fire"

The point of this comparison is that the **eyes** of this person were very bright, like a **flame**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [his eyes were as bright as a flame of fire]

See: Simile

Revelation 1:15 (#1)

οἱ πόδες αὐτοῦ ὅμοιοι χαλκολιβάνῳ ὡς ἐν καμίνῳ πεπυρωμένης

"his feet {were} like bronze as having been refined in a furnace"

The point of this comparison is that the **feet** of this person were shining brightly, as refined **bronze** does. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [his

feet were shining brightly, as bronze does when it has been refined in a furnace]

See: Simile

Revelation 1:15 (#2)

χαλκολιβάνῳ ὡς ἐν καμίνῳ πεπυρωμένης

"bronze as having been refined in a furnace"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [bronze that someone had refined in a furnace]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 1:15 (#4)

ὑδάτων πολλῶν

"of many waters"

By **many waters**, John could mean a loud waterfall or raging floodwaters. Alternate translation: [of a waterfall] or [of raging floodwaters]

See: Idiom

Revelation 1:15 (#3)

ἡ φωνὴ αὐτοῦ ὡς φωνὴ ὑδάτων πολλῶν

"his voice {was} like the sound of many waters"

The point of this comparison is that the **voice** of this person was very loud, like the **sound of many waters**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [his voice was very loud, like the sound of many waters]

See: Simile

Revelation 1:16 (#5)

ἐν τῇ δυνάμει αὐτοῦ

"in its strength"

This expression refers to the greatest brightness of the sun, which occurs at noon, when the sun is highest in the sky. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [at its greatest brightness] or [when it is highest in the sky]

See: Idiom

Revelation 1:16 (#2)

ἐκ τοῦ στόματος αὐτοῦ & ἐκπορευομένη

"coming out of his mouth"

Be sure it is clear in your translation that this means that the blade of the **sword** was protruding from **his mouth**. The sword itself was not in motion. Alternate translation: [protruding from his mouth]

See: Symbolic Language

Revelation 1:16 (#3)

ἡ ὄψις αὐτοῦ ὡς ὁ ἥλιος φαίνει

"his face as the sun shines"

John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [his face was shining as the sun shines]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 1:16 (#4)

ἡ ὄψις αὐτοῦ ὡς ὁ ἥλιος φαίνει

"his face as the sun shines"

The point of this comparison is that the **face** of this person was shining as brightly as the **sun** shines. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [his face was shining as brightly as the sun shines]

See: Simile

Revelation 1:16 (#1)

καὶ ἔχων

"and having"

If it would be helpful to your readers, you could start a new sentence here and indicate the subject of **having** explicitly. Alternate translation: [This one who was like a son of man had]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 1:17 (#2)

ὡς νεκρός

"like a dead man"

The point of this comparison is that just as a **dead man** is lifeless, John was so overcome by fear that he did not even have the energy to keep standing up. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [because I was so overcome by fear that I lost all my energy and became like a lifeless dead man]

See: Simile

Revelation 1:17 (#3)

ἔθηκεν τὴν δεξιὰν αὐτοῦ ἐπ' ἐμὲ

"he placed his right hand on me"

Jesus **placed his right hand** on John as a symbolic action to express comfort and assurance to him because he needed encouragement in this moment of fear. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [he placed his right hand encouragingly on me]

See: Symbolic Action

Revelation 1:17 (#1)

πρὸς τοὺς πόδας αὐτοῦ

"at his feet"

This expression means that John fell to the ground in front of this person. It does not mean that he landed right on his feet. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [onto the ground in front of him]

See: Idiom

Revelation 1:17 (#4)

μὴ φοβοῦ

"Do not be afraid"

If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this double negative that consists of the negative particle **not** and the negative verb **be afraid**. Alternate translation: [Take courage]

See: Double Negatives

Revelation 1:17 (#5)

ὁ πρῶτος καὶ ὁ ἔσχατος

"the first and the last"

This expression has the same meaning as "the alpha and the omega" in 1:8. See how you translated that expression there. Alternate translation: [the one who was at the beginning of all things and who will be at the end of all things] or [the one who created everything and who will bring all things to an end] or [the one who has always existed]

See: Merism

Revelation 1:18 (#3)

ἔχω τὰς κλεῖς τοῦ θανάτου καὶ τοῦ Ἅιδου

"I have the keys of death and of Hades"

Jesus is speaking as if he possesses literal **keys** to **death and Hades**. He means that he has authority over the realm of the dead. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have authority over death and Hades]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 1:18 (#5)

ἔχω τὰς κλεῖς τοῦ θανάτου καὶ τοῦ Ἅιδου

"I have the keys of death and of Hades"

The implication is that Jesus is able to give life to those who have died and let them out of **Hades**. You can indicate this in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I am able to give life to people who have died and let them out of Hades]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 1:18 (#1)

καὶ ὁ ζῶν

"and the one living"

If you translated "I am the first and the last" in the previous verse as "I am the one who has always existed," then the phrase "and the one living" means basically the same thing. Jesus would be using repetition for emphasis. In your translation, you could connect these phrases with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation, following a comma at the end of the previous verse: [yes, I have always been alive]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 1:18 (#4)

ἔχω τὰς κλεῖς τοῦ θανάτου καὶ τοῦ Ἅιδου

"I have the keys of death and of Hades"

In this context, the terms **death** and **Hades** mean the same thing. They both refer to the abode of the dead. Jesus is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [I have complete authority over the realm of the dead]

See: Doublet

Revelation 1:18 (#2)

εἰς τοὺς αἰῶνας τῶν αἰώνων

“to the ages of the ages”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:6. Alternate translation: [forever]

See: Idiom

Revelation 1:18 (#6)

τοῦ θανάτου καὶ τοῦ Ἅιδου

“of death and of Hades”

The word **Hades** is the Greek name for the abode of the dead. In your translation, you could spell this word the way it sounds in your language and then explain its meaning. Alternatively, you could use a word for the abode of the dead in your language. Alternate translation: [of Hades, the abode of the dead]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Revelation 1:19 (#1)

ἃ εἶδες, καὶ ἃ εἰσὶν, καὶ ἃ μέλλει γενέσθαι μετὰ ταῦτα

“what you have seen, and what is, and what is about to happen after these things”

See the discussion of this phrase in the General Introduction to Revelation. Jesus may be referring to the vision John is presently having of him, the letters he will tell John to write, and the visions John will later see. If that is the case, then Jesus is describing everything he wants John to write by naming its major components. Translate this phrase in such a way that this potential meaning would be clear.

See: Merism

Revelation 1:20 (#1)

τὸ μυστήριον

“The mystery”

Jesus is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be helpful in your language. Alternate translation: [I will explain the mystery]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 1:20 (#2)

ἄγγελοι τῶν ἑπτὰ ἐκκλησιῶν

“the angels of the seven churches”

In chapters 2 and 3, Jesus will dictate a letter to each of the **angels of the seven churches** as if those angels were the churches themselves. So in this vision in chapter 1, these **angels**, symbolized by the **stars** in Jesus’ **right hand**, seem to personify the churches. That is, the angels represent the churches as if the churches were people. These **angels** could be: (1) actual angels, that is, spiritual beings. Alternate translation: [angels who represent the seven churches]; (2) leaders of the churches, whom Jesus is describing as angels. Alternate translation: [leaders of the seven churches]; (3) messengers bringing news of the churches to John and carrying John’s letters back to the churches. Alternate translation: [messengers of the seven churches]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation - Chapter 2 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

- The Letter to Ephesus (2:1–7)
- The Letter to Smyrna (2:8–11)
- The Letter to Pergamum (2:12–17)
- The Letter to Thyatira (2:18–29)

You may wish to set each letter apart so that your readers can easily see that these are separate letters. You could, for example, put a blank line between these letters in your translation.

Some translations set quotations from the Old Testament farther to the right on the page than the rest of the text. The ULT does this with the words in verse 27.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

“the angel of the church”
Jesus addresses each of his letters to the “angel” of the church he is writing to. As a note to 1:20 discusses, the word “angel” could have a literal sense, or it could mean “leader” or “messenger.” You should translate “angel” in the introduction to these letters in the same way you decided to translate it in 1:20.

Balaam, Balak, and Jezebel
In two of the letters in this chapter, Jesus refers to people whose stories are told in the Old Testament. In the letter to Pergamum, in 2:14, he refers to Balaam and Balak, and in the letter to Thyatira, in 2:20, he refers to Jezebel. These were all people who tried to harm the Israelites by cursing them or by making them want to stop obeying God. Notes to these verses suggest ways of indicating that Jesus is referring to people whose stories are told in the Bible.

Nicolaitans
In the letter to Ephesus, in 2:6, and in the letter to Pergamum, in 2:15, Jesus refers to the “Nicolaitans.”

Revelation - Chapter 2 Introduction

This name describes people who followed the teachings or practices of a man named Nicolaus. It is no longer known who he was or what he taught. It is possible that he encouraged believers in Jesus, based on a misunderstanding of what it meant to be spiritual or to have Christian freedom, to take part in feasts at the temples of idols and in the immorality that happened during these feasts. In 2:14–15, Jesus seems to associate the teaching of Nicolaus with the teaching of Balaam, who got the Israelites "to eat food sacrificed to idols and to be sexually immoral." The Hebrew name Balaam has the same meaning as the Greek name Nicolas, "one who conquers the people," so when Jesus says in 2:14 that some in Pergamum follow the teaching of Nicolaus "in the same way" that they follow the teaching of Balaam, he may be saying that the contemporary teaching of Nicolaus is the same as the ancient teaching of Balaam. However, none of this is certain, so it would be best in your translation simply to refer to "the works of the Nicolaitans" in 2:6 and to "the teaching of the Nicolaitans" in 2:15 without trying to explain those things any further.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Levels of quotation

The opening of each of the letters to the seven churches is a quotation within a quotation, and the main body of each letter is a quotation within a quotation within a quotation. If your language would not put one direct quotation inside another, you can translate the opening of each letter so that its main body is a simple direct quotation. You could end the quotation that begins at 1:17 at the end of 1:20, and you could then have John resume his narrative of his encounter with Jesus at the beginning of each letter. For example, for the first letter, to Ephesus, you could translate 2:1 this way: "Jesus then told me to write to the angel of the church in Ephesus that the one holding the seven stars in his right hand, the one walking in the midst of the seven golden lampstands, said the following things." (See: Quotes within Quotes)

The use of the second-person singular in letters to groups

Since each of the letters to the seven churches is addressed to an individual "angel," the words "you" and "your" are singular and the verb forms are second-person singular. However, since the angel represents the church—Jesus is addressing the angel as if the angel were the church—"you" and "your" and the singular verbs are plural in their implied references to the believers in the churches. If singular forms would not be natural in your language in such a context, you could use plural forms in your translation. (See: Forms of 'You' — Singular)

In several places, Jesus switches to the second-person plural to speak more directly to the believers themselves. Notes indicate where this happens and suggest using the second-person plural in your translation if that would be natural in your language.

"The one ... says these things"

Jesus begins each of the letters to the seven churches by identifying himself with some of the symbols from the vision that John relates in chapter 1. As he does this, he speaks of himself in the third person. If this would not be natural in your language, you could use the first person in your translation. For example, you could say in 2:1, "I, Jesus, the one holding the seven stars in my right hand and walking in the midst of the seven golden lampstands, say these things."

"I know"

At the beginning of each of the letters to the seven churches, Jesus uses the phrase "I know" to express his personal familiarity with what is happening in the churches. This phrase communicates an assurance that Jesus understands the current religious, social, and moral circumstances in which the Christians are living. While the phrase is usually positive, sometimes it expresses a critical assessment. Thus the phrase indicates more than just a knowledge of circumstances on the part of Jesus. It also implicitly asserts a claim to be in a position to make an authoritative judgment, critical if necessary, about how the believers are responding to these circumstances. To show this, you might consider translating "I know" at the start of each letter as "I am well aware of" or with some similar phrase. (See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information)

"I have against you"

In several of the letters, Jesus tells the believers in a given church, "I have" something "against you." This phrase makes a negative, critical statement, even though it is typically found among other, positive statements. It means "there is something about you of which I disapprove." You could translate this expression with a phrase such as "I disapprove of you because" or "I have a criticism to make of you, that."

"you have this"

Conversely, in several of the letters Jesus makes a positive statement by telling the believers "you have this" and then naming something about them of which he approves. You could translate this expression with a phrase such as "this is to your credit" or "here is a good thing that you are doing."

"Let the one who has an ear hear"
Toward the end of each letter, Jesus says, "Let the one having an ear hear what the Spirit is saying to the churches." Jesus says this to emphasize that what he has just said is important and that it may take some effort to understand and put into practice. This expression presents four translation issues that could be addressed in various ways.

- The expression uses a third-person imperative. If your language does not use that form, you could express the meaning in another way that is natural in your language. For example, you could say, "May the one having an ear hear" or "The one who has an ear should hear." (See: Third-Person Imperatives)
- The expression might seem to be speaking of a specific person, but it really means any person who fits its description. In your translation, express this in the way that would be most natural in your language. For example, you might say, "Anyone who has an ear should hear" (See: Generic Noun Phrases)
- Through this expression, Jesus is addressing his audience in the third person, even though he is speaking directly to them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate the expression in the second person. You could say, for example, "If you have an ear, then hear" (See: First, Second or Third Person)
- The phrase "having an ear" represents the willingness to understand and obey, by association with the part of the body by which people would have received the spoken teaching of Jesus. In your translation, you might say something such as, "Anyone who is willing should understand and obey" (See: Metonymy)

"to the one conquering"
At the end of each letter, Jesus makes a promise "to the one conquering." This expression describes someone who wins a victory, such as on the battlefield or in a sports contest. In the context of the book of Revelation, it refers to a person who refuses to worship idols even at the risk of persecution and death. The expression is therefore paradoxical: The person is said to conquer or win a victory, even though it appears that his enemies have defeated him, since they have put him in prison or even killed him. In your translation, you may wish to express the meaning plainly by saying something such as "to the one who refuses to worship idols even at the risk of persecution and death." (See: Metaphor)

The expression "to the one conquering" might seem to be speaking of a specific person, but it really means any person who fits its description. In your translation, express this in the way that would be most natural in your language. For example, you might say "to anyone who conquers" or "to anyone who refuses to worship idols even at the risk of persecution and death." (See: Generic Noun Phrases)

Revelation 2:1 (#2)

τῷ ἀγγέλῳ τῆς ἐν Ἐφέσῳ ἐκκλησίας

"To the angel of the church in Ephesus"

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, here and in verses 8, 12, and 18 you should translate the term **angel** the way you did in 1:20. Alternate translation: [To the angel who represents the church in Ephesus] or [To the leader of the church in Ephesus] or [To the messenger of the church in Ephesus]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 2:1 (#3)

τάδε λέγει ὁ κρατῶν τοὺς ἑπτὰ ἀστέρας ἐν τῇ δεξιᾷ αὐτοῦ

"The one holding the seven stars in his right hand & says these things"

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, Jesus is identifying himself by referring to symbols from the vision that John describes in chapter 1. As Jesus does this, he speaks of himself in the third person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [I, Jesus, the one holding the seven stars in my right hand ... say these things]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 2:1 (#1)

τῷ ἀγγέλῳ τῆς ἐν Ἐφέσῳ ἐκκλησίας γράψον: τάδε λέγει ὁ κρατῶν τοὺς ἑπτὰ ἀστέρας ἐν τῇ δεξιᾷ αὐτοῦ, ὁ περιπατῶν ἐν μέσῳ τῶν ἑπτὰ λυχνιῶν τῶν χρυσῶν

"To the angel of the church in Ephesus write: 'The one holding the seven stars in his right hand, the one walking in the midst of the seven golden lampstands, says these things"

See the introduction to this chapter for a discussion of how you could translate this verse so that there is not a quotation within a quotation and so that the letter that follows in verses 2–7 is not a quotation within a quotation within a quotation.

See: Quotes within Quotes

Revelation 2:2 (#3)

κακούς

“evil ones”

Jesus is using the adjective **evil** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. The word is plural, and the ULT adds the word **ones** to show this. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [evil people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 2:2 (#1)

οἶδα

“I know”

See the discussion of the phrase **I know** in the introduction to this chapter. Alternate translation: [I am well aware of]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 2:2 (#2)

σου & σου & οὐ δύνῃ & ἐπείρασας & εὗρες

“your & your & you can not & you have tested & you have found”

See the discussion in the introduction to this chapter of how Jesus is using the second-person singular to address the “angel” of this church. Throughout this letter and the other letters in 3, it may be more natural in your language to use the plural form of second-person pronouns and verbs, since Jesus is actually addressing all of the believers in the churches.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Revelation 2:3 (#3)

οὐ κεκοπίακες

“have not grown weary”

Jesus is referring to giving up by association with the way that people who have **grown weary** often give up what they have been doing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [have not given up] or [have not abandoned your faith in me]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 2:3 (#1)

διὰ τὸ ὄνομά μου

“because of my name”

Here, **name** represents a person by association with the way that each person has a name. Alternate translation: [because of me]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 2:3 (#2)

οὐ κεκοπίακες

“have not grown weary”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this double negative that consists of the negative particle **not** and the negative verb **grown weary**. Alternate translation: [have remained strong]

See: Double Negatives

Revelation 2:4 (#2)

τὴν ἀγάπην σου τὴν πρώτην ἀφῆκες

“you have abandoned your first love”

To stop doing something is spoken of as leaving it **behind**. Here the expression **you have left behind your first love** represents **love** as an object that can be forsaken. Alternate translation: [you have stopped loving me as you did at the beginning]

Revelation 2:4 (#1)

ἔχω κατὰ σοῦ, ὅτι

“I have against you that”

See the discussion of the expression **I have against you** in the introduction to this chapter to decide how to translate the expression here and in its other occurrences in these letters. Alternate translation: [I disapprove of you because] or [I have a criticism to make of you, that]

See: Idiom

Revelation 2:5 (#2)

τὰ πρῶτα ἔργα ποίησον

“do the first works”

Here the word **first** indicates earliest in time rather than chief in importance. Alternate translation: [demonstrate your devotion to me in the way you did originally]

See: Idiom

Revelation 2:5 (#1)

πόθεν πέπτωκας

"from where you have fallen"

Jesus is speaking as if the believers in Ephesus have literally **fallen** from a height. He means that they are no longer devoted to him in the way they originally were. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [how much you once loved me]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:5 (#3)

κινήσω τὴν λυχνίαν σου ἐκ τοῦ τόπου αὐτῆς

"I will remove your lampstand from its place"

Jesus is not speaking of a literal **lampstand** here; when he says that he will remove this lampstand, he means that the assembly of believers in Ephesus will no longer exist. However, since Jesus refers to the lampstands in John's vision at the opening of this letter, it would be good to show the connection between the reference there and the reference here. In your translation, you might translate the term **lampstand** directly here but then explain its meaning. Alternate translation: [I will remove your lampstand from its place, yes, you will no longer be a church]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:6 (#1)

τοῦτο ἔχεις, ὅτι μισεῖς

"you have this, that you hate"

See the discussion of the expression **you have this** in the introduction to this chapter to decide how to translate the expression here and in its other occurrences in these letters. Alternate translation: [this is to your credit, that you hate] or [here is a good thing that you are doing: you hate]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:6 (#2)

τῶν Νικολαϊτῶν

"of the Nicolaitans"

The word **Nicolaitans** is the name for people who followed the teachings and practices of a man named Nicolaus. See the introduction to this chapter for a discussion of the Nicolaitans.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 2:7 (#1)

ὁ ἔχων οὖς, ἀκουσάτω

"Let the one having an ear hear"

See the discussion in the introduction to this chapter of how to translate this third-person imperative, found here and towards the end of each of the letters, if your language does not use that form. Alternate translation: [May the one having an ear hear] or [The one who has an ear should hear]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Revelation 2:7 (#2)

ὁ ἔχων οὖς, ἀκουσάτω

"Let the one having an ear hear"

See the discussion in the introduction to this chapter of how to translate this expression that might seem to be speaking of a specific person but which really refers to any person who fits its description. Alternate translation: [Anyone who has an ear should hear]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Revelation 2:7 (#7)

τοῦ ξύλου τῆς ζωῆς

"the tree of life"

Jesus is using this possessive form to identify this **tree** not as having life but as giving **life**. In other words, Jesus means not a living tree but a life-giving tree. Alternate translation: [the life-giving tree]

See: Possession

Revelation 2:7 (#4)

ὁ ἔχων οὖς, ἀκουσάτω

"Let the one having an ear hear"

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, the phrase "having an ear" represents the willingness to understand and obey, by association with the part of the body by which people would have received the spoken teaching of Jesus. Alternate translation: [Anyone who is willing should understand and obey]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 2:7 (#6)

τῷ νικῶντι

"To the one conquering"

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, while the expression "to the one conquering" might seem to be speaking of a specific person, it really means any person who fits its description. Alternate translation: [to anyone who conquers] or [to anyone who refuses to worship idols even at the risk of persecution and death]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Revelation 2:7 (#5)

τῷ νικῶντι

"To the one conquering"

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, Jesus is speaking as if the person to whom he is making this promise will win a victory. He is actually referring to a person who refuses to worship idols even at the risk of persecution and death. In your translation, you may wish to express this meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [To the one who refuses to worship idols even at the risk of persecution and death]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:7 (#8)

τοῦ ξύλου τῆς ζωῆς

"the tree of life"

This is a reference to the description in Genesis 2:9 of the **tree of life** that was in the Garden of Eden. The fruit of that tree enabled anyone who ate it to live forever. So Jesus is saying by implication that he will give everlasting life to anyone who remains faithful to him. However, since the tree of life appears in the closing vision of the book, in 22:2, it would be good to retain the image here rather than simply express its meaning in plain language. So you might translate the phrase **tree of life** directly but then explain its meaning. Alternate translation: [I will grant to him to eat from the tree of life that is in the paradise of God, yes, I will grant him everlasting life]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 2:7 (#3)

ὁ ἔχων οὖς, ἀκουσάτω

"Let the one having an ear hear"

Through this expression, Jesus is addressing his audience in the third person, even though he is speaking directly to them. As the introduction to this chapter discusses, if it would be helpful in your language, you could translate the expression in the second person, here and in its other occurrences in 3. Alternate translation: [If you have an ear, then hear]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Revelation 2:8 (#3)

ὁ πρῶτος καὶ ὁ ἔσχατος

"The first and the last"

See how you translated the phrase **The first and the last** in 1:17.

See: Merism

Revelation 2:8 (#1)

καὶ τῷ ἀγγέλῳ τῆς ἐν Σμύρνῃ ἐκκλησίας γράψον: τάδε λέγει ὁ πρῶτος καὶ ὁ ἔσχατος, ὃς ἐγένετο νεκρὸς καὶ ἔζησεν

"And to the angel of the church in Smyrna write: 'The first and the last, who became dead but lived, says these things"

If you translated the letter to Ephesus in verses 1–7 so that its main body was a simple direct quotation, you can continue to do that with each of the letters. Alternate translation: [Then Jesus told me to write to the angel of the church in Smyrna that the first and the last, who became dead but lived, said these things]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Revelation 2:8 (#2)

τάδε λέγει ὁ πρῶτος καὶ ὁ ἔσχατος, ὃς ἐγένετο νεκρὸς καὶ ἔζησεν

"The first and the last, who became dead but lived, says these things"

If you have decided to use the second person to translate these opening statements in which Jesus refers to himself in the third person, you can continue to do that here. Alternate translation: [I, Jesus, the first and the last, who became dead but lived, say these things]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Revelation 2:9 (#2)

καὶ οὐκ εἰσίν

"but they are not"

Jesus is speaking as if the people who are slandering the believers in Smyrna are literally **not** Jews. He means that they are acting as if they were not Jews, since they are persecuting people who sincerely worship the God of Israel. This makes them **not** Jews in

some spiritual sense. Alternate translation: [but who are not acting in the way that Jews should]

See: Irony

Revelation 2:9 (#1)

πλούσιος εἶ

"you are rich"

Jesus is speaking as if the believers in Smyrna were literally **rich**, even though he has just acknowledged their **poverty**. He means that they are spiritually rich because God will reward them for their faithfulness and suffering. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God will reward you richly]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:9 (#3)

συναγωγὴ τοῦ Σατανᾶ

"are} a synagogue of Satan"

Jesus is speaking as if the **synagogue** where these Jews gathered was literally devoted to the worship of **Satan** instead of the God of Israel. He means that when these Jews gather together and **slander** genuine believers, they are serving Satan's purposes rather than God's. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could say that plainly. Alternate translation: [their gatherings really serve Satan's purposes rather than God's]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:10 (#4)

ἵνα πειρασθῆτε

"so that you will be tested"

The words **so that** introduce the purpose for which **the devil** will **throw** some of the believers **into prison**. Use a natural way in your language for introducing a purpose clause. Be sure that it is clear to your readers that this is a purpose that the devil is pursuing. Jesus is not saying that he is going to use the devil to test the believers to see if they will remain faithful. Alternate translation: [to try to get you to abandon your faith]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Revelation 2:10 (#1)

βάλλειν & ἐξ ὑμῶν εἰς φυλακὴν

"to throw {some} of you into prison"

Jesus does not mean that the devil will literally **throw** some of the believers in Smyrna **into prison**. That is, the devil will not pick them up and heave them through the air. Alternate translation: [to have some of you put in prison]

See: Idiom

Revelation 2:10 (#6)

ἡμερῶν δέκα

"for ten days"

As the General Introduction to Revelation discusses, time references such as this one may have symbolic significance. In this case, by allusion to Daniel 1:14, **ten days** may represent a short or limited amount of time for testing. However, as the Introduction explains, it would be appropriate to translate this as a literal period of time rather than offering an interpretation of the phrase such as "for a short time of testing."

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:10 (#5)

ὑμῶν & πειρασθῆτε & ἕξετε

"you & you will be tested & you will have"

The word **you** is plural in these instances. Jesus is speaking more directly to the believers in Smyrna to warn them about the suffering they are about to experience. If your language marks a distinction between singular and plural forms of "you" and if you have been using the singular forms of "you" and "your" in these letters because they are addressed to individual angels, you may consider using the plural form of "you" here if that would be natural in your language.

See: Forms of 'You' — Singular

Revelation 2:10 (#7)

τὸν στέφανον τῆς ζωῆς

"the crown of life"

Jesus is speaking he will literally give these believers **life** as a crown to wear. He is using the word **crown** to mean "reward." If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [everlasting life as your reward]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:10 (#2)

βάλλειν & ἐξ ὑμῶν εἰς φυλακὴν

"to throw {some} of you into prison"

Jesus is speaking of **the devil** as the person who will do this action, but Jesus is using the devil to represent everyone who will responsible for it. The Jews in Smyrna would actually have the believers put in prison, acting under the devil's influence. Alternate translation: [to influence people to put some of you in prison]

See: Synecdoche

Revelation 2:10 (#3)

ἵνα πειρασθῆτε

"so that you will be tested"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [so that he can test you]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 2:11 (#3)

οὐ μὴ

"certainly not"

As the General Introduction to Revelation discusses, John frequently uses a double negative for emphasis that the ULT translates with the expression "certainly not," as in this case. The second negative does not cancel the first to create a positive meaning. If for emphasis your language uses double negatives that do not cancel one another, it would be appropriate to use that construction here and in the other instances of this double negative throughout the book.

See: Double Negatives

Revelation 2:11 (#5)

οὐ μὴ ἀδικηθῇ ἐκ τοῦ θανάτου τοῦ δευτέρου

"will certainly not be hurt by the second death"

Jesus is speaking as if people who had died would die a **second** time. By **the second death**, he means separation from God. That is spiritual death, just as physical death involves the separation of the human soul and spirit from the human body. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will certainly not experience separation from God after he dies physically]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:11 (#1)

ὁ ἔχων οὖς, ἀκουσάτω & ὁ νικῶν

"Let the one having an ear hear & The one conquering"

See how you translated these phrases in 2:7.

See: Metonymy

Revelation 2:11 (#2)

ὁ νικῶν οὐ μὴ ἀδικηθῇ ἐκ τοῦ θανάτου τοῦ δευτέρου

"The one conquering will certainly not be hurt by the second death"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [The second death will certainly not hurt anyone who conquers]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 2:11 (#4)

τοῦ θανάτου τοῦ δευτέρου

"the second death"

If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you can use a cardinal number here or an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [death number two] or [the next death]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 2:12 (#1)

τὴν ῥομφαίαν τὴν δίστομον τὴν ὀξεῖαν

"the sharp, double-edged sword"

See how you translated this phrase in 1:16.

See: Symbolic Language

Revelation 2:13 (#6)

ἐν ταῖς ἡμέραις Ἀντιπᾶς

"in the days of Antipas"

Jesus is using the term **days** to refer to a specific time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [during the time of Antipas]

See: Idiom

Revelation 2:13 (#9)

ὃς ἀπεκτάνθη

"who was killed"

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you could state this in active form or in another

way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [whom your enemies killed]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 2:13 (#7)

Ἀντιπᾶς

“of Antipas”

The word **Antipas** is the name of a man.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 2:13 (#10)

ὑμῖν

“you”

The word **you** is plural in this instance. Jesus is speaking more directly to the believers in Pergamum because of the suffering they all experienced when Antipas was killed. If your language marks a distinction between singular and plural forms of “you” and if you have been using the singular forms of “you” and “your” in these letters, you may consider using the plural form of “you” here if that would be natural in your language.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Revelation 2:13 (#5)

τὴν πίστιν μου

“my faith”

In this possessive form, **Jesus** is the object rather than the subject of **faith**. That is, this does not mean faith that Jesus has, it means the faith that these believers have in Jesus. Alternate translation: [your faith in me]

See: Possession

Revelation 2:13 (#4)

οὐκ ἠρνήσω τὴν πίστιν μου

“you did not deny my faith”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this double negative that consists of the negative particle **not** and the negative verb **deny**. Alternate translation: [you continued to believe in me]

See: Double Negatives

Revelation 2:13 (#8)

ὁ πιστός μου

“my faithful one”

Jesus is using the adjective **faithful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [who was faithful to me]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 2:13 (#2)

κρατεῖς τὸ ὄνομά μου

“you hold my name”

Here, **name** represents a person by association with the way that each person has a name. Alternate translation: [you hold on to me]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 2:13 (#11)

ὅπου ὁ Σατανᾶς κατοικεῖ

“where Satan lives”

Jesus is speaking as if **Satan** literally lived in Pergamum. He means that Satan has great influence in that city. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [where Satan has such great influence]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:13 (#3)

κρατεῖς τὸ ὄνομά μου

“you hold my name”

Jesus is speaking as if the believers in Pergamum were literally holding on to him. He means that they are continuing to trust him despite the suffering they are experiencing. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you continue to trust me]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:13 (#1)

ὅπου ὁ θρόνος τοῦ Σατανᾶ

“where the throne of Satan {is”

Jesus is speaking as if **Satan** literally had a **throne** in the city of Pergamum. He means that Satan has great influence in that city. (This could be a reference to a giant altar to the god Zeus that existed in Pergamum at this time.) Alternate translation: [in a city where Satan has great influence]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:14 (#1)

ἔχω κατὰ σοῦ ὀλίγα

“I have a few things against you”

See how you translated the similar phrase in 2:4.

See: Idiom

Revelation 2:14 (#3)

κρατοῦντας τὴν διδαχὴν Βαλαάμ

“ones holding the teaching of Balaam”

Jesus is referring to teaching that condones practicing sexual immorality and eating food sacrificed to idols by association with the way that **Balaam** advised **Balak** to get the Israelites to do those things. (See the discussion in the introduction to this chapter.) If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [people who teach the same things that Balaam did]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 2:14 (#6)

τῶν υἱῶν Ἰσραήλ

“the sons of Israel”

Here, **sons** figuratively means “descendants.” Jesus is identifying the Israelites as descendants of their ancestor Israel (who was also known as Jacob). If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people of Israel]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:14 (#2)

κρατοῦντας τὴν διδαχὴν Βαλαάμ

“ones holding the teaching of Balaam”

Jesus is speaking as if the believers in Pergamum were literally **holding** the **teaching of Balaam**. He means that they are doing what this teaching instructs them to do. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [people who are obeying the teaching of Balaam]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:14 (#7)

εἰδωλόθυτα

“idol-offerings”

The word translated **idol-food** describes food that was offered to idols. People then often ate this food as a way of worshiping the idols. Alternate translation: [food sacrificed to idols]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 2:14 (#5)

βαλεῖν σκάνδαλον ἐνώπιον τῶν υἱῶν Ἰσραήλ, φαγεῖν εἰδωλόθυτα καὶ πορνεῦσαι

“to throw a stumbling block before the sons of Israel, to eat idol-offerings and to be sexually immoral”

Jesus is speaking as if **Balak** had literally thrown a **stumbling block**, something that would make people trip and fall, in front of the Israelites. He means that Balak tempted them and got them to sin. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [how to tempt the sons of Israel into sinning by eating food sacrificed to idols and being sexually immoral]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:14 (#4)

Βαλαάμ & τῷ Βαλὰκ

“of Balaam & Balak”

The words **Balaam** and **Balak** are the names of men. Their story is told in Numbers 22:1–24:45. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could identify them further in your translation. Alternate translation: [of the ancient prophet Balaam ... Balak, the king of Moab,]

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 2:15 (#2)

Νικολαϊτῶν

“of the Nicolaitans”

See how you translated the word **Nicolaitans** in 2:6.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 2:15 (#1)

κρατοῦντας τὴν διδαχὴν

“ones holding the teaching”

See how you translated the similar phrase in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [people who are obeying the teaching]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:16 (#2)

αὐτῶν

"them"

The pronoun **them** refers to the "ones holding the teaching of the Nicolaitans," whom Jesus describes in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [these people who obey the teachings of the Nicolaitans]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 2:16 (#3)

πολεμήσω μετ' αὐτῶν ἐν τῇ ῥομφαίᾳ τοῦ στόματός μου

"wage war against them with the sword of my mouth"

Jesus is speaking as if he will literally **wage war** against the disobedient believers in Pergamum with the **sword** in his **mouth**. He likely means that he will announce a punishment against them that will become effective as soon as he speaks it. You could say that in your translation. The UST models one way to do that. However, since the symbol of the sword comes from the opening vision in the book, and since Jesus uses it to identify himself at the beginning of this letter, and since the symbol also appears in one of the last visions in the book, in 19:15–21, you may wish to retain the symbol in your translation rather than state the meaning plainly here.

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:16 (#1)

εἰ δὲ μή

"But if not"

Jesus is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You could supply these words from earlier in the sentence if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [But if you do not repent]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 2:17 (#2)

ὄνομα καινὸν γεγραμμένον

"a new name written"

If your language does not use the passive form in this way for the word **written**, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [a new name that I have written]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 2:17 (#3)

οὐδεὶς οἶδεν, εἰ μὴ ὁ λαμβάνων

"no one knows except the one receiving it"

If it would appear in your language that Jesus is contradicting himself by saying that **no one knows** the new name but then saying that **the one receiving it** knows this name, you could reword this to avoid using an exception clause. Alternate translation: [only the person receiving it knows]

See: Connect — Exception Clauses

Revelation 2:17 (#1)

τοῦ μάννα τοῦ κεκρυμμένου

"of the hidden manna"

If your language does not use the passive form in this way for the word **hidden manna**, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [some manna that I have hidden]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 2:18 (#2)

ὁ ἔχων τοὺς ὀφθαλμοὺς αὐτοῦ ὡς φλόγα πυρός, καὶ οἱ πόδες αὐτοῦ ὅμοιοι χαλκολιβάνῳ

"the one having his eyes like a flame of fire and his feet like bronze"

See how you translated these phrases in 1:14 and 1:15.

See: Simile

Revelation 2:18 (#1)

ὁ Υἱὸς τοῦ Θεοῦ

"The Son of God"

Son is an important title that describes the relationship between Jesus and God. Be sure to retain this title in your translation.

See: Translating Son and Father

Revelation 2:19 (#1)

τὴν ἀγάπην, καὶ τὴν πίστιν, καὶ τὴν διακονίαν, καὶ τὴν ὑπομονήν σου

"love and faith and service and your endurance"

If your language would not use an abstract nouns for the ideas of **love**, **faith**, **service**, and **endurance**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [how you have loved and trusted and served me and how you have endured]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 2:19 (#2)

τὰ ἔργα σου, τὰ ἔσχατα πλείονα τῶν πρώτων

"your last works {are} greater than the first"

Jesus is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [your last works are greater than the first works you did]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 2:20 (#1)

Ἰεζάβελ

"Jezebel"

The word **Jezebel** is the name of a woman. It is not clear whether this is the actual name of this woman or whether Jesus is calling her by this name because she is like the wicked Queen Jezebel whose story is told in the Old Testament. The UST models one way of indicating that this may be an allusion to the Old Testament rather than the actual name of this woman.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 2:20 (#2)

διδάσκει καὶ πλανᾷ

"she teaches and deceives"

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two words connected with **and**. The word **deceives** tells what the result is of what Jezebel **teaches**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase that does not use "and." Alternate translation: [she deceptively teaches]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 2:22 (#1)

βάλλω αὐτὴν εἰς κλίνην

"I will throw her onto a bed"

Jesus is referring to punishing Jezebel with sickness by association with the **bed** that she would have to lie on because she was sick. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will punish her by making her gravely ill]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 2:22 (#2)

τοὺς μοιχεύοντας μετ' αὐτῆς εἰς θλῖψιν μεγάλην

"the ones committing adultery with her into great tribulation"

Jesus is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [I will throw the ones committing adultery with her into great tribulation]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 2:22 (#3)

τοὺς μοιχεύοντας μετ' αὐτῆς εἰς θλῖψιν μεγάλην

"the ones committing adultery with her into great tribulation"

Jesus does not mean that he will literally **throw** the disobedient believers in Thyatira into **tribulation**. That is, he will not pick them up and heave them through the air. Alternate translation: [I will cause the ones committing adultery with her to experience great tribulation]

See: Idiom

Revelation 2:23 (#1)

τὰ τέκνα αὐτῆς

"her children"

The word **children** could mean: (1) literal children of Jezebel and the men who, as verse 22 describes, have been "committing adultery" with her. Alternate translation: [the children she has had with her adulterous lovers]; (2) the disciples of Jezebel. (However, since Jesus says in the previous verse that he will cause these disciples to experience tribulation if they do not repent, it appears that Jesus is giving them the opportunity to repent, so it seems unlikely that he would immediately pronounce a death sentence against them here.) Alternate translation: [her disciples]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:23 (#2)

ἐγώ εἰμι ὁ ἐραυνῶν νεφροὺς καὶ καρδίας

“I am the one searching kidneys and hearts”

Here, **kidneys** represent people’s thoughts and **hearts** represent their emotions. Alternate translation: [I am able to determine exactly what each person is thinking and feeling]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:23 (#3)

ὑμῖν & ὑμῶν

“of you & your”

The word **you** is plural in these instances. Jesus is speaking more directly to the believers in Thyatira in order to warn them that he is going to judge them imminently. You may consider using the plural form of “you” here if that would be natural in your language.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Revelation 2:24 (#2)

τὰ βαθέα τοῦ Σατανᾶ, ὡς λέγουσιν

“the deep things of Satan, as they call them”

The people Jesus is quoting have been using the adjective **deep** as a noun to mean a certain kind of thing. The adjective is plural, and the ULT adds the word **things** to show this. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the things pertaining to Satan that they call deep]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:24 (#7)

ἄλλο βάρος

“another burden”

By **another burden**, Jesus means implicitly no burden other than the one he is about to mention. You can indicate this in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [any burden on you other than the following:]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 2:24 (#5)

οὐ βάλλω ἐφ’ ὑμᾶς ἄλλο βάρος

“I do not put another burden on you”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this as a positive statement. Alternate translation: [I put only this one burden on you]

See: Double Negatives

Revelation 2:24 (#1)

ὑμῖν & ὑμᾶς

“to you & you”

The word **you** is plural in these instances. Jesus is speaking more directly to the faithful believers in Thyatira in order to encourage them. You may consider using the plural form of “you” here if that would be natural in your language.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Revelation 2:24 (#4)

οὐ βάλλω ἐφ’ ὑμᾶς ἄλλο βάρος

“I do not put another burden on you”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [that I do not put another burden on you]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Revelation 2:24 (#6)

οὐ βάλλω ἐφ’ ὑμᾶς ἄλλο βάρος

“I do not put another burden on you”

Jesus is speaking as if he might literally put a **burden** on the believers in Thyatira. He is referring to something he might require of them. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I do not require anything else of you]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:24 (#3)

ὡς λέγουσιν

“as they call them”

The pronoun **they** is an indefinite pronoun that does not have a specific referent in the immediate context. Jesus is using this indefinite construction to focus on what is being said rather than on who is saying it. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this with a different expression that does not use an indefinite pronoun. Alternate translation: [as the people who do hold this teaching call them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 2:25 (#2)

ὃ ἔχετε, κρατήσατε

“hold what you have”

By **what you have**, Jesus means implicitly the good things that the faithful believers in Thyatira have been doing. (See the discussion of the phrase "you have" in the introduction to this chapter.) Alternate translation: [continue to do the good things that you are doing]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 2:25 (#1)

πλὴν ὃ ἔχετε, κρατήσατε ἄχρι οὗ ἂν ἥξω

"only hold what you have until I come"

If you translated the beginning of this quotation in the previous verse as an indirect quotation so that there would not be a quotation within a quotation, you can also translate the end of the quotation here as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [except to hold on to what you have until I come]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Revelation 2:25 (#4)

ἔχετε, κρατήσατε

"hold & you have"

Jesus is continuing to use the plural form of **you** as he speaks to the faithful believers in Thyatira in order to encourage them. You may consider using the plural form of "you" here if that would be natural in your language.

See: Forms of 'You' — Singular

Revelation 2:25 (#3)

ὃ ἔχετε, κρατήσατε

"hold what you have"

Jesus is speaking as if he wants the believers in Pergamum literally to **hold** on to the good things that they have been doing. He means that he wants the believers to continue doing these things. Alternate translation: [continue to do the good things that you have been doing]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:26 (#2)

ὁ νικῶν καὶ ὁ τηρῶν

"the one conquering and the one keeping"

Jesus is not referring to a specific person who is **conquering** in this way. He means any person who conquers in this way. Express this in the way that would be most natural in your language. Alternate translation: [anyone conquering by keeping]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Revelation 2:26 (#4)

ὁ τηρῶν & τὰ ἔργα μου

"the one keeping my works"

The possessive form **my works** describes not what Jesus does but what Jesus commands believers to do. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one doing the works that I command]

See: Possession

Revelation 2:26 (#1)

ὁ νικῶν καὶ ὁ τηρῶν

"the one conquering and the one keeping"

Here Jesus is expressing a single idea by using two phrases connected with **and**. The phrase **the one keeping** tells how **the one conquering** is able to conquer. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an phrase that does not use "and." Alternate translation: [the one conquering by keeping]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 2:26 (#3)

ὁ τηρῶν & τὰ ἔργα μου

"the one keeping my works"

See the discussion in the General Introduction to Revelation of the word "keep." If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning of this expression plainly. Alternate translation: [the one obediently doing what I command]

See: Idiom

Revelation 2:27 (#4)

ὡς τὰ σκεύη τὰ κεραμικὰ συντρίβεται

"as clay jars are shattered"

The point of this comparison is that the one conquering will defeat his enemies as easily as **clay jars are shattered**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [defeating his enemies as easily as clay jars are shattered]

See: Simile

Revelation 2:27 (#5)

ὡς τὰ σκεύη τὰ κεραμικὰ συντρίβεται

"as clay jars are shattered"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [as one shatters clay jars]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 2:27 (#1)

καὶ ποιμανεῖ αὐτοὺς ἐν ῥάβδῳ σιδηρᾷ, ὡς τὰ σκεύη τὰ κεραμικὰ συντρίβεται

"And he will rule them with an iron sceptre, as clay jars are shattered"

This verse is a quotation of Psalm 2:9. You may wish to indicate this in your translation by putting the words of this verse within quotation marks or by using some other punctuation or convention that your language uses to indicate a quotation.

See: Quote Markings

Revelation 2:27 (#3)

ἐν ῥάβδῳ σιδηρᾷ

"with an iron sceptre"

Jesus is speaking as if the one conquering will literally use **an iron scepter** to **rule** the nations. He means that he will rule with great strength, by association with the way that **iron** is very strong. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. However, since Jesus is quoting this image from Psalm 2, and since the image recurs in 12:5 and 19:15, you may wish to retain the image in your translation. Alternate translation: [with great strength]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:27 (#2)

ποιμανεῖ αὐτοὺς

"he will rule them"

The pronoun **he** refers to "the one conquering" and the pronoun **them** refers "the nations" in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the one conquering will rule the nations]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 2:28 (#3)

τὸν ἀστέρα τὸν πρωϊνόν

"the morning star"

Jesus is speaking as if he will literally give the faithful believers in Thyatira **the morning star**. This could mean: (1) confident hope about the future, just as the appearance of the morning star (that is, the planet Venus) shows that a new day is about to begin. (2) a deep and meaningful relationship with Jesus, who says in 22:16, "I am ... the bright morning star." You could say either of these things in your translation. The UST models one way to express the first possibility. However, since this image recurs later in the book, you may wish to retain it here by translating the phrase **the morning star** directly.

See: Metaphor

Revelation 2:28 (#2)

τοῦ πατρός μου

"my Father"

Father is an important title that describes the relationship between God and Jesus. Be sure to retain this title in your translation.

See: Translating Son and Father

Revelation 2:28 (#1)

ὡς κἀγὼ εἴληφα

"as I also have received"

Jesus is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [as I also have received authority]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation - Chapter 3 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

- The Letter to Sardis (3:1–6)
- The Letter to Philadelphia (3:7–13)
- The Letter to Laodicea (3:14–22)

You may wish to set each letter apart so that your readers can easily see that these are separate letters. You could, for example, put a blank line between these letters in your translation.

Some translations set each line of poetry farther to the right than the rest of the text to make it easier to read. The ULT does this with verse 7.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

"The angel of the church"
See the discussion of this concept in the introduction to chapter 2.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

See the discussion in the introduction to chapter 2 of the translation issues in the letters to the seven churches.

Revelation 3:1 (#1)

ὄνομα ἔχεις ὅτι ζῇς

"you have a name that you are alive"

Here, **name** represents the reputation of a person or group. Alternate translation: [you have a reputation for being alive]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 3:1 (#2)

ὅτι ζῇς, καὶ νεκρὸς εἶ

"that you are alive, but you are dead"

When Jesus says that the believers in Sardis have a reputation for being **alive**, he does not mean literally alive, but spiritually vibrant, that is, obeying and honoring God and experiencing God's presence and power. Similarly, when Jesus speaks as if the believers in Sardis were literally **dead**, he means that they are not spiritually vibrant. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for being spiritually vibrant, but actually you are not]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:2 (#4)

ἐνώπιον τοῦ Θεοῦ μου

"before my God"

Here the expression **before my God** means "in front of my God," that is, "where my God can see them." Sight, in turn, represents attention, perspective, and judgment. Alternate translation: [from my God's perspective]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:2 (#2)

στήρισον τὰ λοιπὰ, ἃ ἔμελλον ἀποθανεῖν

"strengthen the remainder that is about to die"

When Jesus says that there are some remaining things in Sardis that are **about to die**, as in the previous verse, he is speaking of the absence of spiritual vibrancy as if it were literally death. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [strengthen the few things about you that are still spiritually vibrant]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:2 (#3)

οὐ γὰρ εὕρηκά σου τὰ ἔργα, πεπληρωμένα

"for I have not found your works completed"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I have not found that you have completed your works]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 3:2 (#1)

γίνου γρηγορῶν

"Becoming waking"

Jesus is speaking as if the believers in Sardis were asleep and needed to wake up. He means that they are complacent and need to become concerned about their spiritual state. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Become concerned about your spiritual state]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:3 (#1)

πῶς εἴληφας καὶ ἤκουσας

"how you have received and heard"

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two words connected with **and**. The word **heard** tells by what means the believers in Sardis learned the things about Jesus that they **received** (that is, believed). If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase that does not use "and." Alternate translation: [how you received the things that you heard]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 3:3 (#2)

πῶς εἴληφας καὶ ἤκουσας

"how you have received and heard"

Jesus means implicitly the things that the believers in Sardis **heard** and **received** (believed) about him. You can indicate this in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [how you believed the teaching about me when you heard it]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 3:3 (#4)

ἐὰν & μὴ γρηγορήσῃς

"if you should not be awake"

As in the previous verse, Jesus is speaking as if the believers in Sardis were asleep and needed to wake up. Once again he means that they are complacent and need to become concerned about their spiritual state. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [if you do not become concerned about your spiritual state]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:3 (#3)

τήρει καὶ μετανόησον

"be keeping and repent"

The believers in Sardis first need to **repent** before they can be **keeping** (that is, obeying) the things that they **received** when they first **heard** about Jesus, so it might be more natural to put the word "repent" before the word "keeping." Alternate translation: [repent and be obedient]

See: Information Structure

Revelation 3:3 (#5)

ἥξω ὡς κλέπτης

"I will come like a thief"

The point of this comparison is that just as a thief comes unexpectedly, so Jesus will come unexpectedly. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I will come unexpectedly like a thief]

See: Simile

Revelation 3:4 (#2)

ὀνόματα

"names"

Here, **names** represent people by association with the way that each person has a name. Alternate translation: [people]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 3:4 (#7)

ἐν λευκοῖς

"in white"

Jesus may mean that faithful and obedient believers actually will wear **white** clothing when they live with him as their everlasting reward, since this is depicted several times in the course of the book. If so, wearing this white clothing would be a symbolic action indicating the purity of their lives and their devotion to Jesus. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [in white clothing that is symbolic of their purity]

See: Symbolic Action

Revelation 3:4 (#5)

περιπατήσουσιν μετ' ἐμοῦ

"they will walk with me"

In this context, the word **walk** refers to how people live and behave. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they will live in relationship with me]

See: Idiom

Revelation 3:4 (#4)

οὐκ ἐμόλυναν τὰ ἱμάτια αὐτῶν

"have not stained their clothes"

Jesus is speaking as if the disobedient believers in Sardis had literally **stained their clothes** while the obedient ones had not. He means that the obedient believers have not compromised their character by sinning. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. However, since Jesus continues the clothing image in the next phrase, you may wish to retain it here by translating the phrase **stained their clothes** directly. Alternate translation: [have not compromised their character by sinning]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:4 (#6)

ἐν λευκοῖς

“in white”

Jesus is using the adjective **white** as a noun to mean a certain kind of clothing. He specifies in the next verse that he means “white garments.” Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [in white garments]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 3:4 (#3)

οὐκ ἐμόλυναν τὰ ἱμάτια αὐτῶν

“have not stained their clothes”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this double negative that consists of the negative particle **not** and the negative verb **stained**. Alternate translation: [have kept their clothes clean]

See: Double Negatives

Revelation 3:4 (#1)

ἀλλὰ ἔχεις

“But you have”

See the discussion of the phrase “you have” in the introduction to chapter 2. Alternate translation: [But this is to your credit, that there are]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:5 (#6)

τῶν ἀγγέλων αὐτοῦ

“his angels”

See how you translated **angel** in 1:20.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 3:5 (#4)

ἐνώπιον τοῦ Πατρός μου, καὶ ἐνώπιον τῶν ἀγγέλων αὐτοῦ

“before my Father and before his angels”

Here the word **before** means “in front of” or “in the presence of” another person. Alternate translation: [in the presence of my Father and in the presence of his angels]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:5 (#2)

οὐ μὴ ἐξαλείψω τὸ ὄνομα αὐτοῦ

“I will certainly not wipe out his name”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this double negative that consists of the negative particle **not** and the negative verb **wipe out**. Alternate translation: [I will certainly keep his name in the Book of Life]

See: Double Negatives

Revelation 3:5 (#5)

τοῦ Πατρός

“Father”

Father is an important title that describes the relationship between God and Jesus. Be sure to retain this title in your translation.

See: Translating Son and Father

Revelation 3:5 (#1)

οὕτως περιβαλεῖται ἐν ἱματίοις λευκοῖς

“will be clothed thus in white garments”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [will wear white garments in this way]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 3:5 (#3)

ὁμολογήσω τὸ ὄνομα αὐτοῦ

“I will confess his name”

Here, **name** represents a person by association with the way that each person has a name. Alternate translation: [I will acknowledge him] or [I will acknowledge that he belongs to me]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 3:6 (#1)

ὁ ἔχων οὖς, ἀκουσάτω τί τὸ Πνεῦμα λέγει ταῖς ἐκκλησίαις

“Let the one having an ear hear what the Spirit is saying to the churches”

You can translate this statement in its three occurrences in this chapter the same way you translated it in its four occurrences in chapter 2.

See: Metonymy

Revelation 3:7 (#1)

ὁ Ἅγιος, ὁ Ἀληθινός

“The Holy One, the True One”

Jesus is using the adjectives **Holy** and **True** as nouns to describe himself as a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these words with equivalent phrases, as the ULT does by adding the word **One** in each case.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 3:7 (#3)

ὁ ἀνοίγων καὶ οὐδεὶς κλείσει, καὶ κλείων καὶ οὐδεὶς ἀνοίγει

“the one opening and no one will shut and shutting and no one opens”

This is a continuation of the quotation and the image of the key from Isaiah 22:22. These two phrases say the same thing in opposite ways. God, speaking through Isaiah, was using repetition to emphasize the idea that the phrases express, that he would give this new palace administrator authority that no one could defy. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine the phrases or express their meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who decides definitively whether to open a door or to lock it shut] or [whose authority no one can defy]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 3:7 (#2)

ὁ ἔχων τὴν κλεῖν Δαυείδ

“the one having the key of David”

Jesus is not referring to a literal **key**. Rather, he is quoting from Isaiah 22:22, where God says that he will make a man named Eliakim the administrator of the royal palace in Jerusalem and give him the “key of the house of David,” symbolizing authority over the kingdom that the dynasty of David rules. As the Messiah, Jesus now has David’s royal authority. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one having royal authority as the Messiah]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:8 (#3)

δέδωκα ἐνώπιόν σου θύραν ἠνεῳγμένην

“I have put before you an opened door”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I have opened a door before you]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 3:8 (#8)

οὐκ ἠρνήσω τὸ ὄνομά μου

“you have not denied my name”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this double negative that consists of the negative particle **not** and the negative verb **denied**. Alternate translation: [you have acknowledged me] or [you have acknowledged that you believe in me]

See: Double Negatives

Revelation 3:8 (#2)

δέδωκα ἐνώπιόν σου θύραν ἠνεῳγμένην

“I have put before you an opened door”

This **opened door** could symbolize: (1) an opportunity to proclaim the gospel or (2) entrance into everlasting life with Jesus. However, since the image of the **door** continues the image of the key from the previous verse, you may wish to retain the image by translating the phrase **I have put before you an opened door** directly.

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:8 (#6)

ἐτήρησάς μου τὸν λόγον

“you have kept my word”

Jesus is using the term **word** to mean the commandments he has given by using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have obeyed my commandments]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 3:8 (#1)

ἰδοὺ, δέδωκα ἐνώπιόν σου θύραν ἠνεῳγμένην, ἣν οὐδεὶς δύναται κλεῖσαι αὐτήν

“behold, I have put before you an opened door that no one is able to shut it”

In order to keep what Jesus says he knows about the believers in Philadelphia together with the phrase **I know your works**, you may wish to move this state-

ment to the end of the verse and make it a separate sentence.

See: Information Structure

Revelation 3:8 (#4)

δέδωκα ἐνώπιόν σου θύραν ἠνεῳγμένην

“I have put before you an opened door”

Here the word **before** means “in front of.” The implication is that the believers in Philadelphia can go through this door, since it is open right in front of them. Alternate translation: [I have opened a door in front of you that you can go through]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 3:8 (#5)

ἣν οὐδεὶς δύναται κλεῖσαι αὐτήν

“that no one is able to shut it”

It might seem that this expression contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you can shorten it. Alternate translation: [that no one is able to shut]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Revelation 3:8 (#7)

οὐκ ἠρνήσω τὸ ὄνομά μου

“you have not denied my name”

Here, **name** represents a person by association with the way that each person has a name. Alternate translation: [you have not denied me]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 3:9 (#5)

ἐνώπιον τῶν ποδῶν σου

“before your feet”

Jesus is using one part of the believers in Philadelphia, their **feet**, to mean their entire beings. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [before you] or [in front of you]

See: Synecdoche

Revelation 3:9 (#3)

καὶ οὐκ εἰσὶν, ἀλλὰ ψεύδονται

“but they are not, rather, they are lying”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:9. Alternate translation: [but who are not acting in the way that Jews should]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:9 (#4)

προσκυνήσουσιν ἐνώπιον τῶν ποδῶν σου

“bow down before your feet”

The enemies of the believers in Philadelphia would **come and bow down** at **their feet** as a symbolic action to show that they honored and respected these believers. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [to bow down before your feet as a gesture of honor and respect]

See: Symbolic Action

Revelation 3:9 (#1)

ἰδοὺ, διδῶ ἐκ τῆς συναγωγῆς τοῦ Σατανᾶ, τῶν λεγόντων ἑαυτοὺς Ἰουδαίους εἶναι, καὶ οὐκ εἰσὶν, ἀλλὰ ψεύδονται; ἰδοὺ, ποιήσω αὐτοὺς, ἵνα ἥξουσιν

“Behold, I will give {those} of the synagogue of Satan, the ones saying themselves to be Jews, but they are not, rather, they are lying, behold, I will make them so that they will come”

It might seem that this sentence contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you can shorten it by saying **behold** just once and by saying only **I will make** and not also **I will give**. Alternate translation: [Behold, those of the synagogue of Satan, the ones saying themselves to be Jews, but they are not, rather, they are lying, I will make them so that they will come]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Revelation 3:9 (#2)

ἐκ τῆς συναγωγῆς τοῦ Σατανᾶ

“those} of the synagogue of Satan”

See how you translated the expression **synagogue of Satan** in 2:9. Alternate translation: [those whose gatherings really serve Satan’s purposes rather than God’s]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:9 (#6)

ἐγὼ ἠγάπησά σε

“I have loved you”

For emphasis, Jesus is stating the pronoun **I**, whose meaning is already present in the verb **have loved**. If your language can state implied pronouns explicitly for emphasis, you may want to use that construction here in your translation. Other languages may have other ways of expressing this emphasis. Alternate translation: [I have certainly loved you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 3:10 (#4)

ἐτήρησας & κἀγώ σε τηρήσω

“you have kept & I will also keep you”

See the discussion in the General Introduction to Revelation of the various ways in which the word **keep** is used in this book. Alternate translation: [you have obeyed ... I also will protect you]

See: Idiom

Revelation 3:10 (#2)

ἐτήρησας τὸν λόγον τῆς ὑπομονῆς μου

“you have kept my word of endurance”

Jesus is using this possessive form to describe a **word** or statement that commands **endurance**, not a statement characterized by endurance (that is, one that endures). Alternate translation: [you have obeyed my command to endure]

See: Possession

Revelation 3:10 (#5)

τῆς ὥρας τοῦ πειρασμοῦ

“the hour of testing”

Jesus is using the term **hour** to refer to a specific time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the time of testing]

See: Idiom

Revelation 3:10 (#3)

τὸν λόγον τῆς ὑπομονῆς μου

“my word of endurance”

If your language would not use an abstract noun for the idea of **steadfastness**, you could express it with the verb “to endure.” See how you translated this word in 1:9 and in 2:2. Alternate translation: [my admonition to suffer patiently]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 3:10 (#1)

ἐτήρησας τὸν λόγον τῆς ὑπομονῆς μου

“you have kept my word of endurance”

Jesus is using the term **word** to a command he has given by using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have kept my command of endurance]

See: Idiom

Revelation 3:10 (#6)

τοὺς κατοικοῦντας ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς

“the ones living on the earth”

See the discussion in the General Introduction to Revelation of how to translate this phrase. Alternate translation: [worldly people]

See: Idiom

Revelation 3:11 (#1)

ἔρχομαι ταχύ

“I am coming quickly”

The implication is that Jesus is **coming quickly** to judge people for whether or not they have remained faithful to him. You can indicate this in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I am coming quickly to judge]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 3:11 (#2)

κράτει ὃ ἔχεις

“Hold what you have”

Alternate translation: [Continue doing the things that are to your credit]

See: Idiom

Revelation 3:11 (#3)

ἵνα μηδεὶς λάβῃ τὸν στέφανόν σου

“so that no one may take your crown”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this double negative that consists of the negative particle **not** and the verb that is negative in this context, **take**. Alternate translation: [so that you will indeed have your crown]

See: Double Negatives

Revelation 3:11 (#4)

τὸν στέφανόν

"crown"

See how you translated **crown** in 2:10. Alternate translation: [your reward]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:12 (#1)

ποιήσω αὐτὸν στῦλον ἐν τῷ ναῷ τοῦ Θεοῦ μου

"I will make him a pillar in the temple of my God"

Jesus is speaking as if he would literally make a faithful and victorious believer a **pillar** in God's temple. This likely symbolizes that the believer will always be in God's temple, just as a pillar is a permanent fixture. (Indeed, Jesus says specifically that this believer will not leave the temple anymore.) If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will have him remain always in the temple of my God]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:12 (#2)

Ἰερουσαλήμ

"Jerusalem"

The word **Jerusalem** is the name of a city.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 3:14 (#1)

ὁ Ἀμήν

"The Amen"

See how you translated the word **Amen** in 1:5, and see the discussion in the General Introduction to Revelation of how to translate this word.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Revelation 3:14 (#2)

ὁ πιστὸς καὶ ἀληθινός

"faithful and true"

The terms **faithful** and **true** mean similar things. Jesus is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [entirely faithful]

See: Doublet

Revelation 3:14 (#3)

ἡ ἀρχὴ τῆς κτίσεως τοῦ Θεοῦ

"the beginning of the creation of God"

Jesus is most likely using this possessive form to describe himself as the one who began the creation of God, that is, the one through whom God created all things. Jesus is likely using this phrase to mean the same thing as he does when he describes himself as "the alpha" or "the first." Jesus is not saying that he was the first creature God created. Jesus is not a created being, he is the eternally begotten Son of God. Alternate translation: [the one through whom God created all things]

See: Possession

Revelation 3:15 (#1)

ψυχρὸς & οὔτε ζεστός & ψυχρὸς & ἢ ζεστός

"cold nor hot & cold or hot"

Jesus is speaking as if the believers in Laodicea were literally water that was a certain temperature. He is using the word **hot** to mean diligently obedient to God and the word **cold** to mean stubbornly resistant to God, so he means that the Laodiceans are complacent and indifferent. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [disobedient nor obedient ... disobedient or obedient]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:16 (#2)

μέλλω σε ἐμέσαι ἐκ τοῦ στόματός μου

"I am about to spew you out of my mouth"

In the context of this image, when Jesus that says he will **spew** or spit the Laodiceans out of his mouth, he means that he will reject them. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I am about to reject you as I would spit out lukewarm water]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:16 (#1)

χλιαρὸς & καὶ οὔτε ψυχρός, οὔτε ζεστὸς

"lukewarm and neither hot nor cold"

In this verse, Jesus continues to develop the image of water temperature that he introduced in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [complacent and neither obedient nor disobedient]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:17 (#4)

ὁ ταλαίπωρος, καὶ ἐλεεινὸς, καὶ πτωχὸς, καὶ τυφλὸς, καὶ γυμνός

“the miserable and pitiable and poor and blind and naked one”

The words **miserable**, **pitiable**, and **poor** mean similar things. Jesus is using these terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [extremely poor as well as blind and naked]

See: Doublet

Revelation 3:17 (#1)

ὅτι λέγεις & πλούσιός εἰμι, καὶ πεπλούτηκα, καὶ οὐδὲν χρείαν ἔχω

“For you say, ‘I am rich and have become wealthy and have no need”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [For you say that you are rich and have become wealthy and have no need]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Revelation 3:17 (#3)

ὁ ταλαίπωρος, καὶ ἐλεεινὸς, καὶ πτωχὸς, καὶ τυφλὸς, καὶ γυμνός

“the miserable and pitiable and poor and blind and naked one”

Jesus is speaking as if the Laodiceans were literally **miserable**, **pitiable**, **poor**, **blind** and **naked**. He means that this is what they are like spiritually. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [spiritually very needy and unhealthy]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:17 (#2)

ὁ ταλαίπωρος, καὶ ἐλεεινὸς, καὶ πτωχὸς, καὶ τυφλὸς, καὶ γυμνός

“the miserable and pitiable and poor and blind and naked one”

Jesus is using the adjectives **miserable**, **pitiable**, **poor**, **blind** and **naked** as nouns to describe a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. Other languages may have other ways of showing this meaning, such as the ULT does by adding the word **one**. Alternate translation: [a person who is miserable, pitiable, poor, blind, and naked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 3:18 (#1)

ἀγοράσαι παρ’ ἐμοῦ χρυσίον πεπυρωμένον ἐκ πυρὸς, ἵνα πλουτήσῃς

“to buy from me gold refined by fire so that you might become rich”

Jesus is speaking as if he wants the believers in Laodicea literally to buy **gold** from him. He is using gold to symbolize spiritual riches, meaning things such as a profound knowledge of God and a life transformed into the image of Christ. When Jesus says that this gold is **refined by fire**, he means that it is pure gold, that is, genuine wealth; by contrast, the riches that the Laodiceans have are not true riches. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to seek genuine spiritual riches from me so that you will be truly wealthy]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:18 (#3)

ἱμάτια λευκὰ, ἵνα περιβάλῃ, καὶ μὴ φανερωθῇ ἡ αἰσχύνη τῆς γυμνότητός σου

“white garments so that you might clothe yourself and the shame of your nakedness might not be shown”

Jesus is speaking as if he wants the believers in Laodicea literally to buy **white garments** from him. As in 3:4, white clothing symbolizes purity of life and devotion to Jesus. Accordingly, **nakedness** symbolizes a sinful life and indifference towards Jesus. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to seek my help in being devoted to me so that you will live a pure life and not be shamefully disobedient]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:18 (#4)

μὴ φανερωθῇ

“might not be shown”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [might not appear]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 3:18 (#5)

κολλούριον ἐγχρῖσαι τοὺς ὀφθαλμούς σου, ἵνα βλέπῃς

“salve to anoint your eyes so that you might see”

Jesus is speaking as if he wants the believers in Laodicea literally to buy **salve** from him to **anoint** their **eyes**. He said in the previous verse that they were “blind,” and this likely symbolized their lack of spiritual discernment. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to seek my help in becoming spiritually discerning]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:18 (#2)

χρυσίον πεπυρωμένον ἐκ πυρὸς

“gold refined by fire”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [gold that fire has refined]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 3:19 (#3)

ζήλευε & καὶ μετανόησον

“be zealous and repent”

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two words connected with **and**. The verb **be zealous** tells how Jesus wants the Laodiceans to **repent**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase that does not use “and.” Alternate translation: [repent zealously]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 3:19 (#1)

ἐγὼ ὅσους ἐὰν φιλῶ, ἐλέγχω καὶ παιδεύω

“I, as many as I love, rebuke and discipline”

For emphasis, Jesus is stating the pronoun **I**, whose meaning is already present in the verbs **rebuke** and **discipline**. If your language can state implied pronouns explicitly for emphasis, you may want to use that construction here in your translation. Other languages may have other ways of expressing this emphasis. Alternate translation: [I certainly rebuke and discipline as many as I love]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 3:19 (#2)

ἐλέγχω καὶ παιδεύω

“rebuke and discipline”

The terms **rebuke** and **discipline** mean similar things. Jesus is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [diligently correct]

See: Doublet

Revelation 3:20 (#4)

δειπνήσω μετ’ αὐτοῦ, καὶ αὐτὸς μετ’ ἐμοῦ

“will eat with him, and he with me”

Jesus is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [I will eat with him and he will eat with me]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 3:20 (#5)

δειπνήσω μετ’ αὐτοῦ, καὶ αὐτὸς μετ’ ἐμοῦ

“will eat with him, and he with me”

Since people share table fellowship with others in their homes only if they have a close relationship, Jesus is using eating together to symbolize that he will become a good friend of the person who welcomes him. You can indicate this in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I will eat with him and he will eat with me, as good friends do]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:20 (#3)

τῆς φωνῆς μου

“my voice”

The word **voice** could mean: (1) by implication, that in addition to knocking on the door, Jesus is also calling out to the person inside the house. Alternate translation: [me calling as I knock]; (2) the sound of the knocking. Alternate translation: [the sound of me knocking]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 3:20 (#2)

κρούω

"knock"

To **knock** at a **door** means to hit it a few times to let a person inside the house know you are standing outside. You could translate this expression with the way people in your culture show that they have arrived at a house, such as "call out" or "cough" or "clap."

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 3:20 (#1)

ἕστηκα ἐπὶ τὴν θύραν καὶ κρούω; ἐάν τις ἀκούσῃ τῆς φωνῆς μου καὶ ἀνοίξῃ τὴν θύραν, καὶ εἰσελεύσομαι πρὸς αὐτὸν, καὶ δειπνήσω μετ' αὐτοῦ, καὶ αὐτὸς μετ' ἐμοῦ

"I stand at the door and knock. If anyone should hear my voice and open the door, I will indeed enter to him and & will eat with him, and he with me"

Jesus is speaking as if he were literally standing outside a **door** and seeking entrance to a house. He means that he is seeking to have personal fellowship with each of the Laodiceans to whom he is writing. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am seeking personal fellowship with each one of you. If anyone recognizes this and wants to have fellowship with me as well, I will certainly enter into a relationship with him of the most intimate kind]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:21 (#2)

τοῦ Πατρός

"Father"

Father is an important title that describes the relationship between God and Jesus. Be sure to retain this title in your translation.

See: Translating Son and Father

Revelation 3:21 (#1)

καθίσαι μετ' ἐμοῦ ἐν τῷ θρόνῳ μου

"to sit with me on my throne"

Jesus is speaking as if a victorious believer would literally **sit with** him on his **throne**. He means that the believer will share his ruling authority. He means the same thing when he says that he has **sat** with his **Father** on his **throne**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will share my ruling authority with him, as I also ... have come to share my Father's ruling authority]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 3:22 (#3)

τὸ Πνεῦμα

"the Spirit"

Here, **the Spirit** most likely refers to God's Spirit, or simply the Holy Spirit of God's triune nature, in contrast to the spirit of the writer or author which one finds in 1:10. In other words, the Holy Spirit addresses the messages and contents of each letter written to each of the seven churches which are addressed in chapters two and three (See: Revelation 2:7, 11, 17, and 29: 3:6, 13, 22). See the introductions for chapter 2 and for chapter 3 to read this same explanatory note.

See: Idiom

Revelation 3:22 (#1)

ὁ ἔχων οὖς, ἀκουσάτω

"Let the one having an ear hear"

See how you translated this phrase in 2:7.

See: Metonymy

Revelation 3:22 (#2)

ὁ ἔχων οὖς, ἀκουσάτω

"Let the one having an ear hear"

See how you translated this phrase in 2:7.

See: First, Second or Third Person

Revelation - Chapter 4 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

At this point in the book of Revelation, John has finished describing the letters to the churches. In this chapter he begins to describe a vision of heaven that God showed him.

Some translations set each line of poetry farther to the right than the rest of the text to make it easier to read. The ULT does this with verses 8 and 11.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Jasper, carnelian, and emerald

These words refer to special stones that the people in John's culture valued for their beauty. If the people in your culture do not consider stones to be valuable,

in your translation you can emphasize that it was the beauty of the stones that made such an impression on John.

Twenty-four elders
John does not explain who or what he means by "elders" when he describes seeing them in the vision he relates in this chapter. These 24 elders may be symbolic of the whole people of God through the ages. There were 12 tribes of Israel in the Old Testament Israel and 12 apostles of Jesus in the New Testament church. In chapter 21, John describes seeing the names of the 12 tribes of Israel on the gates of the New Jerusalem and the names of the 12 apostles on the foundations of that city. However, it is not necessary to offer an explanation in your translation of who these elders might be. If your language has a word for a distinguished older person who is a leader in the society, it would be appropriate to use it without any further explanation.

Giving glory to God
God's glory is the great beauty and radiant majesty that God has because he is God. Other Bible writers describe it as if it were a light so bright that no one can look at it. No one can give God this kind of glory, because it is already his. When people give glory to God or when God receives glory, people say that God has the glory that is his, that it is right for God to have that glory, and that people should worship God because he has that glory. In your translation, be sure that it is clear that when people "give glory" to God, they are not giving God something that he does not already have. Instead, people are acknowledging that God is already glorious. (See: glory, glorious, glorify; and prostrate, bow down, worship)

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Difficult images
Such things as bolts of lightning coming from the throne, lamps that are spirits, and a sea in front of the throne may be difficult to imagine. However, John is describing what he actually saw and heard in his visions, so you can translate his descriptions directly. See the discussion of this in the General Introduction to Revelation. (See: Symbolic Prophecy)

Revelation 4:1 (#3)

θύρα ἠνεῳγμένη ἐν τῷ οὐρανῷ

"a door opened in heaven"

John is speaking as if there were literally a **door** leading into heaven through which he could see. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I could see through an opening into heaven]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 4:1 (#4)

ὡς σάλπιγγος

"like a trumpet"

The point of this comparison is not that the sound of the **voice** was like the sound of a **trumpet** but that the voice was **loud** like a trumpet. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [that had been loud like the sound of a trumpet]

See: Simile

Revelation 4:1 (#1)

θύρα ἠνεῳγμένη ἐν τῷ οὐρανῷ, καὶ ἡ φωνὴ ἡ πρώτη

"a door opened in heaven and the first voice"

John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [I saw a door opened in heaven and I heard the first voice]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 4:1 (#2)

θύρα ἠνεῳγμένη ἐν τῷ οὐρανῷ

"a door opened in heaven"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [an open door in heaven]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 4:2 (#2)

ἐπὶ τὸν θρόνον καθήμενος

"on the throne one sitting"

John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [on the throne there was one sitting] or [someone was sitting on the throne]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 4:2 (#1)

ἐγενόμην ἐν Πνεύματι

"I was in the Spirit"

See how you translated this expression in 1:10. Alternate translation: [the Holy Spirit influenced me]

See: Idiom

Revelation 4:3 (#2)

λίθῳ, ἰάσπιδι καὶ σαρδίῳ & σμαραγδίνῳ

"to a jasper stone and to a carnelian & to an emerald"

The terms **jasper**, **carnelian**, and **emerald** describe gemstones. Jasper is often red, carnelian is often orange, and emerald is usually brilliant green. If your readers would not be familiar with these precious stones, in your translation you could use the name of comparable gems that they would recognize, or you could use general expressions. Alternate translation: [to a red or orange gemstone ... to a brilliant green gemstone]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 4:3 (#1)

ὅμοιος ὁράσει λίθῳ, ἰάσπιδι καὶ σαρδίῳ & ὅμοιος ὁράσει σμαραγδίνῳ

"was} like in appearance to a jasper stone and to a carnelian & like in appearance to an emerald"

The point of these comparisons is that the **one sitting** on the throne and the **rainbow** were dazzling in their **appearance**, like the gemstones John describes. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [was dazzling in appearance, like a jasper stone and a carnelian ... dazzling in appearance like an emerald]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 4:4 (#1)

περιβεβλημένους ἐν ἱματίοις λευκοῖς

"dressed in white garments"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [wearing white garments]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 4:5 (#2)

λαμπάδες πυρὸς

"lamps of fire"

This possessive form does not mean that the **lamps** were made **of fire** but that they burned with fire. Alternate translation: [flaming lamps]

See: Possession

Revelation 4:5 (#3)

τὰ ἑπτὰ πνεύματα

"the seven spirits"

See how you translated this expression in 1:4.

See: Symbolic Language

Revelation 4:5 (#1)

φωναὶ, καὶ βρονταί

"sounds and thunders"

The word translated **sounds** could mean: (1) noises, in which case **sounds and thunders** might be a phrase that expresses a single idea by using two words connected with **and**. The word **thunders** would tell what kind of noises these are. Alternate translation: [rumblings of thunder]; (2) voices. Alternate translation: [voices and thunders]

Revelation 4:6 (#2)

ἔμπροσθεν καὶ ὄπισθεν

"before and behind"

John is using two sides of the body, the front and the back (what is **before** and **behind** a being), to mean the whole body. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [over their whole bodies]

See: Merism

Revelation 4:6 (#1)

ὡς θάλασσα ὑαλίνη, ὁμοία κρυστάλλῳ

"was} as a glass sea, like crystal"

The point of these comparisons could be that the **sea** was (1) clear or (2) sparkling, like **glass** and **crystal**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [was a sea that was as clear as glass or crystal] or [was a sea that was sparkling like glass or crystal]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 4:8 (#1)

κυκλόθεν καὶ ἔσωθεν

“around and underneath”

John is using two sides of the body, the top and the bottom (what is **around** and **underneath** a being), to mean the whole body. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [over their whole bodies]

See: Merism

Revelation 4:8 (#2)

οὐκ ἔχουσιν ἡμέρας καὶ νυκτὸς λέγοντες

“do not have & night and day, saying”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this double negative that consists of the negative particle **not** and the verb **rest**, which in this context means to “stop.” Alternate translation: [saying continuously night and day]

See: Double Negatives

Revelation 4:8 (#3)

ἡμέρας καὶ νυκτὸς

“night and day”

The living creatures are using the two main components of time, **night** and **day**, to mean all the time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [at any time]

See: Merism

Revelation 4:9 (#3)

τὰ ζῷα

“the living creatures”

See how you translated **living creatures** in 4:6.

See: Symbolic Language

Revelation 4:9 (#1)

δώσουσιν & δόξαν, καὶ τιμὴν, καὶ εὐχαριστίαν, τῷ καθημένῳ

“will give glory and honor and thanks to the one sitting”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **glory**, **honor**, and **thanks**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [glorify and honor and thank the one sitting]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 4:9 (#2)

εἰς τοὺς αἰῶνας τῶν αἰώνων

“to the ages of the ages”

See how you translated the same expression in 1:18.

See: Idiom

Revelation 4:10 (#1)

πεσοῦνται

“will fall”

Be sure that it is clear in your translation that the elders do not fall down accidentally. They bow down in front of the throne as a gesture to honor God. Alternate translation: [will bow down respectfully]

See: Symbolic Action

Revelation 4:10 (#2)

βαλοῦσιν τοὺς στεφάνους αὐτῶν ἐνώπιον τοῦ θρόνου

“they will lay their crowns before the throne”

The elders respectfully place their **crowns** on the ground to show that they are submitting to God’s authority over them. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [they will lay their crowns on the ground in front of God’s throne to show that they are submitting to him]

See: Symbolic Action

Revelation 4:11 (#1)

ἄξιος εἶ, ὁ Κύριος καὶ ὁ Θεὸς ἡμῶν, λαβεῖν τὴν δόξαν καὶ τὴν τιμὴν καὶ τὴν δύναμιν

“Worthy are you, our Lord and God, to receive glory and honor and power”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the idea of **glory**, **honor**, and **power**, you could express the same ideas in another way. The UST models one way to do this.

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 4:11 (#3)

ἦσαν, καὶ ἐκτίσθησαν

“they existed and were created”

The expressions **existed** and **were created** mean similar things. The elders are using the two expressions together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [they came into being]

See: Doublet

Revelation 4:11 (#2)

σὺ ἔκτισας

"you have created"

For emphasis, the elders are stating the pronoun **you**, whose meaning is already present in the verb **have created**. If your language can state implied pronouns explicitly for emphasis, you may want to use that construction here in your translation. Other languages may have other ways of expressing this emphasis. Alternate translation: [it was you who created]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation - Chapter 5 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

In this chapter, John continues to describe a vision of heaven that God showed him.

Some translations set each line of poetry farther to the right than the rest of the text to make it easier to read. The ULT does this in verses 9–13.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Sealed scroll

Kings and important people in John's time wrote important documents on large pieces of paper or animal skin. They then rolled them up and sealed them with wax so they would stay closed. Only the person to whom the document was written had the authority to open it by breaking the seal. In this chapter, "the one who was seated on the throne" had written the scroll. Only the person called "the Lion of the tribe of Judah," "the Root of David" and "the Lamb" had the authority to open it. (See: scroll; and authority)

Twenty-four elders

The 24 elders whom John introduced in chapter 4 appear in this chapter as well. In your translation, you can use the same term for them here as you did there.

Revelation 5:1 (#2)

κατεσφραγισμένον σφραγῖσιν ἑπτά

"having been sealed with seven seals"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. Alternate translation: [God had sealed the scroll with seven seals]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 5:1 (#1)

γεγραμμένον ἔσωθεν καὶ ὄπισθεν

"written on the inside and on the back"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [with writing on the front and the back]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 5:2 (#1)

εἶδον

"I saw"

It may be more natural in your language to say "heard" rather than **saw** in this context. Alternate translation: [I heard]

Revelation 5:2 (#2)

ἀνοῖξαι τὸ βιβλίον, καὶ λῦσαι τὰς σφραγῖδας αὐτοῦ

"to open the scroll and to break its seals"

Since someone would need to break the **seals** in order to **open the scroll**, in your translation you may wish to relate these events in the order in which they would have to happen. Alternate translation: [to break the seals and open the scroll]

See: Order of Events

Revelation 5:3 (#1)

ἐν τῷ οὐρανῷ, οὐδὲ ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς, οὐδὲ ὑποκάτω τῆς γῆς

"in heaven or on the earth or under the earth"

John is using the main components of creation—**heaven**, **earth**, and the underworld—to mean all of creation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [anywhere in creation]

See: Merism

Revelation 5:3 (#2)

οὔτε βλέπειν αὐτό

"or to read it"

The word **or** introduces the purpose for which someone would **open the scroll**. Use a natural way in your language for introducing a purpose clause. Alternate translation: [in order to read it]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Revelation 5:4 (#3)

οὐδεὶς & εὑρέθη

"no one was found"

Here the expression **no one was found** could simply mean "there was no one." You could say that as an alternate translation.

See: Idiom

Revelation 5:4 (#2)

οὐδεὶς & εὑρέθη

"no one was found"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the angel did not find anyone]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 5:4 (#1)

ἔκλαιον πολὺ, ὅτι οὐδεὶς ἄξιος εὑρέθη ἀνοῖξαι τὸ βιβλίον, οὔτε βλέπειν αὐτό

"I was weeping much because no one was found worthy to open the scroll or to read it"

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [because no one was found worthy to open the scroll or to read it, I was weeping much]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Revelation 5:5 (#2)

ἡ ῥίζα Δαυείδ

"the Root of David"

This elder is also alluding to the prophecy in Isaiah 11:1 that speaks of the Messiah as if he were a "shoot" from the "stump of Jesse" (the father of King David), a "branch from his roots." In that prophecy Isaiah then refers to this "shoot" as the "root of Jesse" itself. The elder is speaking similarly here. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the Descendant of David] or [the Messiah descended from David]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 5:5 (#1)

ὁ λέων & ἐκ τῆς φυλῆς Ἰούδα

"the Lion from the tribe of Judah"

This elder is alluding to the prophecy in Genesis 49:8–10 in which Jacob says that a ruler for Israel will come from the **tribe of Judah** and in which Jacob compares that ruler to a strong **Lion**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the promised ruler from the tribe of Judah]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 5:5 (#3)

ἐνίκησεν & ἀνοῖξαι

"has conquered to open"

The words **has conquered** introduce the reason for the result that the words **to open** describe. Use a natural way in your language for introducing a result clause. Alternate translation: [has conquered so as to be worthy to open]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Revelation 5:6 (#1)

ὡς ἐσφαγμένον

"as having been"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. The meaning is that the Lamb, although he was alive, had marks or cuts that indicated that at one point others had killed him with violence. Alternate translation: [who had marks that showed that others had once killed him violently]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 5:6 (#2)

τοῦ Θεοῦ, ἀπεσταλμένοι

"of God sent"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way

that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [whom God has sent]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 5:7 (#1)

ἦλθεν

"he came"

The pronoun **he** refers to the Lamb, not to the elder who was speaking with John. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the Lamb came]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 5:8 (#4)

τῶν ἁγίων

"of the saints"

As the General Introduction to Revelation discusses, John often uses the term **saints** to describe people who believe in Jesus and obey him faithfully. John uses the term by association with the way these people are set apart as holy for God. Your language may have a term or expression of its own that would convey this meaning that you could use throughout the book. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [of the disciples of Jesus] or [of believers in Jesus]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 5:8 (#3)

αἵ εἰσιν αἱ προσευχαὶ τῶν ἁγίων

"which are the prayers of the saints"

When John says that these **golden bowls** are the **prayers of the saints**, he likely means by association that the incense in the bowls represents the prayers, since prayers ascend to God in heaven similarly to the way that incense rises through the air and pleasantly attracts attention. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate this by using a singular verb that would refer to the **incense** rather than a plural verb that would refer to the **bowls**. Alternate translation: [which is the prayers of the saints]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 5:8 (#2)

ἔχοντες ἕκαστος

"each one having"

It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. This could mean: (1) that each of the **elders** had a harp and golden bowls of incense. Alternate translation: [Each of the elders had]; (2) that each of the **living creatures** and **elders** had a harp and golden bowls of incense. Alternate translation: [Each of the living creatures and elders had]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 5:8 (#1)

ἔπεσαν ἐνώπιον

"fell before"

Be sure that it is clear in your translation that the living creatures and elders did not fall down accidentally. They bowed down in front of the Lamb as a gesture to honor him. Alternate translation: [bowed down respectfully to]

See: Symbolic Action

Revelation 5:9 (#2)

ἐν τῷ αἵματί σου

"with your blood"

This could mean: (1) the actual **blood** that Jesus offered as a sacrifice for sin. In that case, you could use the word for "blood" in your language with literal meaning and say "with your blood" as the ULT does. (2) the sacrificial death of Jesus, by association with the blood that Jesus shed when he died. Alternate translation: [through your sacrificial death]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 5:9 (#1)

ἐσφάγης, καὶ ἠγόρασας τῷ Θεῷ ἐν τῷ αἵματί σου

"you were slaughtered and with your blood you bought {people} for God"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [you allowed people to slaughter you so that with your blood you could buy people for God]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 5:9 (#3)

ἠγόρασας

"you bought {people"

The living creatures and elders are speaking as if the Lamb literally **bought** people for God. They mean that

through his sacrificial death, the Lamb saved them by setting them free from the guilt and power of sin. Your language may have a term that you can use in your translation that describes someone paying a price or making a sacrifice to set someone else free. Alternate translation: [you redeemed people]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 5:9 (#4)

ἐκ πάσης φυλῆς, καὶ γλώσσης, καὶ λαοῦ, καὶ ἔθνους

"from every tribe and language and people and nation"

The terms **tribe**, **language**, **people**, and **nation** mean similar things. John is using the four terms together to make a comprehensive statement. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [from every different people group]

See: Doublet

Revelation 5:10 (#2)

ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς

"on the earth"

John is using the term **earth** to mean by association the people who live on the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [over the people of the earth]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 5:10 (#1)

βασιλείαν καὶ ἱερεῖς

"a kingdom and priests"

See how you translated the similar phrase in 1:6.

Revelation 5:11 (#1)

μυριάδες μυριάδων καὶ χιλιάδες χιλιάδων

"myriads of myriads and thousands of thousands"

Since **myriads** are larger than **thousands** and John wants to convey what a great number of angels he saw and heard, it might be more natural to put the smaller number first and build up to the larger number. Alternate translation: [thousands of thousands and myriads of myriads]

See: Information Structure

Revelation 5:11 (#2)

μυριάδες μυριάδων καὶ χιλιάδες χιλιάδων

"myriads of myriads and thousands of thousands"

John may be using these multiples of large numbers to indicate implicitly that the number of angels was too great to count. You could indicate that in your translation if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [too great to count]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 5:11 (#3)

μυριάδες μυριάδων

"myriads of myriads"

A myriad is a hundred hundred or ten thousand. Your language may have its own term for this number. You could also use a general expression. Alternate translation: [tens of thousands of tens of thousands] or [hundreds of millions]

See: Numbers

Revelation 5:12 (#1)

τὸ ἐσφαγμένον

"having been slaughtered"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [who allowed others to slaughter him]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 5:12 (#2)

λαβεῖν τὴν δύναμιν, καὶ πλοῦτον, καὶ σοφίαν, καὶ ἰσχὺν, καὶ τιμὴν, καὶ δόξαν, καὶ εὐλογίαν

"to receive power and wealth and wisdom and strength and honor and glory and blessing"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **power**, **wealth**, **wisdom**, **strength**, **honor**, **glory**, and **praise**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. See how you translated the similar expression in 4:11.

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 5:13 (#3)

τῷ καθημένῳ ἐπὶ τῷ θρόνῳ καὶ τῷ Ἀρνίῳ ἡ εὐλογία, καὶ ἡ τιμὴ, καὶ ἡ δόξα, καὶ τὸ κράτος

"To the one sitting on the throne and to the Lamb {be} praise and honor and glory and power"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the idea of **praise**, **honor**, **glory**, and **power**, you could express the same ideas in another way. See how you translated the similar expressions in 4:11 and 5:12.

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 5:13 (#4)

εἰς τοὺς αἰῶνας τῶν αἰώνων

"to the ages of the ages"

See how you translated the same expression in 1:18. Alternate translation: [forever]

See: Idiom

Revelation 5:13 (#1)

πᾶν κτίσμα ὃ ἐν τῷ οὐρανῷ, καὶ ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς, καὶ ὑποκάτω τῆς γῆς, καὶ ἐπὶ τῆς θαλάσσης, καὶ τὰ ἐν αὐτοῖς πάντα

"every creature in heaven and on earth and under the earth and on the sea and everything in them"

The phrase **everything in them** means basically the same thing as the phrase **every creature in heaven and on earth and under the earth and on the sea**. The second phrase emphasizes the meaning of the first phrase by repeating the same idea with different words. John is describing his vision in a way reminiscent of Hebrew poetry, which was based on this kind of repetition. It would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if the repetition might be confusing, you could connect the phrases with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [every creature in heaven and on earth and under the earth and on the sea, yes, everything in them]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 5:13 (#2)

ὃ ἐν τῷ οὐρανῷ, καὶ ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς, καὶ ὑποκάτω τῆς γῆς

"in heaven and on earth and under the earth"

John is using the main components of creation—**heaven**, **earth**, the underworld, and the **sea**—to mean all of creation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. See how you translated the similar expression in 5:3. Alternate translation: [everywhere in creation]

See: Merism

Revelation 5:14 (#2)

ἀμήν

"Amen"

See how you translated **Amen** in 1:6.

See: Symbolic Language

Revelation 5:14 (#3)

ἔπεσαν

"fell down"

Alternate translation: [bowed down respectfully]

See: Symbolic Action

Revelation 5:14 (#1)

οἱ πρεσβύτεροι ἔπεσαν καὶ προσεκύνησαν

"the elders fell down and worshiped"

Some ancient manuscripts read **the elders fell down and worshiped**. ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts add "the one who lives to the ages of the ages." If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it has. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Revelation - Chapter 6 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter describes what John saw happen when the Lamb opened each of the first six seals on the scroll that God gave him. (The Lamb does not open the seventh seal until chapter 8.)

- The first seal (6:1–2)
- The second seal (6:3–4)
- The third seal (6:5–6)
- The fourth seal (6:7–8)
- The fifth seal (6:9–11)
- The sixth seal (6:12–16)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Seven seals

See the discussion in the introduction to chapter 5 of the seals that kept important documents secure in this culture.

Four horsemen
As the Lamb opens each of the first four seals, John describes seeing horsemen riding differently colored horses. The colors of the horses may symbolize how each rider will affect the earth. However, it is not necessary to suggest the meaning of these colors in your translation. (See: Symbolic Prophecy)

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Ordinal numbers
John uses the ordinal numbers "second" through "sixth" in verses 3, 5, 7, 9, and 12. If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you can use cardinal numbers or equivalent expressions in your translation. (See: Ordinal Numbers)

Similes
In verses 12–14, John makes several comparisons in order to describe the images he saw in his vision. He compares these images to everyday things. Notes to these verses suggest ways you might indicate the points of these comparisons in your translation. (See: Simile)

Revelation 6:1 (#1)

ὡς φωνῇ βροντῆς

"as with a voice of thunder"

The point of this comparison is that just as **thunder** is loud, so the **voice** of this living creature was loud. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [in a voice that was as loud as thunder]

See: Simile

Revelation 6:2 (#2)

ἐξῆλθεν νικῶν, καὶ ἵνα νικήσῃ

"he went out conquering and that he might conquer"

John may mean that the rider on the white horse went out "as a conquering one," that is, with all the capacity of a conqueror. In that case, for emphasis he would be using a construction in which a subject and its verb come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of showing the emphasis. Alternate translation: [he went out as a conqueror who was going to conquer]

See: Poetry

Revelation 6:2 (#1)

ἐδόθη αὐτῷ στέφανος

"a crown was given to him"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [he received a crown] or [God gave him a crown]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 6:3 (#1)

ἤνοιξεν

"he opened"

The pronoun **he** refers to the Lamb. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers, here and in verses 5, 7, 9, and 12. Alternate translation: [the Lamb opened]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 6:3 (#2)

τὴν σφραγῖδα τὴν δευτέραν & τοῦ δευτέρου ζῴου

"the second seal & the second living creature"

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, if your language does not use ordinal numbers, you can use cardinal numbers or equivalent expressions in these instances. Alternate translation: [seal number two … living creature number two]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 6:4 (#3)

λαβεῖν τὴν εἰρήνην ἐκ τῆς γῆς

"to take peace from the earth"

John is using the term **earth** to mean by association the people who live on the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to keep the people living on the earth from being peaceful]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 6:4 (#2)

λαβεῖν τὴν εἰρήνην ἐκ τῆς γῆς

"to take peace from the earth"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to keep the earth from being peaceful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 6:4 (#4)

σφάξουσιν

"they will slaughter"

The pronoun **they** refers generally to the people living on the earth. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [people will slaughter]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 6:4 (#5)

ἐδόθη αὐτῷ μάχαιρα μεγάλη

"a great sword was given to him"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God gave him a great sword]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 6:4 (#1)

τῷ καθημένῳ ἐπ' αὐτὸν, ἐδόθη αὐτῷ

"to the one sitting on it, it was granted to him"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God allowed the one sitting on it]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 6:5 (#1)

ζυγὸν

"a balance"

The word **balance** describes an instrument for determining the weight of an object or comparing the weight of two objects. It consists of a central post with a crossbar from which two pans are hung. An object may be placed in one pan and known weights placed in the other pan until the crossbar remains level, meaning that both pans contain an equal weight. Or one object may be placed in one pan and a different object in the other pan; the pan that hangs lower contains the heavier object. Since John is describing what he saw, it would be appropriate to use the name or a description of the ancient tool rather than use the name of a modern device for weighing things. Alternate translation: [a balancing scale] or [a weighing instrument]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 6:6 (#4)

δηναρίου & δηναρίου

"for a denarius & for a denarius"

The **denarius** was a silver coin that was worth a day's wages for a laborer. You could try to express this amount in terms of current monetary values, but that might cause your Bible translation to become outdated and inaccurate, since those values can change over time. So instead you could use a general expression or give the equivalent in wages. Alternate translation, in each instance: [for one silver coin] or [for the pay for one day of work]

See: Biblical Money

Revelation 6:6 (#3)

χοῖνιξ σίτου & τρεῖς χοίνικες κριθῶν

"A choenix of wheat & three choenices of barley"

A **choenix** was a measure equivalent to about one liter or one quart. The plural of choenix is **choenices**. Alternate translation: [one liter of wheat ... three liters of barley] or [one quart of wheat ... three quarts of barley]

See: Biblical Volume

Revelation 6:6 (#1)

λέγουσαν

"saying"

This **voice** is giving instructions to the rider on the black horse. You could indicate that in your translation if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [saying to the rider on the black horse]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 6:6 (#5)

μὴ ἀδικήσῃς

"do not harm"

If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this double negative that consists of the negative particle **not** and the negative verb **harm**. Alternate translation: [be careful to preserve]

See: Double Negatives

Revelation 6:6 (#2)

χοῖνιξ σίτου δηναρίου, καὶ τρεῖς χοίνικες κριθῶν δηναρίου

“A choenix of wheat for a denarius and three choenices of barley for a denarius”

The implication is that there would be famine, so that **wheat** and **barley**, the staple crops in this culture, would become scarce and very expensive. (The balance that John describes the third rider holding in the previous verse may symbolize weighing grain for sale.) You could indicate this in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Create famine that will cause grain to become so scarce that a choenix of wheat will cost a denarius and three choenices of barley will cost a denarius]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 6:7 (#1)

ἤκουσα φωνὴν τοῦ τετάρτου ζῴου λέγοντος

“I heard the voice of the fourth living creature saying”

John is using one part of the **fourth living creature**, its **voice**, to mean all of it in the act of speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I heard the fourth living creature saying]

See: Synecdoche

Revelation 6:8 (#5)

ῥομφαίᾳ

“the sword”

John is using the term **sword** to mean warfare by association with the way the people of his time used swords as weapons in warfare. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [warfare]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 6:8 (#2)

ἐδόθη αὐτοῖς ἐξουσία

“authority was given to them”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God gave authority to them]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 6:8 (#6)

θανάτῳ

“death”

John is likely using the general term **death** to mean one specific cause of death, disease. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [disease]

See: Synecdoche

Revelation 6:8 (#4)

τὸ τέταρτον τῆς γῆς

“one fourth of the earth”

Here, **one fourth** means one part out of four equal parts. Alternate translation: [one out of every four people on the earth]

See: Fractions

Revelation 6:8 (#1)

ὁ Ἅιδης

“Hades”

See how you translated the term **Hades** in 1:18.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Revelation 6:8 (#3)

τὸ τέταρτον τῆς γῆς

“one fourth of the earth”

Here, **the earth** represents the people of the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [one fourth of the people on the earth]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 6:9 (#1)

τοῦ θυσιαστηρίου

“the altar”

John mentions an **altar** here without having described it previously while relating what he saw in this vision. He seems to mean a golden altar that was in front of God’s throne, as he later describes in 8:3 and 9:13. You could indicate that in your translation if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [a golden altar that was in front of God’s throne]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 6:9 (#4)

διὰ τὸν λόγον τοῦ Θεοῦ

“because of the word of God”

John is using the term **word** to mean the message that God communicated to believers by using words and that God wants believers to share by using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because they shared the message from God]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 6:9 (#3)

διὰ τὸν λόγον τοῦ Θεοῦ, καὶ διὰ τὴν μαρτυρίαν ἣν εἶχον

"because of the word of God and because of the testimony that they were having"

These two phrases mean similar things. John is using repetition to emphasize the idea that the phrases express. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them. Alternate translation: [because they testified to the word of God]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 6:9 (#2)

τῶν ἐσφαγμένων

"of the ones having been slaughtered"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the ones whom people had slaughtered]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 6:9 (#5)

διὰ τὴν μαρτυρίαν ἣν εἶχον

"because of the testimony that they were having"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **testimony**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because they testified about Jesus]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 6:10 (#3)

ἐκδικεῖς τὸ αἷμα ἡμῶν, ἐκ τῶν κατοικούντων ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς

"avenge our blood from the ones living on the earth"

The souls are using the term **blood** by association to mean their deaths. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [punish the ones living on the earth to avenge our deaths]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 6:10 (#1)

ἕως πότε ὁ Δεσπότης ὁ ἅγιος καὶ ἀληθινός, οὐ κρίνεις καὶ ἐκδικεῖς τὸ αἷμα ἡμῶν, ἐκ τῶν κατοικούντων ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς

"Until when, holy and true Ruler, do you not judge and avenge our blood from the ones living on the earth"

The souls are using the question form for emphasis. If you would not use the question form for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Holy and true Ruler, we want you to judge and avenge our blood from the ones living on the earth without any further delay!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Revelation 6:10 (#4)

τῶν κατοικούντων ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς

"the ones living on the earth"

The souls are implicitly saying that they want God to judge and punish the **ones living on the earth** who killed them. See how you translated this expression in 3:10. Alternate translation: [the worldly people who killed us]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 6:10 (#2)

οὐ κρίνεις καὶ ἐκδικεῖς τὸ αἷμα ἡμῶν, ἐκ τῶν κατοικούντων ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς

"do you not judge and avenge our blood from the ones living on the earth"

Since the souls actually want God to **judge** the **ones living on the earth** and **avenge** their **blood**, it may be more natural to present the phrases in that order. Alternate translation: [do you not judge the ones living on the earth and avenge our blood from them]

See: Information Structure

Revelation 6:11 (#5)

οἱ ἀδελφοὶ

"brothers"

Although the term **brothers** is masculine, here the word has a generic sense that includes both men and

women. If you wish to retain the expression in your translation, you could word it in a way that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [brothers and sisters]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Revelation 6:11 (#1)

ἐδόθη αὐτοῖς ἑκάστῳ στολὴ λευκή, καὶ ἐρρέθη αὐτοῖς

"a white robe was given to each of them, and it was said to them"

If your language does not use these passive forms, you could express the ideas in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God gave each of them a white robe and told them]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 6:11 (#4)

οἱ ἀδελφοὶ

"brothers"

Here the term **brothers** describes people who share the same faith. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [fellow believers]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 6:11 (#2)

πληρωθῶσιν καὶ

"should be completed both"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [people had killed all of]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 6:11 (#3)

καὶ οἱ σύνδουλοι αὐτῶν, καὶ οἱ ἀδελφοὶ αὐτῶν

"both their fellow servants and their brothers"

The terms **fellow servants** and **brothers** mean similar things. The two terms are being used together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [all of those who believed in Jesus as they did]

See: Doublet

Revelation 6:12 (#3)

ἡ σελήνη ὅλη ἐγένετο ὡς αἷμα

"the full moon became like blood"

The point of this comparison is that just as **blood** is red, the **full moon** turned read. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [the full moon became red like blood]

See: Simile

Revelation 6:12 (#1)

σεισμὸς μέγας

"a great earthquake"

An **earthquake** is a natural disaster in which the ground shakes, often destroying buildings, bridges, and other structures. Your language and culture may have a term for an **earthquake** that you can use in your translation. You could also use a general expression. Alternate translation: [a great shaking of the ground]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 6:12 (#2)

ὡς σάκκος τρίχινος

"like sackcloth {made} of hair"

The word **sackcloth** describes clothing for mourning that in this culture was woven from black goat hair. In this culture, the color black was associated with death. Alternate translation: [like mourning clothing] or [like the feathers of a raven]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 6:13 (#5)

τοὺς ὀλύνθους

"unseasonable fruit"

The term **unripe** describes **fruit** that normally remains on a tree and ripens later. Alternate translation: [later-ripening fruit]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 6:13 (#2)

ἔπεσαν

"fell"

The point of this comparison is that just as all the **fruit** on a **fig tree** might fall at once if a **great wind** shook

the tree, so John saw all of the **stars** fall at once. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [all fell at once]

See: Simile

Revelation 6:13 (#4)

ὡς συκῆ βάλλει τοὺς ὀλύνθους αὐτῆς

"as a fig tree drops its unseasonable fruit"

If your readers would not be familiar with a **fig tree**, you could use the name of a fruit tree that they would recognize or you could use a general expression. Alternate translation: [as a fruit tree drops its late-ripening fruit]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 6:13 (#3)

ὑπὸ ἀνέμου μεγάλου σειομένη

"being shaken by a great wind"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation, with no comma preceding: [when a great wind shakes it]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 6:13 (#1)

οἱ ἀστέρες τοῦ οὐρανοῦ

"the stars of the sky"

It might seem that the expression **the stars of the sky** contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you can shorten it. Alternate translation: [the stars]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Revelation 6:14 (#1)

ὁ οὐρανὸς ἀπεχωρίσθη ὡς βιβλίον ἑλισσόμενον

"the sky was split like a scroll being rolled up"

If your language does not use these passive forms, you could express the ideas in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the sky rolled up as a scroll does when it splits]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 6:14 (#3)

ἐκ τῶν τόπων αὐτῶν ἐκινήθησαν

"were removed from their places"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [moved from their places]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 6:14 (#2)

ὁ οὐρανὸς ἀπεχωρίσθη ὡς βιβλίον ἑλισσόμενον

"the sky was split like a scroll being rolled up"

The point of this comparison is that the sky went away, just as a scroll would roll away to the two sides of a surface if it split while someone had it spread out on that surface. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [the sky rolled away and disappeared, just as a scroll rolls up in two pieces if it splits]

See: Simile

Revelation 6:14 (#4)

ἐκ τῶν τόπων αὐτῶν ἐκινήθησαν

"were removed from their places"

The implication is that the **mountains** and **islands** disappeared when they **were removed from their places**. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [moved from their places and disappeared]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 6:15 (#2)

οἱ πλούσιοι, καὶ οἱ ἰσχυροὶ

"the rich and the powerful"

John is using the adjectives **rich** and **powerful** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these words with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [rich people and powerful people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 6:15 (#3)

καὶ πᾶς δοῦλος καὶ ἐλεύθερος

"and every slave and free {person"

John may not be mentioning people who were **slave** and **free** in addition to all of the preceding people on this list. Instead, he may be using the two main civil statuses in his culture, **slave** and **free**, to mean all people. So this would be a summary of everyone on the list. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this in plain language. Alternate translation, preceded by a comma: [indeed, all people, regardless of their status,]

See: Merism

Revelation 6:15 (#1)

χιλίαρχοι

"chiliarchs"

The word **chiliarchs** describes officers in the Roman army who were in charge of groups of 1,000 soldiers. If your readers would not recognize this term, in your translation you could use a general expression. Alternate translation: [military officers]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 6:16 (#2)

προσώπου

"the face"

The people are using the word **face** to mean by association the area in front of **the one sitting on the throne** where he can see people and things. Alternate translation: [the view]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 6:16 (#1)

λέγουσιν τοῖς ὄρεσιν καὶ ταῖς πέτραις, πέσετε ἐφ' ἡμᾶς, καὶ κρύψατε ἡμᾶς

"they say to the mountains and to the rocks, "Fall on us and hide us"

The people are addressing things that they know cannot hear them, the **mountains** and the **rocks**, in order to express in a strong way what they are feeling. If your readers might not recognize what the people are doing, you could translate this in a way that would make that clear. Alternate translation: [they were saying that they wished the mountains and rocks would fall on them and hide them]

See: Apostrophe

Revelation 6:17 (#3)

τίς δύναται σταθῆναι

"who is able to stand"

Here the word **stand** means to be declared innocent when judged, as in Psalm 130:3, "If you, Yahweh, would mark iniquities, Lord, who could stand?" which means, "If you, Yahweh, kept a record of sins, no one would be declared innocent." Alternate translation: [and everyone will be punished, because no one is innocent!]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 6:17 (#2)

τίς δύναται σταθῆναι

"who is able to stand"

The people are using the question form for emphasis. If you would not use the question form for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [no one is able to stand!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Revelation 6:17 (#1)

ἡ ἡμέρα ἡ μεγάλη τῆς ὀργῆς αὐτῶν

"the great day of their anger"

While this was happening on a certain **day**, the people may be using the word **day** to mean a specific time, the time when God had chosen to judge the world. Alternate translation: [the momentous time when they will punish sin]

See: Idiom

Revelation - Chapter 7 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

The events of this chapter take place after the Lamb opens the sixth seal but before he opens the seventh seal. John describes a vision of 144,000 servants of God whom angels mark with a seal. John then describes a second vision about a great multitude praising God.

- The 144,000 servants (7:1–8)
- The great multitude (7:9–17)

Some translations set each line of poetry farther to the right than the rest of the text to make it easier to read. The ULT does this with verses 5–8 and 15–17.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Large numbers

Translate the large numbers in verses 5–8 in the way that would be most natural in your language.

Some languages may need to supply a noun after the number to express the meaning. For example, in verse 5 you might say "144,000" or "one hundred forty-four thousand people." In verses 6–8 you might say "12,000" or "twelve thousand people."

The order of the tribes
Translators should be aware that the tribes of the people of Israel are not listed in this chapter in the same order as they are generally listed in the Old Testament. This seems to be intentional, and scholars have offered various interpretations for it. In your translation, it would be appropriate to list the tribes in the order in which John presents them here, rather than listing them in the usual Old Testament order.

Revelation 7:1 (#4)

μήτε ἐπὶ πᾶν δένδρον

"or on any tree"

John may be using one place where the wind might blow, against a **tree**, to mean every place where the wind might blow. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation, preceded by a comma: [no, not anywhere at all]

See: Synecdoche

Revelation 7:1 (#3)

ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς, μήτε ἐπὶ τῆς θαλάσσης

"on the land or on the sea"

John seems to be using the two main components of the world, the **land** and the **sea**, to mean everywhere in the world. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [anywhere in the world]

See: Merism

Revelation 7:1 (#2)

ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς, μήτε ἐπὶ τῆς θαλάσσης, μήτε ἐπὶ πᾶν δένδρον

"on the land or on the sea or on any tree"

After John says that the wind would not blow **on the land or on the sea**, he may add **or on any tree** for emphasis, perhaps alluding to his reference in 6:13 to a great wind shaking a tree. In that case the two phrases would mean similar things, as the next two notes explain. John would be using the repetition for emphasis. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine the two phrases. Alternate translation: [on any place on the land or in the sea]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 7:1 (#1)

ἑστῶτας ἐπὶ τὰς τέσσαρας γωνίας τῆς γῆς, κρατοῦντας τοὺς τέσσαρας ἀνέμους τῆς γῆς

"standing at the four corners of the earth, holding the four winds of the earth"

John is speaking as if the **earth** had **four corners**. He is referring from his own standpoint to locations to the north, south, east, and west of him. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could state the meaning plainly, using your own language's words for these primary directions. Alternate translation: [at places on the earth where they could hold back the north, south, east, and west winds]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 7:2 (#2)

σφραγῖδα Θεοῦ ζῶντος

"the seal of the living God"

In this case the word **seal** refers to a tool that a person would use to compress and mark wax in order to create a "seal" in the sense in which John uses that word in chapters 5 and 6. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the sealing tool that belongs to the living God]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 7:2 (#4)

ἀδικῆσαι τὴν γῆν καὶ τὴν θάλασσαν

"to harm the earth and the sea"

The implication is that these angels would **harm the earth and the sea** by not allowing any winds to blow on them. This would, for example, prevent any rainstorms from forming and watering crops. You could indicate this in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [to harm the earth and the sea by holding back the winds]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 7:2 (#3)

οἷς ἐδόθη αὐτοῖς

"to whom it was given to them"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [whom God had allowed]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 7:2 (#1)

ἀνατολῆς ἡλίου

“the rising of the sun”

This expression refers to a specific direction. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly, using your own language’s term for that direction. Alternate translation: [the east]

See: Idiom

Revelation 7:3 (#1)

μὴ ἀδικήσητε τὴν γῆν, μήτε τὴν θάλασσαν μήτε τὰ δένδρα

“Do not harm the earth or the sea or the trees”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this double negative that consists of the negative particle **not** and the negative verb **harm**. Alternate translation: [allow the winds to blow on the earth and the sea and the trees]

See: Double Negatives

Revelation 7:4 (#1)

τῶν ἐσφραγισμένων

“of the ones having been sealed”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the ones whom the angels sealed]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 7:4 (#2)

ἑκατὸν τεσσεράκοντα τέσσαρες χιλιάδες

“144 thousands”

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, you may translate the large number here and the large numbers in verses 6–8 in the way that would be most natural in your language. Some languages may need to supply a noun after the number to express the meaning. Alternate translation: [144,000] or [one hundred forty-four thousand people]

See: Numbers

Revelation 7:4 (#4)

υἱῶν Ἰσραήλ

“of the sons of Israel”

Here the word **sons** could mean: (1) the literal sons of Israel (that is, Jacob) who were the ancestors of the 12 tribes. If this is the meaning, it would be appropriate to retain the term “sons” in your translation. (2) the descendants of Israel (Jacob), who formed 12 tribes. Alternate translation: [of the descendants of Israel]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 7:4 (#3)

ἐσφραγισμένοι

“having been sealed”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. Alternate translation: [The angels had sealed them]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 7:5 (#2)

δώδεκα χιλιάδες

“12 thousands”

Alternate translation: [12,000] or [twelve thousand people]

See: Numbers

Revelation 7:5 (#1)

Ἰούδα & Ῥουβὴν & Γὰδ

“of Judah & of Reuben & of Gad”

The words **Judah**, **Reuben**, and **Gad** are the names of men.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 7:5 (#3)

δώδεκα χιλιάδες ἐσφραγισμένοι

“12 thousands having been sealed”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the angels sealed 12 thousands]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 7:6 (#1)

Ἀσὴρ & Νεφθαλεὶμ & Μανασσῆ

“of Asher & of Naphtali & of Manasseh”

The words **Asher**, **Naphtali**, and **Manasseh** are the names of men.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 7:7 (#1)

Συμεὼν & Λευεὶ & Ἰσσαχὰρ

“of Simeon & of Levi & of Issachar”

The words **Simeon**, **Levi**, and **Issachar** are the names of men.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 7:8 (#1)

Ζαβουλὼν & Ἰωσὴφ & Βενιαμεὶν

“of Zebulun & of Joseph & of Benjamin”

The words **Zebulun**, **Joseph**, and **Benjamin** are the names of men.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 7:8 (#2)

δώδεκα χιλιάδες ἐσφραγισμένοι

“12 thousands & been sealed”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the angels sealed 12 thousands]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 7:9 (#5)

φοίνικες

“palm branches”

In this culture, people would wave **palm branches** on special occasions, especially to celebrate a victory. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [palm branches for a victory celebration]

See: Symbolic Action

Revelation 7:9 (#4)

στολὰς λευκάς

“in white robes”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:4. Alternate translation: [white robes symbolic of their purity]

See: Symbolic Action

Revelation 7:9 (#1)

ὃν ἀριθμῆσαι αὐτὸν οὐδεὶς ἐδύνατο

“that, to number it, no one was able”

It might seem that this expression contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you can shorten it. Alternate translation: [that no one was able to number]

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Revelation 7:9 (#2)

ἐκ παντὸς ἔθνους, καὶ φυλῶν, καὶ λαῶν, καὶ γλωσσῶν

“from every nation and tribe and people and language”

See how you translated the similar expression in 5:9. Alternate translation: [from every different people group]

See: Doublet

Revelation 7:9 (#3)

περιβεβλημένους στολὰς λευκάς

“having been clothed in white robes”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [wearing white robes]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 7:10 (#2)

τῷ καθημένῳ ἐπὶ τῷ θρόνῳ

“the one sitting on the throne”

The people in the great multitude are describing God’s supreme ruling power and authority by association with the way he is **sitting on the throne**, a symbol of that power and authority. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the ruler of all]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 7:10 (#1)

ἡ σωτηρία τῷ Θεῷ ἡμῶν, τῷ καθημένῳ ἐπὶ τῷ θρόνῳ καὶ τῷ Ἀρνίῳ

“Salvation {is} to our God, the one sitting on the throne, and to the Lamb”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **Salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Our God, who is the one sitting on the throne, and the Lamb are the ones who have saved us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 7:11 (#1)

ἔπεσαν & ἐπὶ τὰ πρόσωπα αὐτῶν

"they fell on their faces"

Be sure that it is clear in your translation that the **angels** and **elders** and **living creatures** did not fall down accidentally. They bowed down in front of the throne as a gesture to honor God. Alternate translation: [they bowed down with their faces to the ground]

See: Idiom

Revelation 7:12 (#2)

εἰς τοὺς αἰῶνας τῶν αἰώνων

"to the ages of the ages"

See how you translated the same expression in 1:18. Alternate translation: [forever]

See: Idiom

Revelation 7:12 (#1)

ἡ εὐλογία, καὶ ἡ δόξα, καὶ ἡ σοφία, καὶ ἡ εὐχαριστία, καὶ ἡ τιμὴ, καὶ ἡ δύναμις, καὶ ἡ ἰσχὺς, τῷ Θεῷ ἡμῶν

"Praise and glory and wisdom and thanks and honor and power and strength {be} to our God"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **Praise**, **glory**, **wisdom**, **thanks**, **honor**, **power**, and **strength**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. See how you translated the similar expression in 4:11. Alternate translation: [May everyone praise, glorify, thank, and honor our God and acknowledge how wise, powerful, and strong he is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 7:13 (#2)

οὗτοι, οἱ περιβεβλημένοι τὰς στολὰς τὰς λευκὰς, τίνες εἰσὶν καὶ πόθεν ἦλθον

"These, the ones having been clothed in white robes, who are they, and where have they come from"

This elder is using the question form to introduce something he wants to make sure John understands. Since John answers the question in the next verse, it would be appropriate to retain the question form in your translation, but if it would be helpful to your readers, you could word the question in a way that would show its purpose. Alternate translation: [Do you know who these people are who are wearing white robes and where they have come from]

See: Rhetorical Question

Revelation 7:13 (#1)

ἀπεκρίθη & λέγων μοι

"responded, saying to me"

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two words connected with **and**. The word **responded** indicates that this elder was **saying** these things to John in response to what John was seeing in this vision. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase that does not use "and." Alternate translation: [asked me]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 7:13 (#3)

οἱ περιβεβλημένοι τὰς στολὰς τὰς λευκὰς

"the ones having been clothed in white robes"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the ones wearing white robes]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 7:14 (#3)

ἔπλυναν τὰς στολὰς αὐτῶν, καὶ ἐλεύκαναν αὐτὰς ἐν τῷ αἵματι τοῦ Ἀρνίου

"they have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb"

As in 3:4 and other passages in the book, **robes** that are **white** represent purity of life and devotion to Jesus. The **blood of the Lamb** is the blood that Jesus shed when he died on the cross as the Savior. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. The UST models one way to do this.

See: Metaphor

Revelation 7:14 (#1)

κύριέ μου, σὺ οἶδας

"My lord, you know"

John is answering the elder politely. You may translate this the way someone would respond politely in your

language to a question whose answer they did not know. Alternate translation: [I do not know, please tell me]

See: Politeness

Revelation 7:14 (#2)

τῆς θλίψεως τῆς μεγάλης

"the great tribulation"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **tribulation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the time when believers in Jesus will be greatly persecuted]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 7:15 (#1)

ἡμέρας καὶ νυκτὸς

"day and night"

The elder is using the two main components of time, **day** and **night**, to mean all the time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [constantly]

See: Merism

Revelation 7:16 (#1)

οὐ πεινάσουσιν ἔτι, οὐδὲ διψήσουσιν ἔτι

"They will not hunger anymore, nor will they thirst anymore"

If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate these double negatives that consist of the negative particle **not** and the negative verbs **hunger** and **thirst**. The UST models one way to do this.

See: Double Negatives

Revelation 7:16 (#2)

οὐδὲ μὴ πέσῃ ἐπ' αὐτοὺς ὁ ἥλιος, οὐδὲ πᾶν καῦμα

"nor will the sun fall on them at all, nor any heat"

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two words connected with **or**. The word **sun** tells where this **heat** comes from. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase that does not use "or." Alternate translation: [nor will the heat of the sun fall on them at all]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 7:16 (#3)

οὐδὲ μὴ πέσῃ ἐπ' αὐτοὺς ὁ ἥλιος, οὐδὲ πᾶν καῦμα

"nor will the sun fall on them at all, nor any heat"

By referring to the **sun** and its **heat**, this elder may mean by association that these people will never again have to work hard in the hot sun to make a living. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they will no longer have to work hard in the hot sun to make a living]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 7:17 (#3)

ὁδηγήσει αὐτοὺς ἐπὶ ζωῆς πηγὰς ὑδάτων

"guide them to springs of the waters of life"

The elder is speaking as if Jesus would literally **guide** these believers to **springs** of water. He is using water to represent the everlasting **life** that Jesus gives believers. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will give them everlasting life]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 7:17 (#1)

ποιμανεῖ αὐτούς

"will shepherd them"

The elder is speaking as if Jesus would literally **shepherd** these believers. He means that Jesus will care for them, as a shepherd cares for sheep. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will take care of them]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 7:17 (#2)

ὁδηγήσει αὐτοὺς ἐπὶ ζωῆς πηγὰς ὑδάτων & ἐξαλείψει ὁ Θεὸς πᾶν δάκρυον ἐκ τῶν ὀφθαλμῶν αὐτῶν

"guide them to springs of the waters of life & God will wipe away every tear from their eyes"

These are quotations from the Old Testament, from Isaiah 49:10 and Isaiah 25:8. Since they occur within John's quotation of what this elder told him, they are second-level quotations. You may be able to indicate this by using second-level quotation marks or some other punctuation or convention of your language. You may also wish to use special formatting to set off these quotations, as the ULT does.

See: Quote Markings

Revelation 7:17 (#4)

ἐξαλείψει ὁ Θεὸς πᾶν δάκρυον ἐκ τῶν ὀφθαλμῶν αὐτῶν

"God will wipe away every tear from their eyes"

The elder is using the word **tear** to mean by association the sorrow that people feel that leads them to shed tears. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God will comfort their every sorrow] or [God will comfort them for every sorrow that they have experienced]

See: Metonymy

Revelation - Chapter 8 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter begins to show what happens when the Lamb opens the seventh seal. God uses the prayers of all believers to cause dramatic things to happen on earth. John then describes what happens when angels sound the first four of seven trumpets.

- The Lamb opens the seventh seal (8:1–5)
- The first trumpet (8:6–7)
- The second trumpet (8:8–9)
- The third trumpet (8:10–11)
- The fourth trumpet (8:12–13)

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Ordinal numbers

John uses the ordinal numbers "first" through "fourth" in verses 7, 8, 10, and 12. If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you can use cardinal numbers or equivalent expressions in your translation. (See: Ordinal Numbers)

The fraction "one third"

Many times in this chapter John uses the expression "one third." This means one part out of three equal parts. Translate this in the way that would be most natural in your language. (See: Fractions)

Revelation 8:1 (#1)

ἤνοιξεν

"he opened"

The pronoun **he** refers to the Lamb. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the Lamb opened]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 8:1 (#3)

ὡς ἡμιώριον

"for about half an hour"

An **hour** was the shortest interval of time that this culture measured. So **half an hour** may implicitly mean just a short time. You could indicate this in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [for a moment]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 8:1 (#2)

τὴν σφραγῖδα τὴν ἑβδόμην

"the seventh seal"

If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you can use a cardinal number here or an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [seal number seven] or [the last seal]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 8:2 (#1)

ἐνώπιον & ἑστήκασιν

"stand before"

In this context, while these angels may indeed position themselves in front of God's throne, the phrase **stand before** means to stay in the presence of another person in order to serve that person whenever and however needed. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who remain ready to serve]

See: Idiom

Revelation 8:2 (#2)

ἐδόθησαν αὐτοῖς ἑπτὰ σάλπιγγες

"seven trumpets were given to them"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God gave each of them a trumpet]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 8:3 (#1)

ἐστάθη & ἐδόθη αὐτῷ θυμιάματα πολλὰ

"was stationed & much incense was given to him"

If your language does not use these passive forms, you could express the ideas in active form or in an-

other way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [stationed himself ... God gave him much incense]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 8:4 (#1)

ἐκ χειρὸς τοῦ ἀγγέλου

“from the hand of the angel”

Here, **hand** refers to the censer in the angel’s hand. Alternate translation: [from the censer that the angel was holding]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 8:5 (#2)

ἔβαλεν

“threw {it”

While the pronoun **it** refers to the **censer** in its first instance, in its second instance it refers to the **fire from the altar**. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [threw the fire] or [threw the burning coals]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 8:5 (#1)

ἐγέμισεν αὐτὸν ἐκ τοῦ πυρὸς τοῦ θυσιαστηρίου

“filled it from the fire of the altar”

This is probably a reference to coals that were on **fire** on the altar. Alternate translation: [filled it with burning coals from the fire on the altar]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 8:6 (#1)

σάλπιγγας & σαλπίσωσιν

“trumpets & they might trumpet”

John is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. The verb translated **trumpet** has the same root as the word translated **trumpets**. The repetition of the sounds may be intended to have a musical effect. You may be able to use the same construction in your translation if your language has similar words for this kind of instrument and for the action of playing it.

See: Poetry

Revelation 8:7 (#5)

καὶ τὸ τρίτον τῆς γῆς κατεκάη

“and a third of the earth was burned up”

Some ancient manuscripts include the phrase **and a third of the earth was burned up**. The ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts do not include that phrase. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Revelation 8:7 (#1)

ὁ πρῶτος ἐσάλπισεν

“the first trumpeted”

The word **first** implicitly means the first angel, and the word **sounded** implicitly means that he sounded his trumpet. You could indicate this in your translation if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the first angel sounded his trumpet]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 8:7 (#3)

ἐβλήθη & κατεκάη & κατεκάη & κατεκάη

“it was thrown & was burned up & were burned up & was burned up”

If your language does not use these passive forms, you could express the ideas in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the angel threw it ... burned up ... burned up ... burned up]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 8:7 (#4)

τὸ τρίτον τῆς γῆς κατεκάη, καὶ τὸ τρίτον τῶν δένδρων κατεκάη, καὶ πᾶς χόρτος χλωρὸς κατεκάη

“a third of the earth was burned up, and a third of the trees were burned up, and all the green grass was burned up”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could state this in active form. Alternate translation: [it burned up a third of the earth, a third of the trees, and all the green grass]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 8:7 (#2)

ὁ πρῶτος

“the first”

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, if your language does not use ordinal numbers, you can use cardinal numbers or equivalent expressions here and in verses 8, 10, and 12. Alternate translation: [angel number one]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 8:8 (#2)

ἐγένετο τὸ τρίτον τῆς θαλάσσης αἷμα

"a third of the sea became blood"

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, the expression **one third** means one part out of three equal parts. Here and throughout the chapter, translate the expression in the way that would be most natural in your language.

See: Fractions

Revelation 8:8 (#1)

ὡς ὄρος μέγα πυρὶ καιόμενον, ἐβλήθη

"something} like a great mountain burning with fire was thrown"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the angel threw something like a great mountain burning with fire]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 8:9 (#1)

τὸ τρίτον τῶν πλοίων διεφθάρησαν

"a third of the ships were destroyed"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the bloody water destroyed a third of the ships]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 8:11 (#3)

ἐγένετο & εἰς ἄψινθον

"became wormwood"

John means by association that the water became bitter and poisonous, as if it were the bitter **wormwood** shrub that people in his culture believed was poisonous. Alternate translation: [became poisonous like wormwood]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 8:11 (#2)

ὁ Ἄψινθος

"Wormwood"

Wormwood is a woody shrub that tastes bitter. Because of its bitter taste, people in this culture believed that the shrub was poisonous. Your language may have a term for this shrub or for a similar one that you can use in your translation. You could also use a general expression. Alternate translation: [Bitter Shrub]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 8:11 (#1)

τὸ ὄνομα τοῦ ἀστέρος λέγεται ὁ Ἄψινθος

"the name of the star is called Wormwood"

It might seem that this expression contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you can shorten it. Alternate translation: [the name of the star is Wormwood]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Revelation 8:11 (#4)

πολλοὶ τῶν ἀνθρώπων

"many of the men"

John is not referring to a specific group of **men**. He means people in general. Express this in the way that would be most natural in your language. Alternate translation: [many people]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Revelation 8:12 (#4)

ἡ ἡμέρα μὴ φάνῃ τὸ τρίτον αὐτῆς

"the day, a third of it did not shine"

When John says of **a third** of the **day** that **it did not shine**, he means by association that the sun did not shine during a third of the day. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the sun did not shine during one third of the day]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 8:12 (#1)

ἐπλήγη τὸ τρίτον τοῦ ἡλίου, καὶ τὸ τρίτον τῆς σελήνης, καὶ τὸ τρίτον τῶν ἀστέρων

"a third of the sun was struck, and a third of the moon and a third of the stars"

John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [a third of the sun was struck, and a third of the moon and a third of the stars were struck]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 8:12 (#5)

καὶ ἡ νὺξ ὁμοίως

"and likewise the night"

John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and likewise a third of the night did not shine] or [and likewise the moon and the stars did not shine during one third of the night]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 8:12 (#3)

σκοτισθῇ τὸ τρίτον αὐτῶν

"a third of them were darkened"

The phrase **a third of them were darkened** could mean: (1) one third of the time, the sun, moon, and stars were dark, or (2) one third of the sun, one third of the moon, and one third of the stars became dark. You could say either of these things as an alternate translation.

See: Metaphor

Revelation 8:12 (#2)

ἐπλήγη τὸ τρίτον τοῦ ἡλίου, καὶ τὸ τρίτον τῆς σελήνης, καὶ τὸ τρίτον τῶν ἀστέρων; ἵνα σκοτισθῇ τὸ τρίτον αὐτῶν

"a third of the sun was struck, and a third of the moon and a third of the stars, so that a third of them were darkened"

If your language does not use these passive forms, you could express the ideas in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God struck a third of the sun and a third of the moon and a third of the stars so that a third of them turned dark]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 8:13 (#3)

οὐαὶ, οὐαὶ, οὐαὶ

"Woe, woe, woe"

Since 9:12 and 11:14 speak of a first, second, and third "woe," the eagle may be announcing implicitly that three terrible events are about to occur. The UST models a way to express this possible meaning of the phrase **woe, woe, woe**.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 8:13 (#4)

τῶν λοιπῶν φωνῶν τῆς σάλπιγγος τῶν τριῶν ἀγγέλων τῶν μελλόντων σαλπίζειν

"the remaining sounds of the trumpet of the three angels who are going to trumpet"

This does not mean that the **three angels** only have one **trumpet** among them. Alternate translation: [the blasts that the remaining three angels will make on their trumpets when they blow them]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 8:13 (#1)

ἀετοῦ

"eagle"

Some ancient manuscripts read **eagle**. ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts read "angel." If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Revelation 8:13 (#2)

οὐαὶ, οὐαὶ, οὐαὶ

"Woe, woe, woe"

The eagle may be repeating the word **woe** for emphasis. If it would not be natural in your language to repeat a word in that way, you could express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [What great woe the ones living on the earth will experience] or see the next note for another possibility.

See: Reduplication

Revelation - Chapter 9 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

In this chapter, John continues to describe what happens when angels sound seven trumpets. (See: Symbolic Prophecy)

- The Fifth Trumpet (9:1–12)
- The Sixth Trumpet (9:13–21)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Woe
John describes several "woes" in the book of Revelation. This chapter begins to describe the three "woes" announced at the end of Chapter 8. Woes signify calamity, disaster, or terrible events.

Animal imagery
This chapter includes several animals: locusts, scorpions, horses, lions, and snakes. Animals convey different qualities or traits. For example, a lion is powerful and dangerous. Translators should use the same animals in their translation if possible. If the animal is unknown, use a familiar one with similar qualities or traits.

Abaddon and Apollyon
"Abaddon" is a Hebrew word. "Apollyon" is a Greek word. Both words mean "Destroyer." John used the sounds of the Hebrew word and wrote them with Greek letters. The ULT and UST write the sounds of both words with English letters. Translators are encouraged to transliterate these words using the letters of their own language. The original Greek readers would have understood "Apollyon" to mean "Destroyer." So translators may also indicate this meaning in the text or in a footnote. (See: Copy or Borrow Words)

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Simile
John uses many similes in this chapter. They help to describe the images that he sees in his vision. (See: Simile)

Generic Sense
Several times in this chapter John uses the masculine word "men" in a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use a term in your language that is clearly inclusive of both men and women such as "people" or "humanity." (See: When Masculine Words Include Women)

Revelation 9:1 (#2)

ἐδόθη αὐτῷ ἡ κλεὶς τοῦ φρέατος τῆς Ἀβύσσου

"the key of the shaft of the abyss was given to it"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the star received the key to the shaft of the abyss]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 9:1 (#1)

ὁ πέμπτος ἄγγελος

"the fifth angel"

If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you can use a cardinal number here or an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [angel number five]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 9:2 (#2)

ἐσκοτώθη ὁ ἥλιος καὶ ὁ ἀὴρ ἐκ τοῦ καπνοῦ τοῦ φρέατος

"the sun and the air were darkened from the smoke of the shaft"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the smoke from the shaft darkened the sun and the air]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 9:2 (#1)

ἀνέβη καπνὸς ἐκ τοῦ φρέατος, ὡς καπνὸς καμίνου μεγάλης

"smoke went up from the shaft like the smoke of a great furnace"

The point of this comparison is that a large quantity of **smoke** came from the **shaft**, just as a **great furnace** would give off a large quantity of smoke. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [a large quantity of smoke went up from the shaft, as does from a huge furnace]

See: Simile

Revelation 9:3 (#3)

οἱ σκορπίοι

"scorpions"

A **scorpion** is an insect with a poisonous stinger at the end of its long tail. The sting can cause severe pain or even death. If your readers would not be familiar with what a **scorpion** is, in your translation you could use the name of a comparable insect or animal in your area. Alternate translation: [deadly stinging insects]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 9:3 (#1)

ἐδόθη αὐταῖς ἐξουσία

"power was given to them"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God gave them power]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 9:3 (#2)

ἐδόθη αὐταῖς ἐξουσία, ὡς ἔχουσιν ἐξουσίαν οἱ σκορπίοι τῆς γῆς

"power was given to them as scorpions of the earth have power"

The point of this comparison is that just as **scorpions of the earth** have the power to hurt people by stinging them, so these **locusts** from the abyss had the power to hurt people in that same way. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [to hurt people by stinging them, just as scorpions on earth do]

See: Simile

Revelation 9:4 (#1)

ἐρρέθη αὐταῖς

"it was told to them"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God commanded them]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 9:4 (#2)

ἐρρέθη αὐταῖς, ἵνα μὴ ἀδικήσουσιν τὸν χόρτον τῆς γῆς, οὐδὲ πᾶν χλωρὸν, οὐδὲ πᾶν δένδρον, εἰ μὴ τοὺς ἀνθρώπους οἵτινες οὐκ ἔχουσι τὴν σφραγῖδα τοῦ Θεοῦ ἐπὶ τῶν μετώπων

"it was told to them that they should not harm the grass of the earth or any green plant or any tree, if not the men who did not have the seal of God on {their} foreheads"

Having a direct quotation here may be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And they were told, "Do not harm the grass of the earth or any green plant or any tree, but only the men who do not have the seal of God on their foreheads."]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Revelation 9:4 (#3)

τοὺς ἀνθρώπους

"the men"

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, here and in several other places in this chapter John uses the masculine word **men** in a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use a term in your language that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [the people]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Revelation 9:5 (#3)

ὁ βασανισμὸς αὐτῶν ὡς βασανισμὸς σκορπίου, ὅταν παίσῃ ἄνθρωπον

"their torment {would be} like the torment of a scorpion when it might strike a man"

The point of this comparison is that just as the sting of a **scorpion** is very painful, the **torment** that people would experience after these locusts stung them would be very painful. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [their torment when the locusts stung them would be very painful, as the sting of a scorpion is very painful for a person]

See: Simile

Revelation 9:5 (#1)

ἐδόθη αὐτοῖς ἵνα μὴ ἀποκτείνωσιν αὐτούς, ἀλλ' ἵνα βασανισθήσονται

"it was given to them that they should not kill them, but that they would be tormented"

If your language does not use these passive forms, you could express the ideas in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God did not allow the locusts to kill these people but to torment them for five months]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 9:5 (#2)

ἐδόθη αὐτοῖς ἵνα μὴ ἀποκτείνωσιν αὐτούς

"it was given to them that they should not kill them"

The **them** refers in its first instance to the locusts John describes in 9:3 and in its second instance the people John describes in 9:4 who did not have the seal of God on their foreheads. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [it was given to the locusts that they should not kill these people]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 9:6 (#1)

ἐν ταῖς ἡμέραις ἐκείναις

"in those days"

John is using the term **days** to refer to a specific time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [at that time]

See: Idiom

Revelation 9:6 (#3)

τὸν θάνατον

"death"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **death**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to die]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 9:6 (#4)

φεύγει ὁ θάνατος ἀπ' αὐτῶν

"death flees from them"

John is speaking figuratively of **death** as if it were a living thing that could run away or flee. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they will not be able to die]

See: Personification

Revelation 9:6 (#2)

ζητήσουσιν οἱ ἄνθρωποι τὸν θάνατον, καὶ οὐ μὴ εὑρήσουσιν αὐτόν, καὶ ἐπιθυμήσουσιν ἀποθανεῖν, καὶ φεύγει ὁ θάνατος ἀπ' αὐτῶν

"men will seek death, but they will certainly not find it, and they will long to die, but death flees from them"

These two phrases mean similar things. John is using repetition to emphasize the idea that the phrases express. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine the phrases. Alternate translation: [even though people will want very much to die, they will not be able to die]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 9:7 (#1)

ἡτοιμασμένοις εἰς πόλεμον

"prepared for war"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [wearing armor for war]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 9:8 (#1)

τρίχας ὡς τρίχας γυναικῶν

"hair like the hair of women"

In this culture women typically wore their hair long. So the point of this comparison is that the locusts had long **hair**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [hair that was long like the hair of women]

See: Simile

Revelation 9:8 (#3)

οἱ ὀδόντες αὐτῶν ὡς λεόντων ἦσαν

"their teeth were as of lions"

The point of this comparison is that the locusts had **teeth** that were sharp, large, and strong, like the teeth of **lions**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [their teeth were sharp, large, and strong like lions' teeth]

See: Simile

Revelation 9:8 (#2)

οἱ ὀδόντες αὐτῶν ὡς λεόντων ἦσαν

"their teeth were as of lions"

John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [their teeth were as the teeth of lions]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 9:9 (#3)

θώρακας σιδηροῦς

“iron breastplates”

A **breastplate** was a piece of armor that covered and protected the chest. If your readers would not be familiar with what a breastplate is, in your translation you could use the name of a comparable object in your culture, or you could use a general expression. Alternate translation: [pieces of armor made of iron to protect a soldier’s chest]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 9:9 (#4)

ἡ φωνὴ τῶν πτερύγων αὐτῶν ὡς φωνὴ ἁρμάτων ἵππων πολλῶν

“the sound of their wings {was} like the sound of many chariots of horses”

The point of this comparison is that the **wings** of all the locusts flying around made a very loud **sound**, like **the sound of chariots**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [the sound of their wings was very loud, like the sound of many chariots of horses]

See: Simile

Revelation 9:9 (#1)

εἶχον θώρακας ὡς θώρακας σιδηροῦς

“they had breastplates like iron breastplates”

John is speaking as if these locusts literally had **breastplates**. He probably means that the skin on the front of their bodies was very hard. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the hard skin on the front of their bodies was like iron breastplates]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 9:9 (#2)

εἶχον θώρακας ὡς θώρακας σιδηροῦς

“they had breastplates like iron breastplates”

The point of this comparison is that the skin on the front of the locusts’ bodies was very strong, as if it were made of **iron**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [the hard skin on the front of their bodies was very strong, like an iron breastplate]

See: Simile

Revelation 9:9 (#6)

τρεχόντων εἰς πόλεμον

“running into battle”

John is speaking as if these **chariots** were themselves literally **running into battle**, though it is the **horses** pulling the chariots which would be running and the drivers of the chariots who would be hurrying to get into the **battle**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [whose drivers are hurrying them into battle]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 9:9 (#5)

ἁρμάτων ἵππων

“of & chariots of horses”

John is using this possessive form to describe **chariots** that **horses** pull into battle. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this meaning without using a possessive form. Alternate translation: [horse-drawn chariots]

See: Possession

Revelation 9:10 (#2)

μῆνας πέντε

“for five months”

This could mean implicitly: (1) that the locusts had power for five months to harm people. Alternate translation: [over a period of five months]; (2) that the locusts could sting people and the people would be in pain for five months. Alternate translation: [with a sting that will cause them pain for five months]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 9:10 (#1)

σκορπίοις

“scorpions”

See how you translated the term “scorpion” in 9:3.

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 9:11 (#1)

τῆς Ἀβύσσου

“of the abyss”

See how you translated the term **abyss** in 9:1.

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 9:11 (#2)

τὸν ἄγγελον τῆς Ἀβύσσου; ὄνομα αὐτῷ Ἑβραϊστὶ, Ἀβαδδών, καὶ ἐν τῇ Ἑλληνικῇ ὄνομα ἔχει, Ἀπολλύων

"the angel of the abyss. His name in Hebrew {is} Abaddon, and in Greek he has the name Apollyon"

The word **Abaddon** is a Hebrew name that John spells out using Greek letters so that his readers will know how it sounds. John then tells his readers a Greek name, **Apollyon**, with the same meaning, so that his readers will know what it means. Both names mean Destroyer. In your translation you can spell both names the way they sound in your language and then explain their meaning. Alternate translation: [His Hebrew name is Abaddon and his Greek name is Apollyon; both names mean Destroyer]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Revelation 9:12 (#3)

οὐαὶ

"woe"

See how you translated the term **woe** in 8:13. Alternate translation: [terrible event]

See: Idiom

Revelation 9:12 (#1)

ἡ οὐαὶ ἡ μία ἀπῆλθεν

"The first woe has passed"

See how you translated the term **woe** in 8:13. Alternate translation: [One terrible event is over]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 9:12 (#2)

ἡ οὐαὶ ἡ μία

"The first woe"

If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you could use a cardinal number here or an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [woe number one]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 9:13 (#4)

τοῦ ἐνώπιον τοῦ Θεοῦ

"before God"

Here the word **before** means "in front of" or "in the presence of" another person. The Jews believed that God was especially present at his **altar**. Alternate translation: [that is in the presence of God]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 9:13 (#3)

κεράτων

"horns"

John is referring to the horn-shaped extensions that were at each of the four corners of the top of the altar. He calls them **horns** by association with their shape. If it would be clearer for your readers, in your translation you could just refer to the "corners" of the altar, as UST does.

See: Metonymy

Revelation 9:13 (#2)

φωνὴν μίαν

"a voice"

John is using one part of a person, his **voice**, to represent all of the person in the act of speaking. John does not say who the speaker was, but it may have been God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [someone speaking]

See: Synecdoche

Revelation 9:13 (#1)

ὁ ἕκτος ἄγγελος

"the sixth angel"

If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you could use a cardinal number here or an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [angel number six]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 9:14 (#1)

τῷ ἕκτῳ ἀγγέλῳ

"to the sixth angel"

If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you can use a cardinal number here or an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [to angel number six]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 9:14 (#2)

τοὺς δεδεμένους

“having been bound”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. The text does not say who **bound** these **four angels**, but it implies that God did it or commanded his own angels to do it. Alternate translation: [whom God had bound] or [whom God had commanded his own angels to bind]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 9:14 (#3)

Εὐφράτῃ

“Euphrates”

The word **Euphrates** is the name of a river.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 9:15 (#2)

τὴν ὥραν, καὶ ἡμέραν, καὶ μῆνα, καὶ ἐνιαυτόν

“the hour and day and month and year”

These words all refer to specific periods of time. John is using them together to emphasize that this is a very specific time. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [that specific time]

See: Doublet

Revelation 9:15 (#1)

ἐλύθησαν οἱ τέσσαρες ἄγγελοι, οἱ ἡτοιμασμένοι εἰς τὴν ὥραν, καὶ ἡμέραν, καὶ μῆνα, καὶ ἐνιαυτόν

“the four angels having been prepared for the hour and day and month and year were released”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the sixth angel released the four angels whom God had prepared for the hour and day and month and year]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 9:15 (#3)

τὸ τρίτον τῶν ἀνθρώπων

“a third of men”

A **third** means one part out of three equal parts. Alternate translation: [one out of every three men]

See: Fractions

Revelation 9:16 (#2)

δύο μυριάδες μυριάδων

“was} two myriads of myriads”

A myriad is a hundred hundreds, or ten thousand. Express this number in the way that would be most natural in your language. See how you translated a similar large number in 5:11. Alternate translation: [200,000,000]

See: Numbers

Revelation 9:16 (#1)

ὁ ἀριθμὸς τῶν στρατευμάτων τοῦ ἱππικοῦ δύο μυριάδες μυριάδων; ἤκουσα τὸν ἀριθμὸν αὐτῶν

“the number of the horse soldiers {was} two myriads of myriads; I heard their number”

John typically says **I heard** or “I saw” before describing what he heard or saw, so it might be more natural to put that information first. Alternate translation: [I heard the number of the horse soldiers; it was two myriads of myriads]

See: Information Structure

Revelation 9:17 (#2)

ὑακινθίνους

“hyacinth”

A **hyacinth** is a plant in the lily family that has dark blue flowers on spikes. If your readers would not be familiar with what a hyacinth is, in your translation you could use the name of a plant or other object in your culture that is the same color as hyacinth flowers, or you could use a general expression. Alternate translation: [dark blue]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 9:17 (#1)

θώρακας πυρίνους, καὶ ὑακινθίνους, καὶ θειώδεις

“fiery and hyacinth and sulfurous breastplates”

John is describing the colors of the **breastplates** by association with other things that are those colors. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use objects from your own culture that are these colors or express the meaning plainly. See, for example, how you translated the word “fiery” in 6:3. Alternate translation: [breastplates that were fiery red, hyacinth blue, and sulfur yellow] or [bright red, dark blue, and brilliant yellow breastplates]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 9:18 (#1)

ἀπὸ τῶν τριῶν πληγῶν τούτων ἀπεκτάνθησαν τὸ τρίτον τῶν ἀνθρώπων ἐκ τοῦ πυρὸς, καὶ τοῦ καπνοῦ, καὶ τοῦ θείου, τοῦ ἐκπορευομένου ἐκ τῶν στομάτων αὐτῶν

"By these three plagues, by the fire and the smoke and the sulfur coming out from their mouths, a third of men were killed"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [These three plagues of fire and of smoke and of sulfur coming out from their mouths killed a third of men]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 9:20 (#3)

ἃ οὔτε βλέπειν δύνανται, οὔτε ἀκούειν, οὔτε περιπατεῖν

"which are able neither to see nor to hear nor to walk"

The terms **see** and **hear** and **walk** all describe things that living beings are able to do. John is using the three terms together to emphasize that **idols** are not alive and cannot do anything for those who **worship** them. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [which are not alive at all]

See: Doublet

Revelation 9:20 (#1)

οἳ οὐκ ἀπεκτάνθησαν ἐν ταῖς πληγαῖς ταύταις

"the ones not killed in these plagues"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the ones whom these plagues did not kill]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 9:20 (#2)

ἐκ τῶν ἔργων τῶν χειρῶν αὐτῶν

"of the works of their hands"

John is using one part of these people, their **hands**, to represent all of each person in the act of doing **works**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [of the works they were doing]

See: Synecdoche

Revelation - Chapter 10 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

In this chapter John begins to describe a vision he had of a mighty angel holding a scroll. John is viewing what is happening from the perspective of earth, which is why he speaks of this angel "coming down from heaven." This vision takes place between the blowing of the sixth and seventh trumpets.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Seven thunders

In this chapter John describes seven thunders making sounds that he could understand as words. However, translators should use their normal word for "thunder" when translating these verses. (See: Personification; and Symbolic Prophecy)

"The mystery of God"

This refers to some aspect of the hidden plan of God. It is not necessary to know what this mystery is when translating this phrase.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Simile

In this chapter John uses similes to help him describe the face, legs, and voice of a mighty angel. Translators should represent other objects in this chapter, such as the rainbow and the cloud, with their normal meanings. (See: Simile)

Revelation 10:1 (#4)

οἱ πόδες αὐτοῦ

"his feet"

Since John compares the **feet** of the angel to **pillars**, it is likely that by **feet** he means "legs" by association. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his legs]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 10:1 (#2)

περιβεβλημένον νεφέλην

"clothed in a cloud"

John speaks of the angel as if he were wearing **a cloud** as his clothing. This expression could be understood as figurative. However, because very unusual things were often seen in visions, it could also be understood

as a literally true statement in its context. Alternate translation: [in the midst of a cloud]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 10:1 (#1)

περιβεβλημένον νεφέλην

"clothed in a cloud"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [whose clothing was a cloud]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 10:1 (#3)

καὶ τὸ πρόσωπον αὐτοῦ ὡς ὁ ἥλιος, καὶ οἱ πόδες αὐτοῦ ὡς στῦλοι πυρός

"and his face like the sun and his feet like pillars of fire"

The point of these comparisons is that the angel's **face** was very bright, like the **sun**, and that the angel's **feet** were glowing like **fire**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make these points explicitly. It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. Alternate translation: [The angel's face was very bright, like the sun, and his feet were glowing as if they were on fire]

See: Simile

Revelation 10:2 (#2)

τὸν δὲ εὐώνυμον

"and {his} left"

John is using the adjective **left** as a noun to mean a certain one of the angel's feet. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [and his left foot]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 10:2 (#1)

βιβλαρίδιον ἠνεῳγμένον

"an opened little scroll"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [a little scroll that he had opened]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 10:3 (#4)

ἐλάλησαν & τὰς ἑαυτῶν φωνάς

"spoke their own voices"

It might seem that the expression **spoke their own voices** contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [spoke]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Revelation 10:3 (#1)

φωνῇ μεγάλῃ ὥσπερ λέων μυκᾶται

"in a loud voice, as a lion roars"

The point of this comparison is probably that the **loud voice** of the angel commanded attention like the roar of a **lion**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [in a loud voice that commanded attention as does a lion's roar]

See: Simile

Revelation 10:3 (#2)

ἐλάλησαν αἱ ἑπτὰ βρονταὶ

"the seven thunders spoke"

John speaks of these **seven thunders** as if he assumes that his readers will know what or who they are, but he has not introduced or explained them earlier in the book and interpreters are not certain of their identity. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could introduce them in such a way as to indicate that John has not identified them previously. Alternate translation: [seven thunders spoke]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 10:3 (#3)

ἐλάλησαν αἱ ἑπτὰ βρονταὶ

"the seven thunders spoke"

This expression could mean that thunder **spoke** or sounded **seven** times, rather than that **seven** different **thunders spoke**. You could say that in your translation or indicate this possibility in a footnote. Alternate translation: [thunder spoke seven times] or [thunder sounded seven times]

See: Idiom

Revelation 10:4 (#1)

ἤμελλον γράφειν

“I was going to write”

The implication is that John was going to write down what the seven thunders had said. You can provide this information in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I was going to write down what they had said]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 10:4 (#2)

σφράγισον ἃ ἐλάλησαν αἱ ἑπτὰ βρονταί, καὶ μὴ αὐτὰ γράψῃς

“Seal what the seven thunders said and do not write it”

The voice spoke as if John should literally **seal** what the thunders said. However, since the voice then specified that John was not to write anything down, the voice meant that John should keep secret what the thunders said. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Keep secret what the seven thunders said by not writing it down]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 10:5 (#1)

ἦρεν τὴν χεῖρα αὐτοῦ τὴν δεξιὰν εἰς τὸν οὐρανόν

“raised his right hand to heaven”

The angel **raised his right hand to heaven** as a symbolic action to show that he was swearing an oath by God. If this would not be clear to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [raised his right hand to heaven to show that he swearing an oath by God]

See: Symbolic Action

Revelation 10:6 (#1)

τῷ ζῶντι εἰς τοὺς αἰῶνας τῶν αἰώνων

“by the one living to the ages of the ages”

John assumes that his readers will understand that the angel is referring to God with this expression. You can indicate that explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [by the eternal God]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 10:6 (#2)

εἰς τοὺς αἰῶνας τῶν αἰώνων

“to the ages of the ages”

This expression refers to endless future time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for all eternity]

See: Idiom

Revelation 10:6 (#3)

τὸν οὐρανὸν καὶ τὰ ἐν αὐτῷ, καὶ τὴν γῆν καὶ τὰ ἐν αὐτῇ, καὶ τὴν θάλασσαν καὶ τὰ ἐν αὐτῇ

“heaven and the {things} in it and the earth and the {things} in it and the sea and the {things} in it”

The angel is using the three parts of creation to mean all of creation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the entire creation]

See: Merism

Revelation 10:6 (#4)

χρόνος οὐκέτι

“no more time”

In this context, the word **time** means a delay. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [no further delay]

See: Idiom

Revelation 10:7 (#1)

ἀλλ’ ἐν ταῖς ἡμέραις τῆς φωνῆς τοῦ ἑβδόμου ἀγγέλου, ὅταν μέλλῃ σαλπίζειν

“but in the days of the sound of the seventh angel, when he is going to trumpet”

These two phrases mean similar things. The angel is using repetition to emphasize the idea that the phrases express. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them. Alternate translation: [but in the days when the seventh angel is going to sound a trumpet]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 10:7 (#4)

ἐτελέσθη τὸ μυστήριον τοῦ Θεοῦ

“the mystery of God will be accomplished”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God will accomplish his mystery]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 10:7 (#2)

τῆς φωνῆς τοῦ ἑβδόμου ἀγγέλου

"of the sound of the seventh angel"

This possessive form does not describe what the **seventh angel** sounds like. Instead, it describes a **sound** that the seventh angel will make. Alternate translation: [when the seventh angel makes a sound]

See: Possession

Revelation 10:7 (#3)

ἐν ταῖς ἡμέραις τῆς φωνῆς

"in the days of the sound"

The angel is using the term **days** idiomatically to refer to a specific time. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [at the time of the sound]

See: Idiom

Revelation 10:8 (#1)

τὸ βιβλίον τὸ ἠνεῳγμένον ἐν τῇ χειρὶ τοῦ ἀγγέλου, τοῦ ἑστῶτος ἐπὶ τῆς θαλάσσης καὶ ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς

"the opened scroll in the hand of the angel standing on the sea and on the land"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the scroll that the angel standing on the sea and on the land has opened and is holding in his hand]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 10:10 (#1)

ἐπικράνθη ἡ κοιλία μου

"my stomach was made bitter"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [it made my stomach bitter]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 10:11 (#1)

λέγουσίν μοι

"they said to me"

The pronoun **they** is an indefinite pronoun that does not have a specific referent in the immediate context. John is using this indefinite construction to focus on what he was told rather than on who told it to him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this with a different expression that does not use an indefinite pronoun. Alternate translation: [I was told]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 10:11 (#3)

λαοῖς, καὶ ἔθνεσιν, καὶ γλώσσαις, καὶ βασιλεῦσιν πολλοῖς

"many peoples and nations and languages and kings"

The angel is referring to speakers of various languages by association with the **languages** themselves, and John is referring to the subjects of various kingdoms by association with their **kings**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [many peoples and nations and speakers of many languages and subjects of many kingdoms]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 10:11 (#2)

λαοῖς, καὶ ἔθνεσιν, καὶ γλώσσαις, καὶ βασιλεῦσιν πολλοῖς

"many peoples and nations and languages and kings"

In this context, the terms **peoples**, **nations**, **languages**, and **kings** mean similar things. John is using the four terms together to make a comprehensive statement. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [every different people group]

See: Doublet

Revelation - Chapter 11 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Some translations set each line of poetry farther to the right than the rest of the text to make it easier to read. The ULT does this with verses 15 and 17–18.

Woes

In 8:13, an angel announced three "woes" that the people living on the earth would suffer. Chapter 9 described the first woe. This chapter describes a second one.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Gentiles

The word "Gentiles" here refers to ungodly people groups and not Gentile Christians. (See: godly, godliness, ungodly, godless, ungodliness, godlessness)

Two witnesses

This chapter describes two witnesses. Scholars have many different ideas about who they are. Translators do not need to understand their exact identities in order to translate this chapter accurately. (See: prophet, prophecy, prophesy, seer, prophetess)

Revelation 11:1 (#1)

ἐδόθη μοι κάλαμος ὅμοιος ῥάβδῳ λέγων

"a reed like a measuring rod was given to me, saying"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was Jesus, since the same person speaks of "my two witnesses" in verse 3. Alternate translation: [Jesus gave me a reed like a measuring rod and said]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 11:1 (#2)

κάλαμος ὅμοιος ῥάβδῳ

"a reed like a measuring rod"

The point of this comparison is that this **reed** was long and straight and John could use it to mark off distances as he could with a **measuring rod**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [a reed that was long and straight so that I could use it to mark off distances, as I could with a measuring rod]

See: Simile

Revelation 11:2 (#2)

τὴν αὐλὴν τὴν ἔξωθεν τοῦ ναοῦ, ἔκβαλε ἔξω

"cast out the courtyard outside the temple"

The person who is giving John these instructions is speaking as if John should literally **cast out** the courtyard, that is, fling it away through the air. He means that John should exclude the courtyard from his measurements. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [exclude the courtyard outside the temple]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 11:2 (#3)

ἐδόθη τοῖς ἔθνεσιν

"it has been given to the Gentiles"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God has given it to the Gentiles]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 11:2 (#4)

πόλιν τὴν ἁγίαν

"holy city"

The person speaking with John assumes that he will understand that by **the holy city** he means Jerusalem. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the city of Jerusalem]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 11:2 (#1)

τὴν αὐλὴν τὴν ἔξωθεν τοῦ ναοῦ, ἔκβαλε ἔξω καὶ μὴ αὐτὴν μετρήσῃς

"cast out the courtyard outside the temple and do not measure it"

These two phrases mean similar things. John is using repetition to emphasize the idea that the phrases express. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them. Alternate translation: [do not include the courtyard outside the temple in your measurements]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 11:3 (#2)

περιβεβλημένοι σάκκους

"clothed in sackcloth"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way

that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [wearing sackcloth]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 11:3 (#1)

δώσω

"I will grant"

The person speaking with John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [I will grant authority]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 11:3 (#3)

σάκκους

"in sackcloth"

See how you translated the word **sackcloth** in 6:12. These **witnesses** wore sackcloth while prophesying in order to show their sorrow and grief over the sins that people were committing against God. If this would not be clear to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [sackcloth to show their grief and sorrow over sin]

See: Symbolic Action

Revelation 11:4 (#2)

οὗτοί εἰσιν αἱ δύο ἐλαῖαι καὶ αἱ δύο λυχνίαι, αἱ ἐνώπιον τοῦ Κυρίου τῆς γῆς ἑστῶτες

"These are the two olive trees and the two lampstands that stand before the Lord of the earth"

John assumes that his readers will understand that he is alluding to the vision had by the prophet Zechariah, who saw **two olive trees** and **two lampstands** in Zechariah 4:2–6. In that vision, the trees and lampstands represented the governor, Zerubbabel, and the high priest, Joshua, who led the rebuilding of the temple despite opposition. In the same way, the two witnesses in John's vision will faithfully call people to obey God despite opposition. You could indicate that explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [These two witnesses will serve God faithfully despite opposition just as Zerubbabel and Joshua did, whom the prophet Zechariah saw depicted as two olive trees and two lampstands in a vision that God gave him]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 11:4 (#1)

οὗτοί εἰσιν αἱ δύο ἐλαῖαι καὶ αἱ δύο λυχνίαι, αἱ ἐνώπιον τοῦ Κυρίου τῆς γῆς ἑστῶτες

"These are the two olive trees and the two lampstands that stand before the Lord of the earth"

The **two olive trees** and the **two lampstands** symbolize these witnesses, but they are not literally the witnesses. Alternate translation: [The two olive trees and the two lampstands that stood before the Lord of the earth represent these witnesses]

See: Symbolic Language

Revelation 11:4 (#3)

αἱ ἐνώπιον & ἑστῶτες

"that stand before"

In this context, the phrase **stand before** means to stay in the presence of another person in order to serve them whenever needed. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who faithfully serve]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 11:5 (#4)

καὶ εἴ τις θελήσῃ αὐτοὺς ἀδικῆσαι, οὕτως δεῖ αὐτὸν ἀποκτανθῆναι

"and if anyone should wish to harm them, he must be killed in this way"

This clause is essentially a repetition of the first clause in the verse. John is speaking in something like Hebrew poetry, which was based on this kind of repetition. It would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if such repetition would not be natural in your language, you could connect the clauses with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second clause is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. Alternate translation: [Yes, if anyone should wish to harm them, he must be killed in this way]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 11:5 (#5)

δεῖ αὐτὸν ἀποκτανθῆναι

"he must be killed"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way

that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [he must die]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 11:5 (#3)

κατεσθίει τοὺς ἐχθροὺς αὐτῶν

“devours their enemies”

John is speaking as if **fire** literally **devours** or eats up anyone who would **wish to harm** these witnesses. He means that the fire destroys them completely. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [destroys their enemies completely]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 11:5 (#1)

πῦρ ἐκπορεύεται ἐκ τοῦ στόματος αὐτῶν

“fire comes out from their mouth”

In a context such as this, your language might say “goes” instead of **comes**. Alternate translation: [fire goes out from their mouth]

See: Go and Come

Revelation 11:5 (#2)

τοῦ στόματος αὐτῶν

“their mouth”

Since John is referring to two people, it might be more natural in your language to use the plural form of **mouth** or the dual form if your language has it. Alternate translation: [their mouths]

See: Collective Nouns

Revelation 11:6 (#2)

τὰς ἡμέρας

“during the days”

John is using the term **days** to refer to a specific time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [during the time]

See: Idiom

Revelation 11:6 (#1)

κλεῖσαι τὸν οὐρανόν, ἵνα μὴ ὑετὸς βρέχῃ

“to close up the sky so that no rain might fall”

John is speaking as if these witnesses could literally **close up** the sky. As he goes on to say, he means that they will be able to prevent it from raining. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to keep any rain from falling from the sky]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 11:7 (#1)

τὸ θηρίον τὸ ἀναβαῖνον ἐκ τῆς Ἀβύσσου

“the beast coming up from the abyss”

John describes this **beast** starting in 13:1, so you do not need to explain anything about it here.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Revelation 11:8 (#5)

ἐσταυρώθη

“was crucified”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [suffered crucifixion]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 11:8 (#2)

ἥτις καλεῖται πνευματικῶς

“which is spiritually called”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [which we may spiritually call]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 11:8 (#3)

ἥτις καλεῖται πνευματικῶς, Σόδομα καὶ Αἴγυπτος

“which is spiritually called Sodom and Egypt”

The point of these comparisons is that God once destroyed Jerusalem because its people were so wicked, like **Sodom**, and that Jerusalem oppressed people who belonged to God, like **Egypt**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [which God destroyed for wickedness as he destroyed Sodom and which oppressed God’s people as did Egypt]

See: Simile

Revelation 11:8 (#4)

ὁ Κύριος αὐτῶν

"their Lord"

John is referring to Jesus by a respectful title. Use a form for addressing someone respectfully in your language. Alternate translation: [their Lord Jesus]

See: Politeness

Revelation 11:8 (#1)

τῆς πόλεως τῆς μεγάλης

"of the great city"

John assumes that his readers will understand that by **the great city** he means Jerusalem. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Jerusalem]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 11:9 (#4)

τὰ πτώματα αὐτῶν οὐκ ἀφίουσιν τεθῆναι εἰς μνῆμα

"they do not permit their corpses to be placed in a tomb"

Leaving the **corpses** of the witnesses in the street, rather than burying them, is a symbolic action by which the people of Jerusalem show how much they hated the witnesses. If this would not be clear to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [out of hatred they do not permit anyone to place their corpses in a tomb]

See: Symbolic Action

Revelation 11:9 (#2)

βλέπουσιν ἐκ τῶν λαῶν, καὶ φυλῶν, καὶ γλωσσῶν, καὶ ἐθνῶν

"those from people and tribe and language and nation look at"

John is referring to speakers of various languages by association with the **language** that each one speaks. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those from different people groups and tribes, speakers of various languages, and those from other nations look at]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 11:9 (#3)

τὰ πτώματα αὐτῶν οὐκ ἀφίουσιν τεθῆναι εἰς μνῆμα

"they do not permit their corpses to be placed in a tomb"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [they do not permit anyone to place their corpses in a tomb]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 11:9 (#1)

βλέπουσιν ἐκ τῶν λαῶν, καὶ φυλῶν, καὶ γλωσσῶν, καὶ ἐθνῶν

"those from people and tribe and language and nation look at"

The terms **people**, **tribe**, **language**, and **nation** mean similar things. John is using the four terms together to make a comprehensive statement. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [those from many different people groups look at]

See: Doublet

Revelation 11:10 (#3)

δῶρα πέμψουσιν ἀλλήλοις

"send gifts to one another"

The people will **send gifts to one another** as a symbolic action to show how happy they are that the witnesses are dead. If this would not be clear to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [send gifts to one another to show how happy they are that the witnesses are dead]

See: Symbolic Action

Revelation 11:10 (#1)

καὶ οἱ κατοικοῦντες ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς χαίρουσιν ἐπ' αὐτοῖς, καὶ εὐφραίνονται, καὶ δῶρα πέμψουσιν ἀλλήλοις, ὅτι οὗτοι οἱ δύο προφῆται ἐβασάνισαν τοὺς κατοικοῦντας ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς

"And the ones living on the earth rejoice over them and celebrate and send gifts to one another, because these two prophets tormented the ones living on the earth"

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because these two prophets tormented the ones living on the

earth, the ones living on the earth rejoice over them and celebrate and send gifts to one another]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Revelation 11:10 (#2)

χαίρουσιν ἐπ' αὐτοῖς, καὶ εὐφραίνονται

"rejoice over them and celebrate"

The implication is that people **rejoice over** these witnesses because they are dead. You can provide this information in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [rejoice that they are dead, and they celebrate]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 11:11 (#3)

φόβος μέγας ἐπέπεσεν ἐπὶ τοὺς θεωροῦντας αὐτούς

"great fear fell on the ones seeing them"

John is speaking figuratively of **fear** as if it were a living thing that actively **fell** on people who saw the witnesses alive again. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the ones seeing them became greatly afraid]

See: Personification

Revelation 11:11 (#1)

πνεῦμα ζωῆς ἐκ τοῦ Θεοῦ εἰσῆλθεν εἰς αὐτούς

"a breath of life from God entered into them"

John is speaking of this **breath** as if it were a living thing that **entered into** the bodies of these witnesses on its own. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God enabled them to live and breathe again]

See: Personification

Revelation 11:11 (#2)

ἔστησαν ἐπὶ τοὺς πόδας αὐτῶν

"they stood on their feet"

It might seem that this expression contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [they stood up]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Revelation 11:12 (#1)

ἤκουσαν & αὐτοῖς & ἀνέβησαν & αὐτοὺς & αὐτῶν

"they heard & to them & they went up & their & them"

The pronouns **they**, **their** and **them** all refer to the witnesses, not to the people who were seeing them alive again. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the witnesses heard ... to them ... the witnesses went up ... their ... them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 11:12 (#2)

ἀνάβατε ὧδε

"Come up here"

Since the voice is speaking to two people, the implied "you" in the imperative **Come up** would be dual if your language uses that form. Otherwise, it would be plural.

See: Forms of 'You' — Dual/Plural

Revelation 11:13 (#2)

τὸ δέκατον τῆς πόλεως ἔπεσεν

"a tenth of the city fell"

John is not speaking of this **tenth of the city** as if it were a living thing that could fall down accidentally. He means that one **tenth** of the buildings in the city collapsed. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [one tenth of the buildings in the city collapsed]

See: Idiom

Revelation 11:13 (#4)

ὀνόματα ἀνθρώπων χιλιάδες ἑπτά

"the names of 7,000 men"

Here, **names** represents people by association with the way that each person has a name. Alternate translation: [seven thousand men]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 11:13 (#1)

ἐν ἐκείνῃ τῇ ὥρᾳ

"at that hour"

John is using the term **hour** to refer to a specific time. He does not mean that the earthquake lasted for a full hour. If it would be clearer in your language, you

could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [at that time]

See: Idiom

Revelation 11:13 (#3)

ἀπεκτάνθησαν ἐν τῷ σεισμῷ, ὀνόματα ἀνθρώπων χιλιάδες ἑπτά

"in the earthquake, the names of 7,000 men were killed"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the earthquake killed the names of seven thousand men]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 11:13 (#6)

ἔδωκαν δόξαν τῷ Θεῷ τοῦ οὐρανοῦ

"gave glory to the God of heaven"

This expression does not imply that God lacks glory in any way or that people have glory that they can give to God. It means the people in the city honored God, acknowledging that God was just to punish them with the earthquake for killing the two witnesses. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [honored the God of heaven] or [acknowledged that the God of heaven had done the right thing]

See: Idiom

Revelation 11:13 (#5)

ἀνθρώπων

"of & men"

Although the term **men** is masculine, John is using the word in a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use a term in your language that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [of people]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Revelation 11:14 (#1)

ἡ οὐαὶ ἡ δευτέρα ἀπῆλθεν

"The second woe has passed"

See how you translated "The first woe is past" in 9:12. Alternate translation: [The second terrible event is over]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 11:15 (#3)

ἐγένετο ἡ βασιλεία τοῦ κόσμου τοῦ Κυρίου ἡμῶν καὶ τοῦ Χριστοῦ αὐτοῦ

"The kingdom of the world has become {the kingdom} of our Lord and of his Christ"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of a **kingdom**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: (1) [Our Lord and his Christ will now rule in place of the world-wide system that formerly opposed them] or (2) [Our Lord and his Christ will now rule over all the people of the world]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 11:15 (#1)

ὁ ἕβδομος ἄγγελος

"the seventh angel"

If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you could use a cardinal number here or an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [angel number seven]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 11:15 (#2)

ἐγένετο ἡ βασιλεία τοῦ κόσμου τοῦ Κυρίου ἡμῶν καὶ τοῦ Χριστοῦ αὐτοῦ

"The kingdom of the world has become {the kingdom} of our Lord and of his Christ"

The kingdom of the world could mean: (1) the system of sinful interests and institutions all over the **world** that is opposed to God. Alternate translation: [The kingdom of our Lord and his Christ will now replace the world-wide system that formerly opposed them]; (2) the right to rule the people of the world. Alternate translation: [The kingdom of our Lord and his Christ will now include all the people in the world]

See: Idiom

Revelation 11:15 (#4)

εἰς τοὺς αἰῶνας τῶν αἰώνων

"to the ages of the ages"

This expression refers to endless future time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for all eternity]

See: Idiom

Revelation 11:16 (#2)

ἔπεσαν ἐπὶ τὰ πρόσωπα αὐτῶν

“fell upon their faces”

This expression means that the elders lay down facing the ground. See how you translated the similar expression in 7:11. Alternate translation: [bowed down to the ground]

See: Idiom

Revelation 11:16 (#1)

ἐνώπιον τοῦ Θεοῦ

“before God”

Here the word **before** means “in front of” or “in the presence of” another person. Alternate translation: [in the presence of God]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 11:17 (#1)

ὁ ὢν, καὶ ὁ ἦν

“the one being and the one having been”

Some ancient manuscripts read **the one being and the one having been**. ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts add “and who is to come.” If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Revelation 11:18 (#9)

τοὺς μικροὺς καὶ τοὺς μεγάλους

“the small and the great”

The elders are using two extremes of people, **small** and **great**, to mean them and everyone in between. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [whatever their status]

See: Merism

Revelation 11:18 (#4)

τῶν νεκρῶν κριθῆναι

“for the dead to be judged”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [for you to judge the dead]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 11:18 (#6)

τοῖς φοβουμένοις τὸ ὄνομά σου

“to the ones fearing your name”

Here, **name** represents a person by association with the way that each person has a name. Alternate translation: [the ones fearing you]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 11:18 (#1)

τὰ ἔθνη ὠργίσθησαν

“the nations were enraged”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the nations were furious]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 11:18 (#5)

τῶν νεκρῶν

“for the dead”

John is using the adjective **dead** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [people who have died]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 11:18 (#3)

ἦλθεν ἡ ὀργή σου, καὶ ὁ καιρὸς

“your wrath has come and the time”

John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [your wrath has come and the time has come]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 11:18 (#2)

ἦλθεν ἡ ὀργή σου, καὶ ὁ καιρὸς τῶν νεκρῶν κριθῆναι

“your wrath has come and the time for the dead to be judged”

John is speaking of God’s **wrath** as if it were a living thing that **has come** to the **nations**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you are now punishing them and judging the dead]

See: Personification

Revelation 11:18 (#7)

τοὺς μικροὺς καὶ τοὺς μεγάλους

“the small and the great”

The elders are speaking as if unimportant people were literally **small** and as if important people were literally large or **great**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the unimportant and the important]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 11:18 (#8)

τοὺς μικροὺς καὶ τοὺς μεγάλους

“the small and the great”

The elders are using the adjectives **small** and **great** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate these words with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [both unimportant people and important people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 11:19 (#2)

ἠνοίγη ὁ ναὸς τοῦ Θεοῦ ὁ ἐν τῷ οὐρανῷ

“the temple of God in heaven was opened”

By this expression, John likely means by association that in his vision, God created some opening that allowed him to see into **the temple of God in heaven**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God allowed me to look into his temple in heaven]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 11:19 (#1)

ἠνοίγη ὁ ναὸς τοῦ Θεοῦ ὁ ἐν τῷ οὐρανῷ, καὶ ὤφθη ἡ κιβωτὸς τῆς διαθήκης τοῦ Κυρίου ἐν τῷ ναῷ αὐτοῦ

“the temple of God in heaven was opened and the ark of the covenant of the Lord was seen in his temple”

If your language does not use these passive forms, you could express the ideas in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God opened his temple in heaven and I could see the ark of the covenant of the Lord in his temple]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation - Chapter 12 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Some translations set each line of poetry farther to the right than the rest of the text to make it easier to read. The ULT does this with verses 10–12.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Serpent

The book of Revelation uses imagery from the Old Testament. In this chapter, John refers to Satan as the serpent. This image comes from the account of the Garden of Eden when Satan tempted Eve. (See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information)

Revelation 12:1 (#2)

περιβεβλημένη τὸν ἥλιον

“clothed with the sun”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [whom the sun was clothing]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 12:1 (#1)

σημεῖον μέγα ὤφθη ἐν τῷ οὐρανῷ

“a great sign was seen in heaven”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [people saw a great sign in heaven]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 12:2 (#1)

ἐν γαστρὶ ἔχουσα

“having in the womb”

This expression means that the woman had a child in her **womb**, that is, she was pregnant. If it would be

helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [being pregnant]

See: Idiom

Revelation 12:2 (#2)

κράζει

"she cries out"

To call attention to a development in the story, here John uses the present tense in past narration. If it would not be natural to do that in your language, you could use the past tense in your translation. Alternate translation: [she cried out]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

Revelation 12:2 (#3)

ὠδίνουσα, καὶ βασανιζομένη τεκεῖν

"suffering birth pains and being tormented to give birth"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [suffering birth pains that tormented her as she gave birth]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 12:2 (#4)

ὠδίνουσα, καὶ βασανιζομένη

"suffering birth pains and being tormented"

These two phrases mean similar things. John is using them together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [suffering terrible birth pains]

See: Doublet

Revelation 12:3 (#2)

δράκων πυρρός μέγας

"a large red dragon"

A **dragon** is a mythical monster that looks like a giant reptile. As 12:9 explains, in this book the dragon represents the devil. If your readers would not be familiar with what a dragon is, you could use a general expression in your translation. Alternate translation: [a large red monster]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 12:3 (#1)

ὤφθη ἄλλο σημεῖον

"another sign was seen"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [people saw another sign]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 12:4 (#2)

τὸ τρίτον

"a third"

See how you translated this in 8:7. Alternate translation: [one third]

See: Fractions

Revelation 12:4 (#1)

σύρει

"sweeps away"

To call attention to a development in the story, here John uses the present tense in past narration. If it would not be natural to do that in your language, you could use the past tense in your translation. Alternate translation: [swept]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

Revelation 12:5 (#6)

πρὸς τὸν Θεὸν, καὶ πρὸς τὸν θρόνον αὐτοῦ

"to God and to his throne"

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two words connected with **and**. The word **God** tells whose **throne** this is. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase that does not use "and." Alternate translation: [to God's throne]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 12:5 (#4)

ῥάβδῳ σιδηρᾷ

"an iron scepter"

A **scepter** was an ornamental staff or wand that rulers carried or held as a symbol of their authority. If your readers would not be familiar with what a scepter is, in your translation you could use the name of a comparable object in your culture or you could use a general

expression. Alternate translation: [a royal staff made of iron]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 12:5 (#3)

ἐν ῥάβδῳ σιδηρᾷ

“with an iron scepter”

John is speaking as if this child will literally use **an iron scepter** to **rule all the nations**. He means that the child will rule with great strength by association with the way that **iron** is very strong. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. See how you translated the similar phrase in 2:27. Alternate translation: [with great strength] or [with irresistible power]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 12:5 (#1)

υἱόν ἄρρενα

“a son, a male”

The terms **son** and **male** mean similar things. John is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [a boy]

See: Doublet

Revelation 12:5 (#2)

ἄρρενα

“a male”

John is using the adjective **male** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [a male child]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 12:5 (#5)

ἡρπάσθη τὸ τέκνον αὐτῆς πρὸς τὸν Θεὸν, καὶ πρὸς τὸν θρόνον αὐτοῦ

“her child was snatched away to God and to his throne”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God snatched away her child to his throne]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 12:6 (#2)

ὅπου ἔχει ἐκεῖ τόπον ἡτοιμασμένον ἀπὸ τοῦ Θεοῦ

“where she has a place prepared by God there”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [where God has prepared a place for her]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 12:6 (#3)

τρέφωσιν αὐτὴν

“they might nourish her”

The pronoun **they** is an indefinite pronoun that does not refer to anyone in the immediate context. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this with a different expression that does not use an indefinite pronoun. Alternate translation: [she might receive nourishment]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 12:6 (#1)

ὅπου ἔχει ἐκεῖ τόπον ἡτοιμασμένον ἀπὸ τοῦ Θεοῦ

“where she has a place prepared by God there”

It might seem that this expression, which says both **where** and **there**, contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [where she has a place prepared by God]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Revelation 12:8 (#2)

οὐκ ἴσχυσαν

“he was not strong enough”

John means by association that the dragon was **not strong enough** to prevail against Michael and his army. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he was not able to prevail]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 12:8 (#1)

οὐκ ἴσχυσαν

“he was not strong enough”

The pronoun **he** refers to the dragon, not to Michael. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the dragon was not strong enough]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 12:8 (#3)

τόπος εὑρέθη αὐτῶν

“was a place found for them”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [could anyone find a place for them]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 12:9 (#4)

ὁ καλούμενος

“called”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [whom people call]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 12:9 (#6)

ὁ Σατανᾶς

“Satan”

The word **Satan** is a Hebrew name that means “accuser.” So his readers will know how it sounds, John spells it out using Greek letters after giving the Greek equivalent, **Diabolos**, so that his readers will know what it means. In your translation you could spell **Satan** the way it sounds in your language and use the word for “accuser” in your own language in place of **Diabolos** so that your readers will know what it means.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Revelation 12:9 (#1)

ἐβλήθη ὁ δράκων ὁ μέγας

“the great dragon was thrown down”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. This could mean: (1) that God threw the dragon down after his angels defeated him. Alternate translation: [God threw down the dragon]; (2) that Michael threw the dragon down to earth after defeating him in the war that they fought. Alternate translation: [Michael threw down the dragon]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 12:9 (#7)

τὴν οἰκουμένην ὅλην

“the whole world”

Here the term **world** refers to the people who live in the world. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all the people of the world]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 12:9 (#2)

ὁ ὄφις ὁ ἀρχαῖος, ὁ καλούμενος

“the ancient serpent called”

John assumes that his readers will understand that he is alluding to the way the devil appeared in the form of a **serpent** when he tempted Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden. This story is told in Genesis 3:1–15. You can include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [who tempted Adam and Eve in the form of a serpent, who is called]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 12:9 (#8)

ἐβλήθη εἰς τὴν γῆν, καὶ οἱ ἄγγελοι αὐτοῦ μετ’ αὐτοῦ ἐβλήθησαν

“He was thrown down to the earth and his angels were thrown down with him”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. This could mean: (1) that God threw the dragon down after his angels defeated him. Alternate translation: [God threw the dragon down to the earth and he threw his angels down with him]; (2) that Michael threw the dragon and his angels down to earth after defeating them in the war that they fought. Alternate translation: [Michael threw the dragon down to the earth and he threw his angels down with him]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 12:9 (#3)

ὁ ὄφις ὁ ἀρχαῖος

“the ancient serpent”

A **serpent** is the same animal that is also called a “snake.” It is a reptile that has no legs and so slithers along the ground. If your readers would not be familiar with what a serpent or snake is, you could use a general expression. Alternate translation: [that ancient slithering reptile]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 12:9 (#5)

Διάβολος

“Diabolos”

The word **Diabolos** is a name for the devil. Diabolos means “accuser” in Greek.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 12:10 (#3)

ἡμῶν & ἡμῶν & ἡμῶν

“our & our & our”

This **voice** is addressing believers, since he refers to **our brothers**, so by **our** in each instance, the person speaking means himself and his addressees. So use the exclusive form of that word in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Exclusive and Inclusive ‘We’

Revelation 12:10 (#5)

τῶν ἀδελφῶν ἡμῶν

“of our brothers”

John is using the term **brothers** figuratively to mean people who share the same faith. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation, as in UST: [of our fellow believers]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 12:10 (#4)

ἐβλήθη ὁ κατήγορος τῶν ἀδελφῶν ἡμῶν

“the accuser of our brothers has been thrown down”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God has thrown down the accuser of our brothers]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 12:10 (#6)

τῶν ἀδελφῶν ἡμῶν

“of our brothers”

Although the term **brothers** is masculine, here the word has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If you wish to retain the figurative expression in your translation, you could word it in a way that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [our brothers and sisters]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Revelation 12:10 (#7)

ἡμέρας καὶ νυκτός

“day and night”

The voice is using the two parts of a full day, **day** and **night**, to mean all the time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all the time]

See: Merism

Revelation 12:10 (#1)

ἤκουσα φωνὴν μεγάλην ἐν τῷ οὐρανῷ λέγουσαν

“I heard a loud voice in heaven saying”

John is referring to someone speaking by association with the **voice** that the person is using to speak. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I heard someone saying loudly from heaven]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 12:10 (#2)

ἄρτι ἐγένετο ἡ σωτηρία, καὶ ἡ δύναμις, καὶ ἡ Βασιλεία τοῦ Θεοῦ ἡμῶν, καὶ ἡ ἐξουσία τοῦ Χριστοῦ αὐτοῦ

“Now have come the salvation and the power and the kingdom of our God, and the authority of his Christ”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **salvation**, **power**, **kingdom**, and **authority**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. It may be helpful to make this more than one sentence. Alternate translation: [Now our God has begun to save people. He has acted powerfully to establish his reign. His Christ is reigning with him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 12:11 (#1)

τὸ αἷμα

“the blood”

This could mean: (1) the actual **blood** that Jesus offered as a sacrifice for sin. In that case, you could use the word for “blood” in your language with literal meaning. (2) the sacrificial death of Jesus by association with the **blood** that Jesus shed when he died. Alternate translation: [the sacrificial death]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 12:11 (#3)

τὸν λόγον τῆς μαρτυρίας αὐτῶν

“the word of their testimony”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **word**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [by what they said when they testified to others about Jesus]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 12:11 (#2)

τὸν λόγον τῆς μαρτυρίας αὐτῶν

“the word of their testimony”

The voice is using the term **word** to indicate that these believers gave their **testimony** to Jesus by speaking words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the testimony that they spoke]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 12:11 (#4)

οὐκ ἠγάπησαν τὴν ψυχὴν αὐτῶν ἄχρι θανάτου

“they did not love their lives unto death”

This expression means that these believers did not **love their lives** so much they would refuse **death** even if they needed to die in order to remain faithful to Jesus. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they did not love their lives so much that they would not die for Jesus]

See: Idiom

Revelation 12:12 (#2)

οὐαὶ τὴν γῆν καὶ τὴν θάλασσαν

“Woe to the earth and the sea”

The voice is speaking of the **earth** and the **sea** as if they were living things that could suffer **Woe**. This may be something that readers could understand literally within the world of this vision. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could state the meaning differently. Alternate translation: [Woe to all the creatures who live on the earth and in the sea]

See: Personification

Revelation 12:12 (#1)

εὐφραίνεσθε οὐρανοὶ, καὶ οἱ ἐν αὐτοῖς σκηνοῦντες

“rejoice, heavens, and the ones dwelling in them”

The voice is speaking to the **heavens** as if they were a living thing that could **rejoice**. This may be something that readers could understand literally within the world of this vision. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could state the meaning differently. Alternate translation: [all of you who live in the heavens, rejoice in a way that can be heard throughout the heavens]

See: Personification

Revelation 12:12 (#3)

ὀλίγον καιρὸν ἔχει

“he has little time”

The voice implicitly means that the devil knows that God will soon judge and punish him, and so he has **little time** left in which to resist God and try to turn people away from God. You can provide this information in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [he has little time left in which to keep resisting God]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 12:13 (#2)

τὸν ἄρσενα

“the male”

John is using the adjective **male** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the male child]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 12:13 (#1)

ἐβλήθη

“he had been thrown down”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God had thrown him down]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 12:14 (#3)

καιρὸν, καὶ καιροὺς, καὶ ἥμισυ καιροῦ

“for a time and times and half a time”

Since the vision describes the approximate number of days in three and a half years (1,260) in 12:6 and the number of months in three and a half years (42) in 13:5, it is probable that this number is also three and a half, so **times** means “two times.” If your language uses the dual form, you could use that form for the word **times**. Otherwise, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for a time and two times and half a time]

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Dual/Plural

Revelation 12:14 (#1)

ἐδόθησαν τῇ γυναικὶ δύο πτέρυγες τοῦ ἀετοῦ τοῦ μεγάλου

“two wings of a great eagle were given to the woman”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God gave two wings of a great eagle to the woman]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 12:14 (#5)

προσώπου τοῦ ὄφεως

“the face of the serpent”

Here the word **face** represents the presence of a person by association with the way people can see the face of someone who is present. Alternate translation: [the presence of the serpent]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 12:14 (#2)

ὅπου τρέφεται ἐκεῖ

“where she is nourished there”

It might seem that this expression, which says both **where** and **there**, contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [where she is nourished]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Revelation 12:14 (#4)

καιρὸν, καὶ καιροὺς, καὶ ἥμισυ καιροῦ

“for a time and times and half a time”

Since this length of time during which the woman is **nourished** seems to be the same as in 12:6, it seems that three and a half years is intended. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could say that explicitly. Alternate translation: [for a year and two years and half a year] or [for three and a half years]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 12:15 (#1)

ὕδωρ ὡς ποταμόν

“water like a river”

John says that this **water** was **like a river** to emphasize how much water there was. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a very large volume of water]

See: Simile

Revelation 12:15 (#2)

ἵνα αὐτὴν ποταμοφόρητον ποιήσῃ

“so that he might make her stream-borne”

Alternate translation: [in order to create a flood that would carry her away]

Revelation 12:16 (#2)

ἤνοιξεν ἡ γῆ τὸ στόμα αὐτῆς

“the earth opened its mouth”

John is speaking as if the earth literally had a **mouth** and **swallowed** this **river**. He means that some kind of chasm opened up in the earth and the river flowed down into it. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a chasm opened up in the earth and the river flowed down into it]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 12:16 (#1)

ἐβοήθησεν ἡ γῆ τῇ γυναικί

"the earth helped the woman"

John is speaking of **the earth** as if it were a living thing that **helped** this **woman**. This may be something that readers could understand literally within the world of this vision. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could state the meaning differently. Alternate translation: [something happened on the earth that helped the woman]

See: Personification

Revelation 12:17 (#4)

ἐχόντων τὴν μαρτυρίαν Ἰησοῦ

"having the testimony of Jesus"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **testimony**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [testifying to their faith in Jesus]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 12:17 (#3)

τηρούντων

"keeping"

See how you translated the word **keeping** in 1:3 and in 2:26. Alternate translation: [obeying]

See: Idiom

Revelation 12:17 (#1)

ὠργίσθη ὁ δράκων

"the dragon was enraged"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [this put the dragon in a rage]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 12:17 (#2)

τοῦ σπέρματος αὐτῆς

"of her seed"

Here the term **seed** means offspring. It is a word picture. Just as plants produce seeds that grow into many more plants, so people can have many offspring. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [of her descendants]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 12:18 (#1)

καὶ ἐστάθη ἐπὶ τὴν ἄμμον τῆς θαλάσσης

"And he stood on the sand of the sea"

Some versions number this verse as the first verse of chapter 13. You may want to number the verses according to the main version that your language group uses.

Revelation 12:18 (#2)

τὴν ἄμμον τῆς θαλάσσης

"the sand of the sea"

John is referring to the shore of the sea by association with the sand that is along the shore on the beach. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the shore of the sea]

See: Metonymy

Revelation - Chapter 13 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Some translations set each line of poetry farther to the right than the rest of the text to make it easier to read. The ULT does this with the words of verse 10, which are from the Old Testament.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Similes

John uses many similes in this chapter. They help to describe the images that he sees in his vision. (See: Simile)

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Leopard, bear, and lion

The book of Revelation uses imagery from the Old Testament. In this chapter, John describes a beast that looked like a leopard, a bear, and a lion. This image comes from the book of Daniel. (See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information)

Unknown animals

John uses different animals to try to describe what he saw. Some of these animals may not be known in the target language. (See: Translate Unknowns)

Revelation 13:2 (#1)

παρδάλει & ἄρκου & λέοντος

“a leopard & of a bear & of a lion”

A **leopard** is a large, fierce cat that lives in the jungle. A **bear** is a large, heavy, powerful mammal that can be very dangerous if it feels threatened. A **lion** is a large, fierce cat that often lives on the plains. If your readers would not be familiar with these animals, in your translation you could the names of comparable animals that they would recognize, or you could use general descriptions.

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 13:2 (#3)

τὴν δύναμιν αὐτοῦ, καὶ τὸν θρόνον αὐτοῦ

“his power and his throne”

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two words connected with **and**. The word **throne** tells what kind of **power** the dragon gave to this beast. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase that does not use “and.” Alternate translation: [his ruling power] or [his power to rule]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 13:2 (#2)

τὴν δύναμιν αὐτοῦ, καὶ τὸν θρόνον αὐτοῦ

“his power and his throne”

John is referring to the dragon’s right to rule by association with the **throne** on which a ruler would sit. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his power and his right to rule]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 13:3 (#7)

ὀπίσω τοῦ θηρίου

“after the beast”

John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and they followed after the beast] or, if you retain the term **earth**, [and it followed after the beast]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 13:3 (#8)

ὀπίσω τοῦ θηρίου

“after the beast”

This expression, which is short for “followed after the beast,” means that the people on earth accepted the beast as their ruler. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they accepted the beast as their ruler] or, if you retain the term **earth**, [and it accepted the beast as its ruler]

See: Idiom

Revelation 13:3 (#6)

ὅλη ἡ γῆ

“the whole earth”

Here the term **earth** refers to the people who live on the earth. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all the people on earth]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 13:3 (#3)

ἡ πληγὴ τοῦ θανάτου αὐτοῦ ἐθεραπεύθη

“its wound of death had been healed”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [it had recovered from its wound of death]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 13:3 (#2)

ἐσφαγμένην εἰς θάνατον

“it had been slain unto death”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [someone had slain it]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 13:3 (#5)

ἐθαυμάσθη ὅλη ἡ γῆ

“the whole earth was astonished”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way

that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [this astonished the whole earth]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 13:3 (#1)

ἐσφαγμένην εἰς θάνατον

“it had been slain unto death”

It might seem that the expression **slain unto death** contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [it had been slain]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Revelation 13:3 (#4)

ἡ πληγὴ τοῦ θανάτου

“wound of death”

John is using a possessive form to describe a **wound** that led to **death**. Alternate translation: [deadly wound]

See: Possession

Revelation 13:4 (#2)

τίς ὅμοιος τῷ θηρίῳ, καὶ τίς δύναται πολεμῆσαι μετ’ αὐτοῦ

“Who {is} like the beast, and who is able to war with it”

These two phrases mean similar things. The people are using repetition to emphasize the idea that the phrases express. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them. Alternate translation: [Who is strong enough to war with the beast?] or [No one is strong enough to war with the beast!]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 13:4 (#1)

τίς ὅμοιος τῷ θηρίῳ, καὶ τίς δύναται πολεμῆσαι μετ’ αὐτοῦ

“Who {is} like the beast, and who is able to war with it”

The people of the earth are using the question form for emphasis. If you would not use the question form for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [No one is like the beast, and no one is able to war with it!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Revelation 13:5 (#4)

ἐδόθη αὐτῷ ἐξουσία

“authority was given to it”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was the dragon. Alternate translation: [the dragon gave it authority]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 13:5 (#2)

στόμα λαλοῦν

“a mouth speaking”

John is referring to the capacity to speak by association with the **mouth** that people use to speak. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the capacity to speak, and it spoke]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 13:5 (#1)

ἐδόθη αὐτῷ

“to it was given”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was the dragon. Alternate translation: [the dragon gave it]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 13:5 (#3)

μεγάλα

“great {things”

The implication is that the beast spoke **great things** about itself. You can provide this information in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [great things about itself] or [boasts]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 13:6 (#1)

ἤνοιξε τὸ στόμα αὐτοῦ εἰς

“it opened its mouth unto”

John is referring to the beast speaking by association with **it opened its mouth** in order to speak. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [it spoke]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 13:6 (#2)

τὸ ὄνομα αὐτοῦ

“his name”

Here the word **name** stands for the reputation of a person. Alternate translation: [his reputation]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 13:7 (#2)

ἐδόθη αὐτῷ ἐξουσία

“authority was given to it”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was the dragon. Alternate translation: [the dragon gave it authority]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 13:7 (#3)

πᾶσαν φυλὴν, καὶ λαὸν, καὶ γλῶσσαν, καὶ ἔθνος

“every tribe and people and language and nation”

The terms **tribe**, **people**, **language**, and **nation** mean similar things. John is using the four terms together to make a comprehensive statement. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [every different people group]

See: Doublet

Revelation 13:7 (#1)

ἐδόθη αὐτῷ

“to it was granted”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. This could mean: (1) that the dragon enabled the beast to do this. Alternate translation: [the dragon enabled it]; (2) that God allowed the beast to do this. Alternate translation: [God allowed it]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 13:7 (#4)

πᾶσαν φυλὴν, καὶ λαὸν, καὶ γλῶσσαν, καὶ ἔθνος

“every tribe and people and language and nation”

John is referring to speakers of various languages by association with the **languages** themselves. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [every tribe and people and speakers of every language and every nation]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 13:8 (#3)

ὧν οὐ γέγραπται τὸ ὄνομα αὐτοῦ

“of whom his name has not been written”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [those whose names God has not written]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 13:8 (#1)

ὧν οὐ γέγραπται τὸ ὄνομα αὐτοῦ ἐν τῷ βιβλίῳ τῆς ζωῆς τοῦ Ἀρνίου, τοῦ ἐσφαγμένου ἀπὸ καταβολῆς κόσμου

“of whom his name has not been written in the Book of Life of the Lamb having been slain from the foundation of the world”

This could mean implicitly: (1) that the Lamb was slain from the foundation of the world, that is, God’s purpose from before all time was for Jesus to give his life as a sacrifice. Alternate translation: [all whose names are not written in the Book of Life that belongs to the Lamb whom God appointed from the foundation of the world to die as a sacrifice]; (2) that if a person worships the beast, this means that his name was not written in the Book of Life ... from the foundation of the world. Alternate translation: [all whose names have not been written in the Book of Life of the Lamb having been slain from the foundation of the world]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 13:8 (#2)

ὧν οὐ γέγραπται τὸ ὄνομα αὐτοῦ

"of whom his name has not been written"

Since John is referring to a group of people, it might be more natural in your language to use the plural form of **name**. Alternate translation: [those whose names have not been written]

See: Collective Nouns

Revelation 13:8 (#4)

τοῦ ἐσφαγμένου

"having been slain"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [whom God appointed to die as a sacrifice]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 13:8 (#5)

ἀπὸ καταβολῆς κόσμου

"from the foundation of the world"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **foundation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [since God founded the world]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 13:9 (#2)

εἴ τις ἔχει οὖς

"If anyone has an ear"

John is referring to the ability to hear by association with the way having an **ear** enables people to hear. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [If anyone is able to hear]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 13:9 (#3)

ἀκουσάτω

"let him hear"

If your language does not use the third-person imperative in this way, you could state this in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [may he hear] or [he should hear]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Revelation 13:9 (#1)

εἴ τις ἔχει οὖς, ἀκουσάτω

"If anyone has an ear, let him hear"

John is addressing his listeners in the third person. It may be clearer in your language to use the second person. Alternate translation: [If any of you has an ear, you should hear]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Revelation 13:10 (#1)

εἴ τις εἰς αἰχμαλωσίαν

"If anyone {is} for captivity"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **captivity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [If anyone's enemies are going to take him captive]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 13:10 (#5)

ὧδέ ἐστιν ἡ ὑπομονὴ καὶ ἡ πίστις τῶν ἁγίων

"Here is the endurance and the faith of the saints"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **endurance** and **faith**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [This calls for the saints to endure and to be faithful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 13:10 (#4)

ὧδέ ἐστιν ἡ ὑπομονὴ καὶ ἡ πίστις τῶν ἁγίων

"Here is the endurance and the faith of the saints"

The expression **Here is** introduces something that the speaker is calling for. Alternate translation: [This calls for endurance and faith on the part of the saints]

See: Idiom

Revelation 13:10 (#2)

εἴ τις ἐν μαχαίρῃ ἀποκτενεῖ, δεῖ αὐτὸν ἐν μαχαίρῃ ἀποκτανθῆναι

"if anyone will be killed by the sword, it is necessary for him to be killed by the sword"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [if anyone's enemies will kill him by the sword, it is necessary for them to kill him by the sword]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 13:10 (#3)

εἴ τις ἐν μαχαίρῃ ἀποκτενεῖ, δεῖ αὐτὸν ἐν μαχαίρῃ ἀποκτανθῆναι

"if anyone will be killed by the sword, it is necessary for him to be killed by the sword"

John is referring to execution by association with the way the Romans used a **sword** to execute people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [if anyone will be executed, it is necessary for him to be executed] or [if anyone's enemies will execute him, it is necessary for them to execute him]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 13:11 (#1)

ἐλάλει ὡς δράκων

"it was speaking like a dragon"

The point of this comparison is that this beast was **speaking** in a way that showed it was evil, like the dragon that is a symbol of evil in this book. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [it was speaking in a way that showed it was evil, like a dragon]

See: Simile

Revelation 13:12 (#1)

ἐνώπιον αὐτοῦ

"before it"

Here the word **before** means "in front of" or "in the presence of" another person. Alternate translation: [in its presence]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 13:12 (#2)

οὗ ἐθεραπεύθη ἡ πληγὴ τοῦ θανάτου αὐτοῦ

"of whom his wound of death had been healed"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [who had recovered from his wound of death]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 13:12 (#3)

ἡ πληγὴ τοῦ θανάτου

"wound of death"

John is using a possessive form to describe a **wound** that led to **death**. Alternate translation: [deadly wound]

See: Possession

Revelation 13:13 (#3)

τῶν ἀνθρώπων

"men"

Although the term **man** is masculine, John is using the word in a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use a term in your language that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [people]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Revelation 13:13 (#2)

ἐνώπιον τῶν ἀνθρώπων

"before men"

The term **before** here means "in front of." Alternate translation: [in front of men] or [where men could see them]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 13:13 (#1)

σημεῖα

"signs"

John is not using the word **signs** here and in the next verse to mean the same thing that he does when he speaks of signs in 12:1 and 12:3. Here he does not mean significant sights, but miracles. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [miracles]

See: Idiom

Revelation 13:14 (#1)

τὰ σημεῖα ἃ ἐδόθη αὐτῷ ποιῆσαι

"the signs that have been granted to it to do"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was

the dragon. Alternate translation: [the signs that the dragon has granted it to do]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 13:14 (#3)

τῷ θηρίῳ

“to the beast”

While John says in the next verse that this was an image “of the beast,” that is, an image that looked like the beast, here the expression **to the beast** means “in honor of the beast.” You can provide this information in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [in honor of the beast]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 13:14 (#2)

ἐνώπιον τοῦ θηρίου

“before the beast”

Here the word **before** means “in front of” or “in the presence of” another person. Alternate translation: [in the presence of the beast]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 13:15 (#2)

δοῦναι πνεῦμα τῇ εἰκόνι τοῦ θηρίου

“to give breath to the image of the beast”

John is referring to the **image of the beast** coming alive by association with the **breath** that creatures breathe when they are alive. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to make the image of the beast come alive]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 13:15 (#1)

ἐδόθη αὐτῷ

“it was granted to it”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was the dragon. Alternate translation: [the dragon enabled it]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 13:15 (#3)

ποιήσῃ ὅσοι ἐὰν μὴ προσκυνήσωσιν τῇ εἰκόνι τοῦ θηρίου ἀποκτανθῶσιν

“might cause whoever does not worship the image of the beast to be killed”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [might cause people to kill whoever does not worship the image of the beast]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 13:16 (#2)

τοὺς μικροὺς καὶ τοὺς μεγάλους, καὶ τοὺς πλουσίους καὶ τοὺς πτωχούς, καὶ τοὺς ἐλευθέρους καὶ τοὺς δούλους

“the small and the great and the rich and the poor and the free and the slave”

John is using the adjectives **small**, **great**, **rich**, **poor**, **free**, and **slave** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate these words with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [small people and great people and rich people and poor people and free people and slaves]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 13:16 (#5)

τοὺς μικροὺς καὶ τοὺς μεγάλους

“the small and the great”

John is speaking as if unimportant people were literally **small** and as if important people were literally large or **great**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the unimportant and the important] or [unimportant people and important people]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 13:16 (#3)

τοὺς μικροὺς καὶ τοὺς μεγάλους, καὶ τοὺς πλουσίους καὶ τοὺς πτωχούς, καὶ τοὺς ἐλευθέρους καὶ τοὺς δούλους

“the small and the great and the rich and the poor and the free and the slave”

John is using two extremes of importance, **small** and **great**, to mean people across the entire range of importance. John is using two extremes of wealth,

rich and **poor**, to mean people across the entire range of wealth. John is using two extremes of status, **free** and **slave**, to mean people across the entire range of status. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use equivalent expressions or plain language. Alternate translation: [no matter what their importance and no matter what their wealth and no matter what their status]

See: Merism

Revelation 13:16 (#4)

τοὺς μικροὺς καὶ τοὺς μεγάλους, καὶ τοὺς πλουσίους καὶ τοὺς πτωχούς, καὶ τοὺς ἐλευθέρους καὶ τοὺς δούλους

"the small and the great and the rich and the poor and the free and the slave"

These three phrases mean similar things. John is using repetition to emphasize the idea that the phrases express. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them. Alternate translation: [people of every different kind]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 13:16 (#6)

δῶσιν αὐτοῖς

"they might give to them"

The pronoun **they** is an indefinite pronoun that does not refer to anyone in the immediate context. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this with a different expression that does not use an indefinite pronoun. Alternate translation: [they might have to receive]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 13:16 (#1)

ποιεῖ

"it causes"

The pronoun **it** refers to the second beast, not to the image of the first beast. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the second beast causes]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 13:17 (#1)

τὸν ἀριθμὸν τοῦ ὀνόματος αὐτοῦ

"the number of its name"

In this culture, people used the letters of the alphabet as symbols for numbers as well. As a result, it was possible to add up the values of the letters in someone's name to get the **number** of that **name**. That is what John means implicitly here. If your readers would not be familiar with this practice, you could explain it in your translation. Alternate translation: [the sum of the numerical values of the letters in its name]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 13:18 (#3)

τὸν ἀριθμὸν τοῦ θηρίου

"the number of the beast"

See the note about "the number of its name" in 13:17. Here John means implicitly that this number is the sum of the numerical values of the letters in the name of a certain man. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could say that explicitly. Alternate translation: [the sum of the numerical values of the letters in the name of a certain man]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 13:18 (#2)

ψηφισάτω

"let him calculate"

If your language does not use the third-person imperative in this way, you could state this in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [may he calculate] or [he should calculate]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Revelation 13:18 (#1)

ὧδε ἡ σοφία ἐστίν

"Here is wisdom"

The expression **Here is** introduces something that the speaker is calling for. Alternate translation: [This calls for wisdom]

See: Idiom

Revelation - Chapter 14 Introduction

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Harvest
Harvest is when people go out to gather ripe food from plants. Jesus used this as a metaphor to teach his followers that they need to go and tell other people about him so those people can be part of God's kingdom. This chapter speaks symbolically of two harvests.

The first is a harvest of grain. This may mean the time when Jesus gathers in his people from the whole earth. The second harvest is of grapes. This may mean the time when God gathers in wicked people to punish them. (See: Metaphor; and faith)

Revelation 14:1 (#2)

ἑκατὸν τεσσεράκοντα τέσσαρες χιλιάδες

"were} 144 thousands"

See how you translated this in Revelation 7:4. Alternate translation: [one hundred forty-four thousand]

See: Numbers

Revelation 14:1 (#1)

τὸ Ὄρος Σιών

"Mount Zion"

The word **Zion** is the name of the mountain on which the city of Jerusalem is located.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 14:1 (#4)

τοῦ Πατρὸς

"of & Father"

Father is an important title that describes the relationship between God and Jesus. Be sure to retain this title in your translation.

See: Translating Son and Father

Revelation 14:1 (#3)

ἔχουσαι τὸ ὄνομα αὐτοῦ, καὶ τὸ ὄνομα τοῦ Πατρὸς αὐτοῦ, γεγραμμένον ἐπὶ τῶν μετώπων αὐτῶν

"having his name and the name of his Father written on their foreheads"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. Alternate translation: [His name and the name of his Father appeared in writing on their foreheads]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 14:2 (#4)

ὡς κιθαρῳδῶν κιθαριζόντων ἐν ταῖς κιθάραις αὐτῶν

"was} like harpists harping on their harps"

John's repetitive use of three words with the root "harp" seems to imitate the sound of music. You may wish to use three similar words in your translation if that is possible in your language.

See: Poetry

Revelation 14:2 (#3)

ὡς κιθαρῳδῶν κιθαριζόντων ἐν ταῖς κιθάραις αὐτῶν

"was} like harpists harping on their harps"

The point of this comparison is that the **sound** that John **heard** was also beautiful and melodious. (John explains in the next verse that it was the sound of a great number of people singing.) If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [beautiful and melodious, like harpists harping on their harps]

See: Simile

Revelation 14:2 (#2)

ὑδάτων πολλῶν

"of many waters"

By **sound of many waters**, John could mean a loud waterfall or raging floodwaters. See how you translated the similar expression in 1:15. Alternate translation: [of a waterfall] or [of raging floodwaters]

See: Idiom

Revelation 14:2 (#1)

ὡς φωνὴν ὑδάτων πολλῶν, καὶ ὡς φωνὴν βροντῆς μεγάλης

"like the sound of many waters and like the sound of great thunder"

The point of these comparisons is that the **sound** John **heard** was loud and powerful. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [that was loud and powerful, like the sound of many waters and like the sound of booming thunder]

See: Simile

Revelation 14:3 (#1)

ᾄδουσιν

"they sing"

The pronoun **they** refers to the **144 thousands** whom John describes in 14:1 and later in this verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate

translation: [the 144 thousands sing] or [the 144,000 people sing]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 14:3 (#4)

οἱ ἠγορασμένοι

“having been bought”

John is speaking as if the Lamb literally **bought** these people. He means that through his sacrificial death, the Lamb saved them by setting them free from the guilt and power of sin. Your language may have a term that you can use in your translation that describes someone paying a price or making a sacrifice to set someone else free. See what you did in 5:9. Alternate translation: [whom the Lamb redeemed]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 14:3 (#3)

οἱ ἠγορασμένοι

“having been bought”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, 5:9 indicates that it was the Lamb. Alternate translation: [whom the Lamb bought]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 14:3 (#2)

οὐδεὶς ἐδύνατο μαθεῖν τὴν ᾠδὴν, εἰ μὴ αἱ ἑκατὸν τεσσεράκοντα τέσσαρες χιλιάδες

“no one was able to learn the song except the 144 thousands”

If it would appear in your language that John was contradicting himself by saying that **no one** could learn the song and then naming people who could learn the song, you could reword this to avoid using an exception clause. Alternate translation: [the only ones who were able to learn the song were the 144 thousands]

See: Connect — Exception Clauses

Revelation 14:3 (#5)

ἀπὸ τῆς γῆς

“from the earth”

John is referring to the inhabitants of the earth by association with the **earth** on which they live. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from among the inhabitants of the earth]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 14:4 (#1)

οὗτοί εἰσιν οἳ μετὰ γυναικῶν οὐκ ἐμολύνθησαν, παρθένοι γάρ εἰσιν

“These are they who have not been defiled with women, for they are virgins”

John is speaking as if the people who are singing have literally never had sexual relations. In context, he most likely means that they have not worshiped idols. Having sexual relations outside of marriage, or not waiting until marriage to have sexual relations, is a common Old Testament image for idol worship. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [These are they who have not worshiped idols, for they are faithful to God]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 14:4 (#2)

μετὰ γυναικῶν οὐκ ἐμολύνθησαν

“have not been defiled with women”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. John is not saying that women make men **defiled**. He is saying that sexual relations outside of marriage are sinful. In your translation, be sure that this is clear to your readers. Alternate translation: [have not committed immoral acts with women]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 14:4 (#3)

οἱ ἀκολουθοῦντες τῷ Ἀρνίῳ ὅπου ἂν ὑπάγει

“the ones following the Lamb wherever he goes”

This statement may be one that readers could understand literally within the world of this vision. However, in the New Testament, **following** someone often means being that person’s disciple and obeying his teaching. That could be what John means here. Alternate translation: [the ones who obey the Lamb no matter what he asks]

See: Idiom

Revelation 14:4 (#7)

ἀπαρχὴ τῷ Θεῷ καὶ τῷ Ἀρνίῳ

“as first fruits for God and for the Lamb”

John is speaking as if these people were literally the **first fruits** of a harvest. He means that they are the first of many people who will eventually believe in Jesus. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [as the first of many people who will believe in God and Jesus]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 14:4 (#4)

οὗτοι ἠγοράσθησαν

“These have been bought”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. See what you did in 14:3. Alternate translation: [The Lamb bought them]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 14:4 (#5)

οὗτοι ἠγοράσθησαν

“These have been bought”

See how you translated this in 14:3. Alternate translation: [These the Lamb redeemed]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 14:4 (#6)

ἀπὸ τῶν ἀνθρώπων

“from among men”

Although the term **man** is masculine, John is using the word in a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use a term in your language that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [from among humanity]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Revelation 14:5 (#5)

ἐν τῷ στόματι αὐτῶν οὐχ εὑρέθη ψεῦδος

“no lie has been found in their mouth”

The implication is that these people have told **no lie** about who Jesus is, despite the pressure they have been facing to deny that he is Lord and Savior. You can provide this information in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [they have always told the truth about who Jesus is]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 14:5 (#1)

ἐν τῷ στόματι αὐτῶν οὐχ εὑρέθη ψεῦδος

“no lie has been found in their mouth”

Since John is referring to a group of people, it might be more natural in your language to use the plural form of **mouth**. Alternate translation: [no lie has been found in their mouths]

See: Collective Nouns

Revelation 14:5 (#6)

ἄμωμοί γὰρ εἰσιν

“for they are blameless”

Some ancient manuscripts read **for they are blameless**. ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts add “before the throne of God.” If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Revelation 14:5 (#2)

ἐν τῷ στόματι αὐτῶν οὐχ εὑρέθη ψεῦδος

“no lie has been found in their mouth”

Here the expression **has been found** means “could be found” or “was there.” Alternate translation: [there was no lie in their mouths]

See: Idiom

Revelation 14:5 (#3)

ἐν τῷ στόματι αὐτῶν οὐχ εὑρέθη ψεῦδος

“no lie has been found in their mouth”

John is referring to people speaking by association with the way that a person speaks with his **mouth**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they have told no lies]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 14:5 (#4)

ἐν τῷ στόματι αὐτῶν οὐχ εὑρέθη ψεῦδος

“no lie has been found in their mouth”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this double negative that consists of the negative particle **no** and the negative word **lies**. Alternate translation: [they have always told the truth]

See: Double Negatives

Revelation 14:6 (#1)

ἐπὶ πᾶν ἔθνος, καὶ φυλὴν, καὶ γλῶσσαν, καὶ λαόν

“to every nation and tribe and language and people”

The terms **nation**, **tribe**, **language**, and **people** mean similar things. John is using the four terms together to make a comprehensive statement. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [every different people group]

See: Doublet

Revelation 14:7 (#2)

ἦλθεν ἡ ὥρα τῆς κρίσεως αὐτοῦ

“the hour of his judgment has come”

The angel is using the word **hour** by association to mean a specific time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the time of his judgment has come] or [the time has come when he will judge]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 14:7 (#1)

ἦλθεν ἡ ὥρα τῆς κρίσεως αὐτοῦ

“the hour of his judgment has come”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgment**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the hour has come when he will judge]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 14:7 (#3)

τὸν οὐρανὸν, καὶ τὴν γῆν, καὶ θάλασσαν, καὶ πηγὰς ὑδάτων

“the heaven and the earth and the sea and the springs of water”

The angel is using four main components of creation to mean all of creation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [everything that exists]

See: Merism

Revelation 14:8 (#1)

ἔπεσεν, ἔπεσεν, Βαβυλὼν ἡ μεγάλη

“Fallen, fallen has Babylon the Great”

This second angel is speaking as if Babylon has literally **fallen** down. He means that the city has been destroyed. The repetition of the word **fallen** is emphatic and indicates complete destruction. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Babylon the Great has been completely destroyed] or [God has completely destroyed Babylon the Great]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 14:8 (#5)

πάντα τὰ ἔθνη

“all the nations”

The angel says **all** here as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [nations throughout the world]

See: Hyperbole

Revelation 14:8 (#7)

ἐκ τοῦ οἴνου τοῦ θυμοῦ τῆς πορνείας αὐτῆς

“from the wine of the passion of her immorality”

In the second instance, as in 14:3, having immoral sexual relations is a symbolic image for worshiping idols. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to worship idols as she did]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 14:8 (#3)

Βαβυλὼν ἡ μεγάλη

“Babylon the Great”

Since the ancient city of Babylon was destroyed centuries earlier, the angel is not speaking literally of that city. The angel is using **Babylon** to symbolize some other city or empire. The specific identity of that city or empire is a matter of interpretation rather than trans-

lation. Alternate translation: [the great city that is like Babylon] or [the great empire that is like Babylon]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 14:8 (#2)

Βαβυλὼν ἡ μεγάλη

"Babylon the Great"

The word **Babylon** is the name of an ancient city that founded an empire whose armies destroyed Jerusalem and the temple in 586 B.C.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 14:8 (#6)

ἐκ τοῦ οἴνου τοῦ θυμοῦ τῆς πορνείας αὐτῆς, πεπότικεν πάντα τὰ ἔθνη

"caused all the nations to drink from the wine of the passion of her immorality"

This second angel is speaking as if Babylon has literally caused the nations to **drink** a certain kind of **wine**. This means, in the first instance, that Babylon led the nations to commit sexual immorality with her. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [caused all the nations to give in to passions that led them to commit sexual immorality with her]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 14:8 (#4)

ἡ & πεπότικεν πάντα τὰ ἔθνη

"who caused all the nations to drink"

The angel is speaking of the city of **Babylon** as if it were a living thing that **caused** the nations **to drink** from a certain cup. The angel means that the rulers of the city did this, symbolically (See: next note). If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [whose rulers caused all the nations to drink]

See: Personification

Revelation 14:10 (#2)

τοῦ Θεοῦ, τοῦ κεκερασμένου

"of God having been poured"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [that God has poured]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 14:10 (#1)

καὶ αὐτὸς πίεται ἐκ τοῦ οἴνου τοῦ θυμοῦ τοῦ Θεοῦ, τοῦ κεκερασμένου ἀκράτου ἐν τῷ ποτηρίῳ τῆς ὀργῆς αὐτοῦ

"he will also drink from the wine of the wrath of God having been poured undiluted into the cup of his anger"

The angel is speaking as if anyone who worships the beast will literally **drink** a certain kind of **wine** from a certain **cup**. He means symbolically that God will make such a person experience the just consequences of his actions. Within this image, the fact that the wine is **undiluted** means that God will not show him mercy as he judges him. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God will make him experience the just consequences of his actions and in his anger God will not show him any mercy]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 14:10 (#5)

ἐνώπιον ἀγγέλων ἁγίων καὶ ἐνώπιον τοῦ Ἀρνίου

"before the holy angels and before the Lamb"

Here the word **before** means "in front of" or "in the presence of" another person. Alternate translation: [in the presence of the holy angels and in the presence of the Lamb]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 14:10 (#3)

βασανισθήσεται

"he will be tormented"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God will torment him]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 14:10 (#4)

πυρὶ καὶ θείῳ

"fire and sulfur"

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two words connected with **and**. The word **fire** describes the state of the **sulfur**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an

equivalent phrase that does not use "and." Alternate translation: [fiery sulfur]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 14:11 (#1)

τοῦ βασανισμοῦ αὐτῶν

"of their torment"

The third angel is referring to the burning sulfur with which God is tormenting these people by association with the **torment** itself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [of the burning sulfur with which God is tormenting them]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 14:11 (#2)

εἰς αἰῶνας αἰώνων

"to the ages of the ages"

This expression refers to endless future time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for all eternity]

See: Idiom

Revelation 14:11 (#4)

εἴ τις λαμβάνει

"if anyone receives"

The angel is using a characteristic expression of the Greek language. Alternate translation: [anyone who receives]

See: Idiom

Revelation 14:11 (#3)

ἡμέρας καὶ νυκτός

"day and night"

The angel is using the two parts of a full day, **day** and **night**, to mean all the time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [at any time]

See: Merism

Revelation 14:12 (#3)

τὴν πίστιν Ἰησοῦ

"the faith of Jesus"

In this possessive form, **Jesus** is the object rather than the subject of **faith**. That is, this does not mean the faith that Jesus has, it means the faith that people have in Jesus. Alternate translation: [faith in Jesus]

See: Possession

Revelation 14:12 (#2)

τηροῦντες τὰς ἐντολὰς τοῦ Θεοῦ, καὶ τὴν πίστιν Ἰησοῦ

"keeping the commandments of God and the faith of Jesus"

See how you translated the word **keeping** in 1:3 and in 2:26. Alternate translation: [obeying the commandments of God and maintaining their faith in Jesus]

See: Idiom

Revelation 14:12 (#1)

ὧδε ἡ ὑπομονὴ τῶν ἁγίων ἐστίν

"Here is the endurance of the saints"

The expression **Here is** introduces something that the speaker is calling for. Alternate translation: [This calls for endurance on the part of the saints]

See: Idiom

Revelation 14:13 (#1)

φωνῆς ἐκ τοῦ οὐρανοῦ λεγούσης

"a voice from heaven saying"

John is referring to someone speaking by association with the **voice** that the person is using to speak. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation, as in UST: [I heard someone speaking from heaven and saying]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 14:13 (#5)

ἐν Κυρίῳ

"in the Lord"

The person speaking is referring to Jesus by a respectful title. Use a form for addressing someone respectfully in your language. Alternate translation: [in the Lord Jesus]

See: Politeness

Revelation 14:13 (#3)

οἱ νεκροὶ οἱ & ἀποθνῄσκοντες

“the dead dying”

The person speaking is using the adjective **dead** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [people who die if they die]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 14:13 (#6)

ἵνα

“so”

The word translated **so** introduces a result of the action that the previous sentence describes. If it would be helpful in your language, you could refer back to that action. Alternate translation: [because they are blessed as a result of dying in the Lord,]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Revelation 14:13 (#4)

οἱ ἐν Κυρίῳ ἀποθνῄσκοντες ἀπ’ ἄρτι

“dying in the Lord from now on”

The expression **dying in the Lord** means to die while still maintaining faith in Jesus. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who die from now on while still maintaining their faith in Jesus]

See: Idiom

Revelation 14:13 (#7)

τὰ & ἔργα αὐτῶν ἀκολουθεῖ μετ’ αὐτῶν

“their deeds follow with them”

John is speaking of the **deeds** of these people who have died **in the Lord** as if those deeds could **follow** the people as they come into the presence of God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God will acknowledge as they come into his presence that they have served him diligently]

See: Personification

Revelation 14:13 (#2)

λεγούσης, γράψον, μακάριοι οἱ νεκροὶ οἱ ἐν Κυρίῳ ἀποθνῄσκοντες ἀπ’ ἄρτι

“saying, “Write, ‘Blessed {are} the dead dying in the Lord from now on”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so there is no quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [that told me to write, “Blessed are the dead dying in the Lord from now on”]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Revelation 14:14 (#1)

ὅμοιον

“one like”

John is using the adjective **like** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. ULT adds the word **one** to show that. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [a person who looked like a son of man]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 14:14 (#3)

δρέπανον ὀξύ

“a sharp sickle”

A **sickle** is a tool with a curved blade that agricultural workers use to cut down standing crops in order to harvest them. If your readers would not be familiar with what a **sickle** is, you could use a general expression. Alternate translation: [a sharp harvesting tool]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 14:14 (#2)

Υἱὸν Ἀνθρώπου

“a son of man”

This could mean: (1) a human being, in a characteristic Hebrew expression that John would be borrowing. Alternate translation, as in UST: [a human being]; (2) the Messiah, since “the Son of Man” is a title for the Messiah. Alternate translation: [the Messiah, the Son of Man]

See: Idiom

Revelation 14:15 (#1)

ἐξηράνθη

“has been ripened”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [has ripened]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 14:16 (#1)

ἐθερίσθη ἡ γῆ

"the earth was harvested"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [he harvested the earth]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 14:18 (#1)

ὁ ἔχων ἐξουσίαν ἐπὶ τοῦ πυρός

"the & the one having authority over & fire"

John is referring implicitly to the **fire** that burned up sacrifices on the altar. You can provide this information in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the one responsible for maintaining the altar fire]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 14:19 (#1)

ληνὸν

"winepress"

A **winepress** a large basin made of stone or wood. Workers put grapes in this basin and, with bare feet, trample on the grapes to extract their juice. If your readers would not be familiar with what a **winepress** is, you could use a general expression. Alternate translation: [large basin]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 14:20 (#5)

σταδίων χιλίων ἑξακοσίων

"1,600 stadia"

The word **stadia** is the plural form of "stadium," which was a distance of about 185 meters. If it would be helpful in your language, you could give the equivalent in modern measurements. Alternate translation: [about 300 kilometers] or [about 200 miles]

See: Biblical Distance

Revelation 14:20 (#1)

ἐπατήθη ἡ ληνὸς

"the winepress was trampled"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [workers trampled the winepress]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 14:20 (#4)

ἄχρι τῶν χαλινῶν τῶν ἵππων

"up to the bridles of the horses"

The word **bridles** describes sets of headgear that riders use to control horses. If your readers would not be familiar with what **bridles** are, you could use an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [as high as horses' heads]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 14:20 (#3)

αἷμα

"blood"

John is referring to a stream of blood by association with the **blood** that ran out of the winepress. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a stream of blood]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 14:20 (#2)

ἐπατήθη ἡ ληνὸς

"the winepress was trampled"

John is referring to the grapes in the winepress by association with the **winepress** itself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [workers trampled the grapes in the winepress]

See: Metonymy

Revelation - Chapter 15 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

In this chapter, John describes events and pictures that occur in heaven.

Some translations set each line of poetry farther to the right than the rest of the text to make it easier to read. The ULT does this with verses 3–4.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

"Victorious over the beast"
These people are spiritually victorious. While most spiritual battles cannot be seen, the book of Revelation pictures spiritual battles as occurring openly. (See: spirit, wind, breath; and Symbolic Prophecy)

"The temple having the tent of witness was open in heaven"
Scripture elsewhere indicates the earthly temple copied God's perfect dwelling place in heaven. Here John seems to refer to God's heavenly dwelling place or temple. (See: heaven, sky, heavens, heavenly; and Symbolic Prophecy)

Songs
The book of Revelation often describes heaven as a place where people sing. People there worship God with songs. This illustrates that heaven is a place where God is always worshiped.

Revelation 15:1 (#2)

ἔχοντας πληγὰς ἑπτὰ τὰς ἐσχάτας

"having seven final plagues"

John is speaking of these **plagues** as if they were something that the **seven angels** had in their possession. He means that God had made these angels responsible for administering the plagues. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who would be responsible for administering seven final plagues]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 15:1 (#3)

ἐτελέσθη ὁ θυμὸς τοῦ Θεοῦ

"the wrath of God was finished"

John is referring to God's punishments for sin by association with the **wrath** that God feels because of sin. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the punishments of God were finished]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 15:1 (#4)

ἐτελέσθη ὁ θυμὸς τοῦ Θεοῦ

"the wrath of God was finished"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God finished punishing all wrongdoing]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 15:1 (#1)

μέγα καὶ θαυμαστόν

"great and marvelous"

The terms **great** and **marvelous** mean similar things. John is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [amazing]

See: Doublet

Revelation 15:2 (#3)

τοὺς νικῶντας ἐκ τοῦ θηρίου, καὶ ἐκ τῆς εἰκόνος αὐτοῦ, καὶ ἐκ τοῦ ἀριθμοῦ τοῦ ὀνόματος αὐτοῦ

"the ones being victorious over the beast and over his image and over the number of his name"

John means implicitly that these people were **victorious** because they did not worship **the beast and his image** and did not accept **the number of his name** on their right hands or foreheads. You can provide this information in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [who had not worshiped the beast or his image and who had not accepted the number of his name as a mark on their right hands or foreheads]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 15:2 (#1)

ὡς θάλασσαν ὑαλίνην

"as it were a sea of glass"

The point of this comparison is that the large object made of **glass** looked like a **sea**. That is, it was wide and spacious and level. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. See how you translated the similar expression in 4:6. Alternate translation: [a large glass surface]

See: Simile

Revelation 15:2 (#2)

μεμιγμένην πυρί

"having been mixed with fire"

The point of this further comparison seems to be that the glass sea was sparkling with light or reflecting the flashes of light that came from the nearby throne, as

John describes in 4:5. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [that looked as if it was flashing with fire]

See: Simile

Revelation 15:3 (#6)

ὁ Βασιλεὺς τῶν αἰώνων

"King of the Ages"

Some ancient manuscripts read **King of the Ages**. ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts read "King of the Nations." If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Revelation 15:3 (#5)

ὁ Βασιλεὺς τῶν αἰώνων

"King of the Ages"

The believers are using a possessive form to describe not what God rules over but for how long God will rule. Alternate translation: [you who will be king for all eternity]

See: Possession

Revelation 15:3 (#2)

μεγάλα καὶ θαυμαστὰ τὰ ἔργα σου

"Great and marvelous {are} your deeds"

The terms **Great** and **marvelous** mean similar things. The victorious believers are using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Your deeds are amazing]

See: Doublet

Revelation 15:3 (#3)

δίκαιαι καὶ ἀληθιναὶ αἱ ὁδοί σου

"Righteous and true {are} your ways"

The terms **Righteous** and **true** mean similar things. The victorious believers are using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Your ways are completely righteous]

See: Doublet

Revelation 15:3 (#4)

αἱ ὁδοί σου

"are} your ways"

The victorious believers are singing about God's actions as if they were **ways** or paths that God was walking on. Alternate translation: [are your actions]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 15:3 (#1)

ᾄδουσιν τὴν ᾠδὴν Μωϋσέως, τοῦ δούλου τοῦ Θεοῦ, καὶ τὴν ᾠδὴν τοῦ Ἀρνίου

"they sing the song of Moses the servant of God and the song of the Lamb"

This could mean implicitly: (1) that these victorious believers sing one song. Alternate translation: [they sing a song that Moses, the servant of God, sang and that the Lamb now sings]; (2) that these victorious believers sing two songs. Alternate translation: [they sing the song of Moses, the servant of God, and they also sing the song of the Lamb]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 15:4 (#1)

τίς οὐ μὴ φοβηθῇ, Κύριε, καὶ δοξάσει τὸ ὄνομά σου

"Who will certainly not fear {you}, Lord, and glorify your name"

The victorious believers are using the question form for emphasis. If you would not use the question form for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Everyone should fear you, Lord, and glorify your name!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Revelation 15:4 (#2)

δοξάσει τὸ ὄνομά σου

"glorify your name"

Here, **name** represents the character and reputation of person by association with the way that each person has a name. Alternate translation: [praise you for your excellent character]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 15:4 (#4)

τὰ δικαιώματά σου ἐφανερώθησαν

"your righteous deeds have been manifested"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [you have manifested your righteous deeds]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 15:4 (#3)

ἐνώπιόν σου

"before you"

Here the word **before** means "in front of" or "in the presence of" another person. Alternate translation: [in your presence]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 15:5 (#3)

ὁ ναὸς τῆς σκηνῆς τοῦ μαρτυρίου

"the temple of the dwelling of the testimony"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **testimony**, you could express the same idea in another way. The phrase "the tabernacle of the testimony" is a common Old Testament description of the tent that held the ark of the covenant. John describes in 11:19 how the ark was now in the temple in heaven. Alternate translation: [the temple, that is, the tent holding the ark of the covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 15:5 (#1)

ἠνοίγη ὁ ναὸς τῆς σκηνῆς τοῦ μαρτυρίου ἐν τῷ οὐρανῷ

"the temple of the dwelling of the testimony in heaven had been opened"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God had opened the temple of the tabernacle of the testimony in heaven]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 15:5 (#2)

ὁ ναὸς

"the temple"

When John says that the **temple** had been opened, he means by association that the doors of the temple had been opened and he could see inside. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the doors of the temple]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 15:6 (#3)

λίθον

"linen"

John is referring to linen clothes by association with the **linen** from which this clothing is made. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [linen clothes]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 15:6 (#4)

λίθον

"linen"

The word **linen** is the name for a fine, expensive cloth that people make from the strong fibers of the inner bark of the flax plant. If your readers would not be familiar with what linen is, you could use a general expression. Alternate translation: [clothes made from fine, expensive fabric]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 15:6 (#1)

οἱ ἔχοντες τὰς ἑπτὰ πληγὰς

"having the seven plagues"

See how you translated the similar expression in 15:1. Alternate translation: [who would be responsible for administering the seven plagues]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 15:6 (#2)

ἐνδεδυμένοι λίθον καθαρὸν λαμπρὸν, καὶ περιεζωσμένοι περὶ τὰ στήθη ζώνας χρυσᾶς

"having been clothed with clean, bright linen and with golden sashes having been wrapped around {their} chests"

If your language does not use these passive forms, you could express the ideas in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. Alternate translation: [They were wearing clean, bright linen clothes and they had wrapped golden sashes around their chests]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 15:7 (#1)

γεμούσας τοῦ θυμοῦ τοῦ Θεοῦ

"being full of the wrath of the God"

John is referring to God's punishments for sin by association with the **wrath** that God feels because of sin. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [being full of punishments from God]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 15:7 (#2)

τοῦ ζῶντος εἰς τοὺς αἰῶνας τῶν αἰώνων

"living to the ages of the ages"

This expression refers to endless future time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who lives for all eternity]

See: Idiom

Revelation 15:8 (#1)

ἐγεμίσθη ὁ ναὸς καπνοῦ ἐκ τῆς δόξης τοῦ Θεοῦ, καὶ ἐκ τῆς δυνάμεως αὐτοῦ

"the temple was filled with smoke from the glory of God and from his power"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [smoke from the glory of God and from his power filled the temple]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 15:8 (#3)

τελεσθῶσιν αἱ ἑπτὰ πληγαὶ τῶν ἑπτὰ ἀγγέλων

"the seven plagues of the seven angels were completed"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the seven angels had completed their seven plagues]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 15:8 (#2)

ἐκ τῆς δόξης τοῦ Θεοῦ, καὶ ἐκ τῆς δυνάμεως αὐτοῦ

"from the glory of God and from his power"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **glory** and **power**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [because God was so glorious and powerful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation - Chapter 16 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the vision that John began to describe in chapter 15. Together these two chapters describe the seven plagues that complete the wrath of God. (See: wrath, fury)

Some translations set each line of poetry farther to the right than the rest of the text to make it easier to read. The ULT does this with verses 5–7.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Seven bowls of God's wrath

This chapter reveals severe judgments. John pictures the execution of these judgments as angels pouring out seven bowls of God's wrath. (See: Metaphor)

Translation Issues in This Chapter

- When John says that an angel "poured out his bowl," he means that the angel poured out what was in his bowl. You can say that in your translation each time. (See: Metonymy)
- In this chapter, John uses adjectives "first" through "seventh" as nouns to identify the angels who pour out the bowls of God's wrath. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate these words with equivalent phrases, for example, "the first angel," "the second angel," and so forth. (See: Nominal Adjectives)
- If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you could use cardinal numbers for these angels, for example, "angel number one," "angel number two," and so forth. (See: Ordinal Numbers)

Revelation 16:1 (#1)

μεγάλης φωνῆς ἐκ τοῦ ναοῦ, λεγούσης

"a loud voice from the temple saying"

John is referring to someone speaking by association with the **voice** that the person is using to speak. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [someone speaking loudly from the temple and saying]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 16:1 (#2)

τοῦ θυμοῦ τοῦ Θεοῦ

"of the wrath of God"

John is referring to God's punishments for sin by association with the **wrath** that God feels because of sin. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that hold the punishments from God]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 16:2 (#1)

ὁ πρῶτος

"the first"

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, John is using the adjective **first** as a noun to identify this particular angel. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase, and you could do the same with the similar expressions that describe the other six angels. Alternate translation: [the first angel]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 16:2 (#2)

ὁ πρῶτος

"the first"

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, if your language does not use ordinal numbers, here and for the other six angels you could use a cardinal number or an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [angel number one]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 16:2 (#5)

τοὺς ἀνθρώπους

"the men"

Although the term **men** is masculine, John is using the word in a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use a term in your language that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [the people]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Revelation 16:2 (#3)

ἕλκος κακὸν καὶ πονηρὸν

"a bad and harmful sore"

Since John is referring to what happened to each person in a group of people, it might be more natural in your language to use the plural form of **sore**. Alternate translation: [bad and harmful sores]

See: Collective Nouns

Revelation 16:2 (#4)

κακὸν καὶ πονηρὸν

"bad and harmful"

The terms **bad** and **harmful** mean similar things. John is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [very severe]

See: Doublet

Revelation 16:3 (#2)

πᾶσα ψυχὴ ζῶσα

"every living soul"

John is referring to living creatures by association with the **soul** or vital breath that keeps them alive. (Sea creatures do not breathe air, but they circulate water comparably to the way land creatures circulate air.) If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [every living creature]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 16:3 (#1)

ὡς νεκροῦ

"as of a corpse"

The point of this comparison is that the sea turned into **blood** that was foul and smelled bad, like the blood of a **corpse**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [that was foul and smelled bad]

See: Simile

Revelation 16:4 (#1)

ἐγένετο

"it became"

The pronoun **it** refers to the **water** in the **rivers** and **springs**. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the water in them became]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 16:5 (#2)

ὁ ὢν, καὶ ὁ ἦν, ὁ Ὅσιος

“the one being and the one who was, the Holy One”

Even though the angel is addressing God, the angel is speaking about God in the third person. You could make this clear by using the word “you” in your translation. Alternate translation: [you who are and who were, you who are holy]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Revelation 16:5 (#3)

ὁ ὢν, καὶ ὁ ἦν, ὁ Ὅσιος

“the one being and the one who was, the Holy One”

Some ancient manuscripts read **the one being and the one who was, the Holy One**. ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts read “O Lord, the one being and the one who was and who is to be.” If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Revelation 16:5 (#1)

τοῦ ἀγγέλου τῶν ὑδάτων

“the angel of the waters”

John is using this possessive form to indicate that God had given this **angel** authority over the **waters** (the rivers and springs) and responsibility for maintaining them. The angel is affirming that God has done the right thing even though this has damaged the waters. Alternate translation: [the angel who was responsible for the waters]

See: Possession

Revelation 16:5 (#4)

ὁ Ὅσιος

“the Holy One”

The angel is using the adjective **Holy** as a noun. He is referring to God by one of his essential attributes. ULT adds the word **One** to show that. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the Holy God]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 16:5 (#5)

ταῦτα

“these”

The pronoun **these** refers to the people who have killed the saints and prophets, as the angel describes in the next verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [these people]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 16:6 (#1)

αἷμα ἁγίων καὶ προφητῶν ἐξέχεαν

“they poured out the blood of the saints and prophets”

The angel is referring to the fact that these people killed **the saints and prophets** by association with the way they shed their **blood** when they killed them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they shed the blood of the saints and prophets when they killed them]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 16:6 (#2)

ἄξιοί εἰσιν

“they are worthy”

The angel of the waters means implicitly that the people who killed the saints and prophets are **worthy** of this punishment, that is, they deserve it. You can provide this information in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. Alternate translation: [They deserve this punishment]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 16:7 (#2)

ἀληθιναὶ καὶ δίκαιαι

“are} true and righteous”

The terms **true** and **righteous** mean similar things. The altar is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [entirely righteous]

See: Doublet

Revelation 16:7 (#1)

ἤκουσα τοῦ θυσιαστηρίου λέγοντος

“I heard the altar saying”

John is describing the **altar** as a living thing that can speak. As the General Introduction to Revelation discusses, within the world of this vision, this is not a figure of speech and so you can translate it literally even if your language does not use figures of speech.

See: Personification

Revelation 16:8 (#4)

πυρί

“fire”

John is speaking as if the sun were literally scorching people with **fire**. He means that the sun’s rays became so hot that they burned people just as badly as fire burns people. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the heat of its rays]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 16:8 (#1)

ἐδόθη αὐτῷ

“it was granted to it”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God permitted it]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 16:8 (#3)

τοὺς ἀνθρώπους

“men”

Although the term **men** is masculine, John is using the word in a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use a term in your language that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [people]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Revelation 16:8 (#5)

τοὺς ἀνθρώπους

“men”

Although the term **men** is masculine, John is using the word in a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use a term in your language that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [people]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Revelation 16:8 (#2)

ἐδόθη αὐτῷ

“it was granted to it”

John is speaking of the **sun** as if it were a living thing that could receive permission to do something. As the General Introduction to Revelation discusses, within the world of this vision, this may not be a figure of speech, and so you could translate it literally even if your language does not use figures of speech. However, if it would be clearer in your language, you could consider it a figure of speech and provide an equivalent translation. Alternate translation: [God caused it]

See: Personification

Revelation 16:9 (#2)

ἐβλασφήμησαν τὸ ὄνομα τοῦ Θεοῦ

“they blasphemed the name of the God”

Here, **name** represents the character and reputation of person by association with the way that each person has a name. Alternate translation: [they maligned the character of the God]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 16:9 (#1)

ἐκαυματίσθησαν οἱ ἄνθρωποι καῦμα μέγα

“men were scorched a great scorch”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the sun scorched men greatly]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 16:9 (#4)

δοῦναι αὐτῷ δόξαν

“to give him glory”

If you wish to retain the biblical idiom in your translation but your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and glorify him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 16:9 (#3)

οὐ μετενόησαν δοῦναι αὐτῷ δόξαν

"they did not repent to give him glory"

In the Bible, a person giving God **glory** often means that person acknowledging that he has sinned and that God is justly punishing him. Alternate translation: [they did not repent of their sin and acknowledge that God was punishing them for it justly]

See: Idiom

Revelation 16:10 (#4)

ἐμασῶντο τὰς γλώσσας αὐτῶν

"they were chewing their tongues"

The pronoun **they** refers to the people whom God afflicted with painful sores, as John describes in 16:2 and as he makes clear in the next verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the people whom God had punished with sores were chewing their tongues]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 16:10 (#2)

ἐγένετο ἡ βασιλεία αὐτοῦ ἐσκοτωμένη

"its kingdom became darkened"

John does not say specifically how God **darkened** the entire area where the beast ruled and so you may not wish to offer any explicit explanation in your translation. However, if your language would not describe something like this without saying how it happened, you could suggest an explanation. Alternate translation: [God made thick clouds cover the sun in order to darken its kingdom] or [God caused an eclipse of the sun in order to darken its kingdom]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 16:10 (#3)

ἡ βασιλεία αὐτοῦ

"its kingdom"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of a **kingdom**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the area that the beast ruled as king]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 16:10 (#1)

ἐγένετο ἡ βασιλεία αὐτοῦ ἐσκοτωμένη

"its kingdom became darkened"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God darkened its kingdom]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 16:11 (#1)

ἐκ τῶν πόνων αὐτῶν, καὶ ἐκ τῶν ἑλκῶν αὐτῶν

"because of their pain and because of their sores"

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two words connected with **and**. The word **pain** tells what kind of **sores** these were. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase that does not use "and." Alternate translation: [because of their painful sores]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 16:12 (#1)

τὸν Εὐφράτην

"the Euphrates"

The word **Euphrates** is the name of a river. See how you translated it in 9:14.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 16:12 (#2)

ἐξηράνθη τὸ ὕδωρ αὐτοῦ, ἵνα ἑτοιμασθῇ ἡ ὁδὸς τῶν βασιλέων τῶν ἀπὸ ἀνατολῆς ἡλίου

"its water was dried up so that the way of the kings from the rising of the sun might be prepared"

If your language does not use these passive forms, you could express the ideas in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God dried up its water in order to prepare the way for the kings from the rising of the sun]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 16:12 (#3)

τῶν ἀπὸ ἀνατολῆς ἡλίου

"from the rising of the sun"

This expression refers to a particular direction from the perspective of the speaker. Your language may

have its own way of referring to this direction. Alternate translation: [from the east]

See: Idiom

Revelation 16:13 (#1)

ὡς βάτραχοι

"like frogs"

John does not seem to be drawing a comparison between these **unclean spirits** and **frogs** in order to indicate something about the character of the spirits. Rather, he seems to be describing the appearance of the spirits. This appearance may have some symbolic significance, but that is a matter of interpretation rather than translation. Alternate translation: [that looked like frogs]

See: Simile

Revelation 16:14 (#1)

σημεῖα

"signs"

John is using the word **signs** here in the same sense as in 13:13. See how you translated the word there. Alternate translation: [miracles]

See: Idiom

Revelation 16:15 (#1)

In this verse, Jesus breaks into John's narrative of his vision to address the believers who are listening to it or reading it. ULT puts the verse in parentheses to show this. There may be a comparable convention in your language that you can use in your translation. You can also state explicitly that the Lord Jesus said this, as UST does.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 16:15 (#3)

τηρῶν τὰ ἱμάτια αὐτοῦ, ἵνα μὴ γυμνὸς περιπατῇ, καὶ βλέπωσιν τὴν ἀσχημοσύνην αὐτοῦ

"keeping his garments so that he might not walk around naked and they see his indecency"

As the General Introduction to Revelation discusses, here the term "keeping" means "preserving," that is, maintaining the **garments** in good repair. This represents living in a way that pleases God. Walking around **naked** similarly stands for living in a way that displeases God, that is, committing sins. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [continuing to live in a way that pleases God and not committing sins that others can see]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 16:15 (#2)

ἔρχομαι ὡς κλέπτης

"I am coming like a thief"

The point of this comparison is that Jesus **is coming** at a time when people will not be expecting him, just as a **thief** comes when people are not expecting him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I am coming at a time when you are not expecting me]

See: Simile

Revelation 16:15 (#5)

καὶ βλέπωσιν τὴν ἀσχημοσύνην αὐτοῦ

"and they see his indecency"

The pronoun **they** is an indefinite pronoun that does not refer to anyone in the immediate context. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this with a different expression that does not use an indefinite pronoun. Alternate translation: [so that people can see his indecency]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 16:15 (#4)

τηρῶν τὰ ἱμάτια αὐτοῦ

"keeping his garments"

This expression means to keep one's **garments** on, that is, to continue to wear clothes. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [continuing to wear clothes]

See: Idiom

Revelation 16:15 (#6)

τὴν ἀσχημοσύνην

"indecency"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **indecency**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [indecent behavior]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 16:16 (#3)

Ἁρμαγεδών

“Armageddon”

The word **Armageddon** is a Hebrew word that John spells out using Greek letters so his readers will know how it sounds. In your translation you can spell it the way it sounds in your language.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Revelation 16:16 (#4)

Ἁρμαγεδών

“Armageddon”

The word **Armageddon** is the name of a valley.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 16:16 (#1)

συνήγαγεν αὐτοὺς

“they brought them together”

The pronoun **they** refers to the spirits of demons that John describes in 16:14 and the pronoun **them** refer to the kings John describes in that same verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the spirits of demons brought the kings together]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 16:16 (#2)

τὸν καλούμενον

“called”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [that people call]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 16:17 (#2)

γέγονεν

“It has happened”

This expression means that the speaker has accomplished what he intended to do. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly, indicating that God is the one sitting on the **throne** in the **temple**. Alternate translation: [I, God, have accomplished what I intended to do]

See: Idiom

Revelation 16:17 (#1)

ἐξῆλθεν φωνὴ μεγάλη ἐκ τοῦ ναοῦ ἀπὸ τοῦ θρόνου λέγουσα

“a loud voice came out from the temple from the throne, saying”

John is referring to someone speaking by association with the **voice** that the person is using to speak. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I heard the one who was sitting on the throne in the temple say loudly]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 16:18 (#2)

ἄνθρωπος

“man”

Although the term **man** is masculine, John is using the word in a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use a term in your language that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [humanity]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Revelation 16:18 (#1)

φωναὶ, καὶ βρονταί

“sounds and thunder”

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two words connected with **and**. The word **sounds** describes what the **thunder** produced. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase that does not use “and.” Alternate translation: [crashes of thunder]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 16:19 (#5)

Βαβυλὼν ἡ μεγάλη ἐμνήσθη ἐνώπιον τοῦ Θεοῦ, δοῦναι αὐτῇ

“Babylon the Great was remembered before God to give to her”

John is not suggesting that God had forgotten about Babylon the Great but now **remembered** the city. He is using a common biblical expression that means that God took action with regard to a person or entity of which he was already aware, either to help or to punish. If it would be helpful in your language, you

could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God punished Babylon the Great by giving her]

See: Idiom

Revelation 16:19 (#6)

Βαβυλὼν ἡ μεγάλη ἐμνήσθη

"Babylon the Great was remembered"

John is referring to the people who live in the city of **Babylon** by association with that city itself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people who lived in the great city of Babylon were remembered]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 16:19 (#4)

Βαβυλὼν ἡ μεγάλη ἐμνήσθη ἐνώπιον τοῦ Θεοῦ, δοῦναι αὐτῇ

"Babylon the Great was remembered before God to give to her"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God remembered Babylon the Great to give to her]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 16:19 (#1)

ἡ πόλις ἡ μεγάλη

"the great city"

John assumes that his readers will understand that by **the great city** he means **Babylon the Great**, as he says later in the verse. You can use the name here as well if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Babylon the Great]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 16:19 (#3)

ἔπεσαν

"fell"

John is not speaking of these **cities** or their buildings as if they were living things that could fall down accidentally. He means that the buildings in the cities collapsed. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [collapsed]

See: Idiom

Revelation 16:19 (#2)

αἱ πόλεις

"the cities"

John is using these **cities** as a whole to mean the individual parts of them, that is, their buildings. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the buildings in the cities]

See: Synecdoche

Revelation 16:19 (#7)

δοῦναι αὐτῇ τὸ ποτήριον τοῦ οἴνου τοῦ θυμοῦ τῆς ὀργῆς αὐτοῦ

"to give to her the cup of the wine of the wrath of his anger"

John is alluding to what the angel said in 14:10 about the "wine of the wrath" of God's "anger" that was in his "cup." It is likely that he is therefore referring symbolically, as the angel was, to God making people and entities experience the just consequences of their actions. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to make her experience the just consequences of her actions that have made God so angry]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 16:20 (#2)

ἔφυγεν

"fled"

John is speaking of each **island** as if it were a living thing that **fled**. He means that the islands disappeared beneath the surface of the ocean. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [sank into the ocean]

See: Personification

Revelation 16:20 (#1)

καὶ πᾶσα νῆσος ἔφυγεν, καὶ ὄρη οὐχ εὑρέθησαν

"And every island fled, and the mountains were not found"

John means implicitly that these things also happened as a result of the earthquake. You can provide this information in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. UST models one way to do that.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 16:20 (#3)

ὄρη οὐχ εὑρέθησαν

"the mountains were not found"

Here the expression **were not found** means "could not be found" or "were not there." Alternate translation: [there were no mountains anymore]

See: Idiom

Revelation 16:21 (#3)

τοὺς ἀνθρώπους & οἱ ἄνθρωποι

"men & men"

Although the term **men** is masculine, John is using the word in a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use a term in your language that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [people]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Revelation 16:21 (#2)

ὡς ταλαντιαία

"about a talent in weight"

A talent was a weight of about 33 kilograms or about 70 pounds. If it would be helpful in your language, you could give the equivalent in modern measurements. Alternate translation: [in hailstones weighing about 33 kilograms each] or [in hailstones weighing about 70 pounds each]

See: Biblical Weight

Revelation 16:21 (#1)

χάλαζα μεγάλη, ὡς ταλαντιαία

"great hail, about a talent in weight"

John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [great hail, in hailstones weighing about a talent each]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation - Chapter 17 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter begins to describe how God will destroy the entity that the book of Revelation calls Babylon.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

The great prostitute

Those who have sex with prostitutes are unfaithful to God's purposes for sexual relations to take place within marriage. The "great prostitute" in this chapter may therefore represent some person or entity that leads people to be unfaithful to God spiritually. But it is not necessary to try to identify this person or entity in your translation. (See: Symbolic Prophecy)

Seven hills

An angel tells John in 17:9, "The seven heads are seven hills where the woman is sitting." This could mean that the woman represents the city of Rome, which is known as the City of Seven Hills. However, since this is a matter of interpretation rather than translation, it would not be appropriate to say explicitly in your translation that the seven hills indicate the city of Rome.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Metaphors

John uses many different metaphors in this chapter. He explains some of their meanings, but allows them to remain relatively unclear. The translator should do the same. (See: Metaphor)

Translation Issues in This Chapter

"The beast that you saw was and is not but is about to come up"

This and similar phrases in this chapter contrast the beast with Jesus. Jesus is called "the one who is and who was and who is to come" elsewhere in the book of Revelation. (See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information)

Paradox

A paradox is a statement that asserts as true two things that seemingly cannot both be true at the same time. This sentence in 17:11 is a paradox: "the beast ... is itself also an eighth, but it is from the seven." The translator should not attempt to explain how both of these things can be true; that should remain a paradox.

Revelation 17:1 (#2)

τῆς πόρνης τῆς μεγάλης τῆς καθημένης ἐπὶ ὑδάτων πολλῶν

"of the great prostitute sitting on many waters"

Since the angel explains the meaning of the **great prostitute** in verse 18 and the meaning of the **waters** in verse 15, you do not need to say anything in your translation about their meaning here.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Revelation 17:1 (#3)

τῆς καθημένης ἐπὶ ὑδάτων πολλῶν

"sitting on many waters"

The angel is using the word **waters** to mean a specific body of water by association. The phrase **sitting on many waters** is an allusion to Jeremiah 51:13, where the same phrase describes the ancient city of Babylon and its location on the great Euphrates River. (The Hebrew word that Jeremiah uses can mean both "sit" and "dwell.") If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who lives next to a great river]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 17:1 (#1)

τὸ κρίμα τῆς πόρνης τῆς μεγάλης

"the judgment of the great prostitute"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgment**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how God will judge the great prostitute]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 17:2 (#1)

μεθ' ἧς ἐπόρνευσαν οἱ βασιλεῖς τῆς γῆς

"with whom the kings of the earth committed sexual immorality"

The angel is speaking as if the **kings of the earth** had literally **committed sexual immorality** with this prostitute. But that is not literally the case even within the world of this vision, since the angel explains in verse 18 that the prostitute symbolizes a city. So the sexual immorality likely symbolizes idolatry and, in light of chapter 18, greed. It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The kings of the earth joined her in being idolatrous and greedy]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 17:2 (#3)

ἐμεθύσθησαν οἱ κατοικοῦντες τὴν γῆν ἐκ τοῦ οἴνου τῆς πορνείας αὐτῆς

"the ones living {on} the earth were intoxicated from the wine of her sexual immorality"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the wine of her sexual immorality intoxicated the ones inhabiting the earth]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 17:2 (#2)

ἐμεθύσθησαν οἱ κατοικοῦντες τὴν γῆν ἐκ τοῦ οἴνου τῆς πορνείας αὐτῆς

"the ones living {on} the earth were intoxicated from the wine of her sexual immorality"

The angel is speaking as if the **sexual immorality** of the prostitute had been **wine** and that the **ones inhabiting the earth** had literally been **intoxicated** by that wine. But once again these things are not literally the case even within the world of this vision. The sexual immorality likely represents idolatry and greed and the intoxication likely represents deception. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [she deceived the ones inhabiting the earth to make them indulge in idolatry and greed]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 17:3 (#1)

ἀπήνεγκέν με εἰς ἔρημον ἐν Πνεύματι

"he carried me away in the Spirit to a wilderness"

See how you translated the expression **in the Spirit** in 1:10 and 4:2. Alternate translation: [as he carried me away to a wilderness, the Holy Spirit inspired me so that I could receive further revelation]

See: Idiom

Revelation 17:3 (#2)

γέμοντα ὀνόματα βλασφημίας

"being full of blasphemous names"

This expression means that **blasphemous names** were written all over this **beast**. Your language may have its own way of stating this. Alternate translation: [covered with blasphemous names]

See: Idiom

Revelation 17:4 (#4)

μαργαρίταις

"pearls"

The word **pearls** describes beautiful and valuable white beads that form inside the shell of a certain kind of small animal that lives in the ocean.

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 17:4 (#5)

βδελυγμάτων καὶ τὰ ἀκάθαρτα

"of abominations and the impurities"

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two words connected with **and**. The word **abominations** describes the **impurities** of the woman's conduct. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase that does not use "and." Alternate translation: [the abominable impurities]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 17:4 (#1)

ἡ γυνὴ ἦν περιβεβλημένη πορφυροῦν καὶ κόκκινον, καὶ κεχρυσωμένη χρυσῷ, καὶ λίθῳ τιμίῳ, καὶ μαργαρίταις

"the woman was clothed in purple and scarlet and adorned with gold and precious stone and pearls"

John is referring to the clothing and jewelry that the **woman** was wearing by association with the materials out of which they were made. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the woman was clothed in purple and scarlet robes and adorned with gold jewelry in which precious stones and pearls were set]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 17:4 (#3)

λίθῳ τιμίῳ

"precious stone"

The term **precious stone** refers to a beautiful and valuable piece of mineral or rock, such as is often used in jewelry. It may be more natural in your language to use a plural form here. Alternate translation: [gemstones]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 17:4 (#2)

ἡ γυνὴ ἦν περιβεβλημένη πορφυροῦν καὶ κόκκινον, καὶ κεχρυσωμένη χρυσῷ, καὶ λίθῳ τιμίῳ, καὶ μαργαρίταις

"the woman was clothed in purple and scarlet and adorned with gold and precious stone and pearls"

If your language does not use these passive forms, you could express the ideas in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the woman was wearing purple and scarlet clothing and she had adorned herself with gold jewelry in which precious stones and pearls were set]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 17:5 (#2)

ὄνομα & Μυστήριον

"a name, a mystery"

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two words together. The word **mystery** tells what kind of **name** was written on the woman's forehead. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [a mysterious name] or [a name that had a symbolic meaning]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 17:5 (#1)

ἐπὶ τὸ μέτωπον αὐτῆς & γεγραμμένον

"on her forehead had been written"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [someone had written on her forehead]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 17:5 (#3)

ὄνομα & Μυστήριον

"a name, a mystery"

Some interpreters consider the word **mystery** to be part of the name of this woman. Alternate translation: [a name: Mystery,]

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 17:6 (#2)

ἐθαύμασα & θαῦμα μέγα

"I wondered a great wonder"

John is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may

have its own way of expressing the same meaning. Alternate translation: [I wondered greatly]

See: Poetry

Revelation 17:6 (#1)

ἐκ τοῦ αἵματος τῶν ἁγίων, καὶ ἐκ τοῦ αἵματος τῶν μαρτύρων Ἰησοῦ

"from the blood of the saints and from the blood of the witnesses of Jesus"

These two phrases mean similar things. John is using repetition to emphasize the idea that the phrases express. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them. Alternate translation: [from the blood of the saints who had borne witness to Jesus]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 17:7 (#1)

διὰ τί ἐθαύμασας

"Why are you wondering"

The angel is using the question form for emphasis. If you would not use the question form for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You do not need to wonder!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Revelation 17:8 (#1)

εἰς ἀπώλειαν ὑπάγει

"it is going to destruction"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **destruction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [is going to be destroyed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 17:8 (#3)

ἀπὸ καταβολῆς κόσμου

"from the foundation of the world"

See how you translated this expression in 13:8. Alternate translation: [since God founded the world]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 17:8 (#2)

οὐ γέγραπται

"have not been written"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God has not written]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 17:9 (#3)

ὅπου ἡ γυνὴ κάθηται ἐπ' αὐτῶν

"where the woman is sitting on them"

It might seem that this expression contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [where the woman is sitting]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Revelation 17:9 (#2)

ὧδε ὁ νοῦς ὁ ἔχων σοφίαν

"Here {is} the mind having wisdom"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wisdom**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [This calls for a wise mind]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 17:9 (#1)

ὧδε ὁ νοῦς ὁ ἔχων σοφίαν

"Here {is} the mind having wisdom"

The expression **Here is** introduces something that the speaker is calling for. Alternate translation: [This calls for a mind that has wisdom]

See: Idiom

Revelation 17:10 (#3)

ὀλίγον

"a little"

The angel is using the adjective **little** as a noun to mean a certain length of time. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [for a little while]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 17:10 (#2)

ἔπεσαν

“have fallen”

The angel is speaking of these **five** kings as if they have literally **fallen**. He means that they have died. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [have died]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 17:10 (#1)

οἱ πέντε & ὁ εἷς & ὁ ἄλλος

“the five & the one & the other”

John is using the adjectives **five**, **one**, and **other** as nouns to mean these kings. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate these words with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [the first five kings ... one more of the kings ... the other king]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 17:11 (#1)

ὄγδοός & τῶν ἑπτά

“an eighth & the seven”

The angel is using the adjectives **eighth** and **seven** as nouns to mean these kings. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [an eighth king ... the seven kings]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 17:11 (#3)

εἰς ἀπώλειαν ὑπάγει

“is going to destruction”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **destruction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [is going to be destroyed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 17:11 (#2)

ὄγδοός

“an eighth”

If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you could use a cardinal number here or an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [king number eight]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 17:12 (#2)

μίαν ὥραν

“for one hour”

In the ancient world, an **hour** was the shortest time span that people envisioned. In this context, the term does not mean a literal hour of 60 minutes. It means the shortest time imaginable. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for just a little while]

See: Idiom

Revelation 17:12 (#1)

βασιλείαν

“a kingdom”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of a **kingdom**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [authority to rule as kings]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 17:13 (#2)

τὴν δύναμιν καὶ τὴν ἐξουσίαν αὐτῶν

“their power and authority”

The terms **power** and **authority** mean similar things. The angel is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [all of their authority]

See: Doublet

Revelation 17:13 (#1)

οὗτοι μίαν γνώμην ἔχουσιν

“These have one mind”

This expression means to be in complete agreement. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [These kings are in complete agreement]

See: Idiom

Revelation 17:14 (#1)

οἱ μετ’ αὐτοῦ, κλητοὶ, καὶ ἐκλεκτοὶ, καὶ πιστοί

“the ones with him {are} called and chosen and faithful”

The words **called** and **chosen** are not passive verbal forms, they are adjectives. However, if your language

does not use passive forms, it might be clearer for your readers to use expressions that do not seem to be passive verbal forms. Alternate translation: [God has called and chosen the ones with him and they are faithful]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 17:15 (#2)

γλῶσσαι

"languages"

The angel is referring to speakers of various languages by association with the **languages** themselves. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [speakers of various languages]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 17:15 (#1)

λαοὶ καὶ ὄχλοι εἰσὶν, καὶ ἔθνη καὶ γλῶσσαι

"are peoples and multitudes and nations and languages"

The terms **peoples**, **multitudes**, **nations**, and **languages** mean similar things. John is using the four terms together to make a comprehensive statement. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [every different people group]

See: Doublet

Revelation 17:16 (#2)

ἠρημωμένην

"desolated"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [desolate]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 17:16 (#4)

αὐτὴν κατακαύσουσιν πυρί

"they will burn her completely with fire"

It might seem that this expression contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [they will burn her up completely]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Revelation 17:16 (#3)

τὰς σάρκας αὐτῆς φάγονται

"they will consume her flesh"

The angel is speaking as if these **horns** (that is, these kings) and the **beast** will literally **consume** the **flesh** of the **prostitute**. But even within the world of this vision, that is not literally true. This is a common biblical image for destroying someone. If it would be clearer in your language, and especially if it would be helpful to your readers to know that cannibalism has no part in God's judgments against evil, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they will destroy her]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 17:16 (#1)

ἠρημωμένην ποιήσουσιν αὐτὴν καὶ γυμνήν

"they will make her desolated and naked"

The terms **desolated** and **naked** mean similar things. John is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [they will take away everything she has]

See: Doublet

Revelation 17:17 (#8)

ἄχρι τελεσθήσονται οἱ λόγοι τοῦ Θεοῦ

"until the words of God will be fulfilled"

The angel is using the term **words** to mean things that God has spoken by using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [until God has fulfilled what he has spoken]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 17:17 (#6)

τὴν βασιλείαν αὐτῶν

"their kingdom"

Since the angel is referring to things that belong to several people, it might be more natural in your language to use the plural form of **kingdom**. Alternate translation: [their kingdoms]

See: Collective Nouns

Revelation 17:17 (#1)

ὁ & Θεὸς ἔδωκεν εἰς τὰς καρδίας αὐτῶν

“God has put into their hearts”

Here the **heart** represents the desires. Alternate translation: [God has put into their desires]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 17:17 (#3)

ποιῆσαι τὴν γνώμην αὐτοῦ, καὶ ποιῆσαι μίαν γνώμην, καὶ

“to do his purpose and to do one purpose and”

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two shorter phrases connected with **and**. The phrase **to do one purpose** tells how the kings will **do his purpose**, that is, God’s purpose. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase that does not use “and.” Alternate translation: [to do God’s purpose by agreeing]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 17:17 (#7)

ἄχρι τελεσθήσονται οἱ λόγοι τοῦ Θεοῦ

“until the words of God will be fulfilled”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [until God has fulfilled his words]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 17:17 (#4)

ποιῆσαι μίαν γνώμην

“to do one purpose”

This expression means to be in complete agreement. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to be in complete agreement]

See: Idiom

Revelation 17:17 (#2)

ὁ & Θεὸς ἔδωκεν εἰς τὰς καρδίας αὐτῶν

“God has put into their hearts”

The angel is speaking as if God has literally **put** something into the **hearts** of these kings. He means that God has led them to want to do something. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God has led them to have the desire]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 17:17 (#5)

τὴν βασιλείαν αὐτῶν

“their kingdom”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of a **kingdom**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [their authority to rule as kings]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 17:18 (#1)

ἡ πόλις ἡ μεγάλη, ἡ ἔχουσα βασιλείαν ἐπὶ

“the great city having a kingdom over”

The angel is referring to the king who rules from the **great city** by association with that city itself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the great city whose king has a kingdom over]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 17:18 (#2)

ἡ πόλις ἡ μεγάλη, ἡ ἔχουσα βασιλείαν ἐπὶ

“the great city having a kingdom over”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **kingdom**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the great city that rules over] or [the great city whose king rules over]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation - Chapter 18 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Some translations set each line of poetry farther to the right than the rest of the text to make it easier to read. The ULT does this with all or part of verses 1–8, 10, 16–17, and 19–24.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

“in one hour”

Characters in the narrative use the expression “in one hour” in verses 10, 17, and 19. In the ancient world, an “hour” was the shortest time span that people envisioned. In this context, the term does not mean a literal hour of 60 minutes. It means the shortest time

imaginable. You may wish to translate this phrase with a comparable phrase in your language such as "in such a short time." (See: Idiom)

"woe, woe"
In verses 10, 16, and 19, kings and merchants repeat the word "woe" for emphasis. If it would not be natural in your language to repeat a word like that, you could express the emphasis in another way, for example, by using a different expression and including the word "very," as the UST does.

"she," "her"
People in this culture conventionally referred to cities by using feminine pronouns. Accordingly, throughout this chapter, various speakers refer to the city of Babylon as "she" and "her." Your language may use a different gender, so you might say "it" and "its" in your translation. You could also use a noun and say "that city." (See: Pronouns — When to Use Them)

"will not be see/heard/found anymore"
In verses 21, 22, and 23, an angel speaks a series of similar phrases describing what will not be "found" or "heard" or "seen" in Babylon "anymore." The repetition of such phrases is a figure of speech for emphasis. The angel is emphasizing how thoroughly God will destroy Babylon. If possible, use similar statements in your own translation. You may also wish to make each of these verses a separate paragraph, as ULT does, or use formatting in some other way to highlight the repeated phrases. (See: Litany)

Revelation 18:1 (#1)

ἡ γῆ ἐφωτίσθη ἐκ τῆς δόξης αὐτοῦ

"the earth was illuminated by his glory"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [his glory illuminated the earth]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 18:2 (#3)

ἐγένετο

"she has become"

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, the pronoun **she** refers to the city of Babylon. People in this culture conventionally referred to cities with feminine pronouns. Your language may use a different gender. You could also use a noun. Alternate translation: [it has become] or [that city has become]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 18:2 (#2)

ἔπεσεν, Βαβυλὼν ἡ μεγάλη

"Babylon the Great has fallen"

Some ancient manuscripts read, **Babylon the Great has fallen**. ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts read, "Fallen, fallen is Babylon the Great." If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Revelation 18:2 (#6)

φυλακὴ παντὸς πνεύματος ἀκαθάρτου, καὶ φυλακὴ παντὸς ὀρνέου ἀκαθάρτου, καὶ μεμισημένου

"a hold of every unclean spirit and a hold of every unclean and detested bird"

The angel is speaking as if these spirits and birds were literally in a **hold**, that is, a prison or other place where they were watched or guarded and could not leave. He means that the spirits and birds are now able to linger in the ruins of Babylon. Your language may have terms for places where animals and birds stay. Alternate translation: [a den of every unclean spirit and a roost of every unclean and detested bird]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 18:2 (#4)

κατοικητήριον δαιμονίων, καὶ φυλακὴ παντὸς πνεύματος ἀκαθάρτου

"a habitation of demons and a hold of every unclean spirit"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. The angel is speaking in a Hebrew style of poetry, and Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition. It would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if such repetition would not be natural in your language, you could connect the phrases with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [an abode of demons, yes, a hold of every unclean spirit]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 18:2 (#9)

μεμισημένου

"detested"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [detestable]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 18:2 (#5)

φυλακὴ παντὸς πνεύματος ἀκαθάρτου, καὶ φυλακὴ παντὸς ὀρνέου ἀκαθάρτου, καὶ μεμισημένου

"a hold of every unclean spirit and a hold of every unclean and detested bird"

The angel says **every** here as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [she has become overrun with unclean spirits and with unclean and detested birds]

See: Hyperbole

Revelation 18:2 (#1)

ἔπεσεν, Βαβυλὼν ἡ μεγάλη

"Babylon the Great has fallen"

See how you translated the similar expression in 14:8. Alternate translation: [Babylon the Great has been destroyed] or [God has destroyed Babylon the Great]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 18:2 (#7)

ὀρνέου ἀκαθάρτου, καὶ μεμισημένου

"of & unclean and detested bird"

The terms **unclean** and **detested** mean similar things. The angel is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [loathsome bird]

See: Doublet

Revelation 18:2 (#8)

ὀρνέου ἀκαθάρτου, καὶ μεμισημένου

"of & unclean and detested bird"

The angel assumes that his listeners will understand that these birds are **unclean** and **detested** according to the law of Moses because they eat dead animals. You can say that explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [unclean and detested bird that eats dead animals] or [loathsome bird that eats dead animals]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 18:3 (#2)

πάντα τὰ ἔθνη

"all the nations"

The angel says **all** here as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [nations throughout the world]

See: Hyperbole

Revelation 18:3 (#1)

ἐκ τοῦ οἴνου τοῦ θυμοῦ τῆς πορνείας αὐτῆς, πέπτωκαν πάντα τὰ ἔθνη

"all the nations have drunk from the wine of her immoral passion"

See how you translated the similar expression in 17:2. Here, as there, this statement is not intended literally even within the world of this vision. Alternate translation: [all the nations have indulged in idolatry and greed with her]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 18:3 (#3)

οἱ βασιλεῖς τῆς γῆς μετ' αὐτῆς ἐπόρνευσαν

"the kings of the earth have committed sexual immorality with her"

See how you translated the similar expression in 17:2. This statement too is not intended literally. Alternate translation: [the kings of the earth have joined her in being idolatrous and greedy]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 18:4 (#1)

ἤκουσα ἄλλην φωνὴν ἐκ τοῦ οὐρανοῦ λέγουσαν

"I heard another voice from heaven saying"

John is referring to someone speaking by association with the **voice** that the person is using to speak. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I heard someone speaking from heaven and saying]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 18:5 (#1)

ἐκολλήθησαν αὐτῆς αἱ ἁμαρτίαι ἄχρι τοῦ οὐρανοῦ

"her sins have been heaped as far as heaven"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. This could mean: (1) Alternate translation: [the heap of her sins is as high as heaven]; (2) Alternate translation: [the heap of her sins is as high as the sky]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 18:5 (#3)

ἐμνημόνευσεν ὁ Θεὸς τὰ ἀδικήματα αὐτῆς

"God has remembered her offenses"

The voice is not suggesting that God had forgotten about Babylon but has now **remembered** the city's **offenses**. The angel is using a common biblical expression that means that God has taken action with regard to a person or entity of which he was already aware, either to help or to punish. See how you translated the similar expression in 16:19. Alternate translation: [God has punished her for her offenses]

See: Idiom

Revelation 18:5 (#2)

ἐκολλήθησαν αὐτῆς αἱ ἁμαρτίαι ἄχρι τοῦ οὐρανοῦ

"her sins have been heaped as far as heaven"

The voice is speaking as if the **sins** of Babylon were literally in a very high pile. He means that Babylon has committed very many sins. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [she has committed very many sins]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 18:6 (#1)

ἀπόδοτε αὐτῇ ὡς καὶ αὐτὴ ἀπέδωκεν, καὶ διπλώσατε τὰ διπλᾶ, κατὰ τὰ ἔργα αὐτῆς

"Give back to her even as she has given, and double doubles {to her} according to her deeds"

The voice from heaven is using a characteristic form of Hebrew speech. The voice is naming a number and then, for emphasis, naming the next higher number. An example of this is in Amos 1:3, "For three sins of Damascus, even for four, I will not turn away punishment." If it might seem to your readers that the voice from heaven was contradicting itself, first saying to punish Babylon one way (just as much as the city hurt others) and then saying to punish Babylon a different way (twice as much as the city hurt others), you could show in your translation that this is actually a progression for emphasis. UST models one way to do this.

See: Parallelism

Revelation 18:6 (#2)

ἀπόδοτε & διπλώσατε & κεράσατε

"Give back & double & to her & mix"

All of these imperatives are plural. (They seem to address the angels whom God has appointed to punish Babylon, as UST indicates.) So use plural imperatives in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of 'You' — Singular

Revelation 18:6 (#3)

διπλώσατε τὰ διπλᾶ, κατὰ τὰ ἔργα αὐτῆς; ἐν τῷ ποτηρίῳ ᾧ ἐκέρασεν, κεράσατε αὐτῇ διπλοῦν

"double doubles {to her} according to her deeds; in the cup that she mixed, mix double for her"

These two phrases mean similar things. The voice from heaven is using repetition to emphasize the idea that the phrases express. The first phrase expresses it literally and the second phrase expresses it figuratively. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine the two phrases. UST models one way of doing this.

See: Parallelism

Revelation 18:6 (#5)

ἐν τῷ ποτηρίῳ ᾧ ἐκέρασεν, κεράσατε αὐτῇ διπλοῦν

"in the cup that she mixed, mix double for her"

The voice is speaking as if Babylon had literally **mixed** a **cup** of wine for others to drink. This is a reprise of the image in 14:8. However, the emphasis here is on how drinking too much wine makes a person stagger. This is an image of how Babylon will stagger from God's punishments. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [punish her in a way that will make her stagger twice as much as she made others stagger]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 18:6 (#4)

διπλώσατε τὰ διπλᾶ

“double doubles {to her”

The voice is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have its own way of expressing the same meaning. Alternate translation: [repay her double]

See: Poetry

Revelation 18:7 (#5)

πένθος οὐ μὴ ἴδω

“I will certainly not see mourning”

Here the word **see** means “to experience.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will not experience any mourning at all]

See: Idiom

Revelation 18:7 (#4)

χήρα οὐκ εἰμί

“I am not a widow”

Babylon is referring to herself as not being dependent on anyone by association with the way that a **widow** in this culture likely would be dependent on others. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am not dependent on anyone]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 18:7 (#3)

κάθημαι βασίλισσα

“I sit {as} a queen”

Here the word **sit** means “to be.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am a queen]

See: Idiom

Revelation 18:7 (#1)

ἐν τῇ καρδίᾳ αὐτῆς λέγει & κάθημαι βασίλισσα... καὶ χήρα οὐκ εἰμί καὶ πένθος οὐ μὴ ἴδω

“she says in her heart, ‘I sit {as} a queen and I am not a widow and I will certainly not see mourning”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [she says in her heart that she sits as a queen and that she is not a widow and that she will not see mourning at all]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Revelation 18:7 (#2)

ἐν τῇ καρδίᾳ αὐτῆς λέγει

“she says in her heart”

Here the **heart** figuratively represents the thoughts and motives. Alternate translation: [she thinks to herself]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 18:8 (#2)

ἐν πυρὶ κατακαυθήσεται

“she will be consumed by fire”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [fire will consume her]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 18:8 (#1)

ἐν μιᾷ ἡμέρᾳ

“in one day”

The voice is using the term **day** to mean a short time. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in just a short time]

See: Idiom

Revelation 18:9 (#1)

καὶ & οἱ βασιλεῖς τῆς γῆς

“And the kings of the earth”

Some versions continue the quotation of the voice from heaven that begins in verse 4 through to the end of this chapter. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to punctuate the quotation the way it does. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to punctuate the quotation the way ULT does and end it with verse 8.

See: Quote Markings

Revelation 18:9 (#4)

τὸν καπνὸν τῆς πυρώσεως αὐτῆς

"the smoke of her burning"

John is referring to the fire that will burn Babylon by association with the **burning** itself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the smoke from the fire that is burning her]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 18:9 (#2)

οἱ & πορνεύσαντες

"the & ones having committed sexual immorality"

Here as in 14:3, committing **sexual immorality** is a symbolic image for worshiping idols. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the ones having worshiped idols]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 18:9 (#3)

κλαύσονται καὶ κόψονται

"will weep and wail"

The terms **weep** and **wail** mean similar things. John is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [will weep bitterly]

See: Doublet

Revelation 18:10 (#4)

μιᾷ ὥρᾳ

"in one hour"

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, in the ancient world, an **hour** was the shortest time span that people envisioned. In contexts such as this one, the term does not mean a literal hour of sixty minutes. It means the shortest time imaginable. Alternate translation: [in such a short time]

See: Idiom

Revelation 18:10 (#5)

ἦλθεν ἡ κρίσις σου

"your judgment has come"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgment**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [God has judged you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 18:10 (#3)

ὅτι μιᾷ ὥρᾳ ἦλθεν ἡ κρίσις σου

"For in one hour your judgment has come"

The kings are speaking directly to the city of Babylon even though they know that the city cannot hear them. They are doing this to show in a very strong way to the people who can hear them, their fellow kings, how they feel about what is happening to Babylon. If someone speaking your language would not do this, you could translate this as the merchants speaking to one another about Babylon rather than to Babylon. Alternate translation: [For in one hour her judgment has come]

See: Apostrophe

Revelation 18:10 (#1)

διὰ τὸν φόβον τοῦ βασανισμοῦ αὐτῆς

"because of the fear of her torment"

John is referring to the fire that is burning up and tormenting Babylon by association with the **torment** itself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because they are afraid of the fire that is tormenting her]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 18:10 (#2)

οὐαὶ, οὐαί

"Woe, woe"

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, the speakers are repeating the word **woe** for emphasis. If it would not be natural in your language to repeat a word like that, you could express the emphasis in another way, for example, by using a different expression and including the word "very," as the UST does.

See: Reduplication

Revelation 18:11 (#1)

κλαίουσιν καὶ πενθοῦσιν

"weep and mourn"

The terms **weep** and **mourn** mean similar things. John is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [weep bitterly]

See: Doublet

Revelation 18:12 (#5)

πᾶν ξύλον θύϊνον

"every citron wood"

Since there is only one kind of **citron** tree, by **every citron wood**, John means by association many kinds of wood that are fragrant like citron wood. Alternate translation: [every fragrant wood]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 18:12 (#4)

πᾶν ξύλον θύϊνον

"every citron wood"

The wood of the **citron** tree is desirable because it is fragrant. If your readers would not be familiar with **citron wood**, you could use a general expression. Alternate translation: [every fragrant wood]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 18:12 (#2)

βυσσίνου, καὶ πορφύρας, καὶ σιρικοῦ, καὶ κοκκίνου

"fine linen and purple cloth and silk and scarlet cloth"

See how you translated **fine linen**, the term for an expensive cloth made from flax, in 15:6; **purple cloth** is a dark red-blue cloth that was very expensive at this time; **silk** is a soft, strong cloth made from the fine string that silkworms make when they form their cocoons; **scarlet cloth** was an expensive red cloth. If some or all of these terms might be unfamiliar to your readers, you could use a general expression in your translation. Alternate translation: [many kinds of expensive cloth]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 18:12 (#1)

λίθου τιμίου

"precious stone"

See how you translated the term **precious stone** in 17:4. Alternate translation: [gemstones]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 18:12 (#6)

σκεῦος ἐλεφάντινον

"ivory vessel"

The word **ivory** describes a beautiful, hard, white material that people get from the tusks or teeth of very large animals such as elephants and walruses. Alternate translation: [beautiful containers made from tusks] or [containers made from valuable animal teeth]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 18:12 (#7)

μαρμάρου

"marble"

The word **marble** describes a beautiful, valuable stone that people use in buildings and to make statues, furniture, and many other things. If your readers might not be familiar with marble, you could use a general expression in your translation. Alternate translation: [beautiful stone]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 18:12 (#3)

πᾶν ξύλον θύϊνον, καὶ πᾶν σκεῦος ἐλεφάντινον, καὶ πᾶν σκεῦος ἐκ ξύλου τιμιωτάτου, καὶ χαλκοῦ, καὶ σιδήρου, καὶ μαρμάρου

"every citron wood and every ivory vessel and every vessel from the costliest wood and bronze and iron and marble"

John says **every** in these cases as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [many kinds of fragrant wood and many kinds of ivory vessels and many kinds of vessels made from precious wood and bronze and iron and marble]

See: Hyperbole

Revelation 18:13 (#1)

κιννάμωμον, καὶ ἄμωμον

"cinnamon and spice"

Since **cinnamon** is one kind of **spice**, John means implicitly that cinnamon was one example of the spices that the merchants sold. You can indicate this your

translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [cinnamon and other spices]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 18:13 (#4)

σωμάτων, καὶ ψυχὰς ἀνθρώπων

“bodies and souls of men”

In this context, the expressions **bodies** and **souls of men** mean the same thing. John is using the two terms together for emphasis. He is first stating how things look on the outside: The bodies of the slaves whom the merchants are trading appear to be just another physical cargo. But John is then stating the real truth: This traffic in slaves is a traffic in human souls. You could indicate this in your translation. Alternate translation: [slaves, that is, the souls of men]

See: Doublet

Revelation 18:13 (#3)

θυμιάματα, καὶ μύρον, καὶ λίβανον

“incense and myrrh and frankincense”

Since **myrrh** and **frankincense** are two kinds of **incense**, John means implicitly that these are two examples of the incense that the merchants sold. You can indicate this your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [myrrh and frankincense and other kinds of incense]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 18:13 (#5)

ψυχὰς ἀνθρώπων

“souls of men”

Although the term **men** is masculine, John is using the word in a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use a term in your language that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [human souls]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Revelation 18:13 (#2)

κιννάμωμον, καὶ ἄμωμον

“cinnamon and spice”

The word **cinnamon** describes a fragrant spice that people make from the bark of a certain tree. If your readers would not be familiar with what cinnamon is, you could use a general term. Alternate translation: [spice from tree bark and other spices]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 18:14 (#8)

πάντα τὰ λιπαρὰ καὶ τὰ λαμπρὰ

“all the luxurious and the splendid”

The terms **luxurious** and **splendid** mean similar things. John is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [all the very luxurious goods]

See: Doublet

Revelation 18:14 (#6)

πάντα τὰ λιπαρὰ καὶ τὰ λαμπρὰ ἀπώλετο ἀπὸ σοῦ, καὶ οὐκέτι οὐ μὴ αὐτὰ εὑρήσουσιν

“all the luxurious and the splendid has perished from you, and they will certainly not be found any longer”

These two phrases mean similar things. John is using repetition to emphasize the idea that the phrases express. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them. Alternate translation: [all the luxurious and the splendid has perished from you forever]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 18:14 (#10)

οὐκέτι οὐ μὴ αὐτὰ εὑρήσουσιν

“they will certainly not be found any longer”

The merchants are actually using a double negative here, “they will not be found at all no longer.” The second negative does not cancel the first to create a positive meaning. If for emphasis your language uses double negatives that do not cancel one another, it would be appropriate to use that construction here in your translation.

See: Double Negatives

Revelation 18:14 (#1)

ἡ ὀπώρα σου τῆς ἐπιθυμίας τῆς ψυχῆς ἀπῆλθεν ἀπὸ σοῦ, καὶ πάντα τὰ λιπαρὰ καὶ τὰ λαμπρὰ ἀπώλετο ἀπὸ σοῦ

“your autumn fruit of the desire of {your} soul has gone away from you, and all the luxurious and the splendid has perished from you”

As John relates this vision, here he addresses something that he knows cannot hear him, the city of Babylon in the vision, in order to show his readers in a strong way how he feels about it. If someone speaking your language would not do this, you could translate this as John speaking about Babylon rather than to Babylon. Alternate translation: [her autumn fruit, the desire of her soul, has gone away from her, and all the luxurious and the splendid has perished from her]

See: Apostrophe

Revelation 18:14 (#4)

ἡ ὀπώρα

"autumn fruit"

John is referring to ripe fruit by association with the way fruit ripens in the **autumn**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [ripe fruit]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 18:14 (#5)

ἡ ὀπώρα & ἀπῆλθεν

"autumn fruit & has gone away"

John is using **autumn fruit** to represent the rich pleasures that Babylon desired. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [rich pleasures ... have gone away]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 18:14 (#7)

πάντα τὰ λιπαρὰ καὶ τὰ λαμπρὰ

"all the luxurious and the splendid"

John is using the adjectives **luxurious** and **splendid** as nouns to mean certain kinds of goods. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this phrase with an equivalent one. Alternate translation: [all the luxurious and splendid goods] or [everything that is luxurious and splendid]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 18:14 (#3)

ἡ ὀπώρα σου τῆς ἐπιθυμίας τῆς ψυχῆς ἀπῆλθεν

"your autumn fruit of the desire of {your} soul has gone away"

Here the term **soul** represents the whole person by association with the way that each person has a soul. Alternate translation: [the autumn fruit that you desired has gone away]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 18:14 (#11)

οὐ μὴ αὐτὰ εὑρήσουσιν

"they will certainly not be found"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [certainly no one will find them]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 18:14 (#2)

ἡ ὀπώρα σου τῆς ἐπιθυμίας τῆς ψυχῆς

"your autumn fruit of the desire of {your} soul"

In this possessive form, **fruit** is the object of **desire** rather than the result of **desire**. That is, this does not mean fruit that the soul's desire has borne, but it means fruit that the soul desires to have. Alternate translation: [the autumn fruit that your soul desires to have]

See: Possession

Revelation 18:14 (#9)

οὐκέτι οὐ μὴ αὐτὰ εὑρήσουσιν

"they will certainly not be found any longer"

Here the expression **will not be found** means "will not be able to be found" or "will not be there." Alternate translation: [they will not be there any longer]

See: Idiom

Revelation 18:15 (#2)

κλαίοντες καὶ πενθοῦντες

"weeping and mourning"

The terms **weeping** and **mourning** mean similar things. John is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [weeping bitterly]

See: Doublet

Revelation 18:15 (#1)

διὰ τὸν φόβον τοῦ βασανισμοῦ αὐτῆς

“because of the fear of her torment”

See how you translated this same expression in 18:10. Alternate translation: [because they are afraid of the fire that is tormenting her]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 18:16 (#1)

ἡ περιβεβλημένη βύσσινον, καὶ πορφυροῦν, καὶ κόκκινον, καὶ κεχρυσωμένη ἐν χρυσίῳ, καὶ λίθῳ τιμίῳ, καὶ μαργαρίτῃ

“having been dressed in fine linen and purple and scarlet and adorned with gold and precious stones and pearls”

The merchants are speaking as if the city of Babylon had literally been **dressed** in expensive clothing and **adorned** with jewels. They mean that the people of the city lived in luxury. Even if your language does not ordinarily use figures of speech, you may wish to preserve this figure of speech in your translation so that your readers can see how the merchants were speaking about Babylon. One way to do that would be to translate it as a simile, as UST does.

See: Metaphor

Revelation 18:16 (#3)

βύσσινον, καὶ πορφυροῦν, καὶ κόκκινον & χρυσίῳ, καὶ λίθῳ τιμίῳ, καὶ μαργαρίτῃ

“fine linen and purple and scarlet & gold and precious stones and pearls”

See how you translated each of these terms in 18:12.

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 18:16 (#2)

ἡ περιβεβλημένη βύσσινον, καὶ πορφυροῦν, καὶ κόκκινον, καὶ κεχρυσωμένη

“having been dressed in fine linen and purple and scarlet and adorned”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [that dressed in fine linen and purple and scarlet and adorned herself]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 18:17 (#1)

ἠρημώθη ὁ τοσοῦτος πλοῦτος

“so much wealth has been destroyed”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God has destroyed so much wealth]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 18:17 (#3)

ὅσοι τὴν θάλασσαν ἐργάζονται

“as many as work the sea”

John is using this general expression to mean anyone else who, like the previous three kinds of people he mentions in this verse, earns a living from the sea in some way. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [as many others as earn their living from the sea]

See: Idiom

Revelation 18:17 (#2)

κυβερνήτης

“shipmaster”

The word **shipmaster** refers to a particular member of a ship’s crew. In this context, this could mean: (1) the captain of a ship. Alternate translation, as in UST: [ship captain]; (2) the person who steers a ship. Alternate translation: [navigator]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 18:18 (#3)

τίς

“What”

By **What**, the sea workers implicitly mean “What city.” You can say this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [What city] or, in an exclamation, [No other city]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 18:18 (#1)

τὸν καπνὸν τῆς πυρώσεως αὐτῆς

“the smoke of her burning”

See how you translated the same expression in 18:9. Alternate translation: [the smoke from the fire that is burning her]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 18:18 (#2)

τίς ὁμοία τῇ πόλει τῇ μεγάλῃ

“What {is} like the great city”

The sea workers are using the question form for emphasis. If you would not use the question form for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Nothing is like the great city!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Revelation 18:19 (#1)

ἔβαλον χοῦν ἐπὶ τὰς κεφαλὰς αὐτῶν

“they threw dust on their heads”

The sea workers **threw dust on their heads** as a symbolic action to show how distressed they were that Babylon had been destroyed. If this would not be clear to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [they threw dust on their heads to show how distressed they were]

See: Symbolic Action

Revelation 18:19 (#4)

ἠρημώθη

“she has been destroyed”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God has destroyed her]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 18:19 (#2)

κλαίοντες καὶ πενθοῦντες

“weeping and mourning”

The terms **weeping** and **mourning** mean similar things. John is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [weeping bitterly]

See: Doublet

Revelation 18:19 (#3)

τὰ πλοῖα ἐν τῇ θαλάσσῃ

“ships in the sea”

It might seem that the expression **ships in the sea** contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [ships]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Revelation 18:20 (#1)

εὐφραίνου

“Rejoice”

The sea workers finish speaking at the end of verse 19. Someone else begins speaking here. It would be appropriate to show this in your translation by using whatever punctuation or convention your language uses to show the end of one quotation and the beginning of another.

See: Quote Markings

Revelation 18:20 (#3)

εὐφραίνου

“Rejoice”

The implied “you” in the imperative **Rejoice** is singular here because this imperative addresses **heaven**. The pronoun **you** is plural because it addresses the **saints and apostles and prophets**. So use a singular imperative and a plural pronoun in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Revelation 18:20 (#2)

εὐφραίνου

“Rejoice”

In this verse, someone breaks into John’s narrative of his vision to speak directly to the audience in heaven and on earth. ULT puts the verse in parentheses to show this. There may be a comparable convention in your language that you can use in your translation. You can also state explicitly who is speaking, as UST does. That speaker could be: (1) the voice from heaven that spoke in 18:4–8 or another voice from heaven. (2) Jesus, as in 16:15. (3) John himself.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 18:20 (#5)

ἔκρινεν ὁ Θεὸς τὸ κρίμα ὑμῶν ἐξ αὐτῆς

“God has judged your judgment against her”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgment**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [God has judged her for what she did to you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 18:20 (#6)

ἔκρινεν ὁ Θεὸς τὸ κρίμα ὑμῶν ἐξ αὐτῆς

"God has judged your judgment against her"

The speaker is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have its own way of describing this. Alternate translation: [she deserved to be judged for what she did to you, and God has indeed judged her]

See: Poetry

Revelation 18:20 (#4)

οὐρανέ

"heaven"

The speaker is referring to everyone who lives in heaven by association with **heaven** itself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all of you who live in heaven]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 18:21 (#5)

ὁρμήματι

"with violence"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **violence**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [violently]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 18:21 (#2)

μύλινον

"a & millstone"

A **millstone** is a large, flat, round stone that people use to crush kernels of grain against a second **millstone**, processing the grain into food for humans. If your readers would not be familiar with what a millstone is, in your translation you could use the name of a comparable object in your culture or you could use a general expression.

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 18:21 (#4)

οὕτως ὁρμήματι βληθήσεται Βαβυλὼν ἡ μεγάλη πόλις

"Thus Babylon, the great city, will be thrown down with violence"

The angel is speaking as if Babylon will literally be **thrown down** as if from a height. He means that the city will be completely destroyed. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God will completely destroy Babylon, the great city]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 18:21 (#3)

οὕτως ὁρμήματι βληθήσεται Βαβυλὼν ἡ μεγάλη πόλις

"Thus Babylon, the great city, will be thrown down with violence"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God will throw down Babylon, the great city]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 18:21 (#1)

λίθον ὡς μύλινον μέγαν

"a stone like a great millstone"

The point of this comparison is that the **stone** that the **angel took up** was very large and heavy and so it made a tremendous, dramatic splash when it hit the **sea**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [a stone that was very large and heavy like a great millstone]

See: Simile

Revelation 18:21 (#6)

οὐ μὴ εὑρεθῇ ἔτι

"she will certainly not be seen anymore"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [no one at all will see her anymore]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 18:22 (#4)

πᾶς τεχνίτης οὐ μὴ εὑρεθῇ

“every craftsman will certainly not be found”

Here the expression **will not be found** means “will not be able to be found” or “will not be there.” Alternate translation: [no craftsman will be there]

See: Idiom

Revelation 18:22 (#1)

καὶ φωνὴ κιθαρῳδῶν, καὶ μουσικῶν, καὶ αὐλητῶν, καὶ σαλπιστῶν, οὐ μὴ ἀκουσθῇ

“and the sound of harpists and musicians and flutists and trumpeters will certainly not be heard”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and no one at all will hear the sound of harpists and musicians and flutists and trumpeters]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 18:22 (#5)

φωνὴ μύλου οὐ μὴ ἀκουσθῇ

“the sound of a mill will certainly not be heard”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [no one at all will hear the sound of a mill]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 18:22 (#2)

ἐν σοὶ & ἐν σοὶ & ἐν σοὶ

“in you & in you & in you”

The angel is speaking directly to the city of Babylon even though he knows that the city cannot hear him. He is doing this to show in a very strong way to the people who can hear them, probably “heaven” and the “saints and apostles and prophets” from verse 20, how he feels about what is happening to Babylon. If someone speaking your language would not do this, you could translate this as the angel speaking about Babylon rather than to Babylon. Alternate translation: [in her ... in her ... in her]

See: Apostrophe

Revelation 18:22 (#3)

πᾶς τεχνίτης οὐ μὴ εὑρεθῇ

“every craftsman will certainly not be found”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [no one at all will find a craftsman]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 18:23 (#6)

πάντα τὰ ἔθνη

“all the nations”

The angel says **all** here as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [nations throughout the world]

See: Hyperbole

Revelation 18:23 (#1)

ἐν σοὶ & ἐν σοὶ

“in you & in you”

As in verse 22, for emphasis the angel is speaking directly to the city of Babylon even though he knows that the city cannot hear him. If someone speaking your language would not do this, you could translate this as the angel speaking about Babylon rather than to Babylon. Alternate translation: [in her ... in her]

See: Apostrophe

Revelation 18:23 (#5)

ἐν τῇ φαρμακείᾳ σου ἐπλανήθησαν πάντα τὰ ἔθνη

“all the nations were deceived by your sorcery”

The angel is speaking as if these Babylon had literally used **sorcery** to deceive the nations. He likely means that Babylon made living in excessive luxury seem attractive and acceptable. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you influenced all the nations to try to live in luxury]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 18:23 (#3)

φωνὴ

“the voice”

Since the angel is referring to two people, it might be more natural in your language to use the plural form of **voice** or the dual form if your language marks that distinction. Alternate translation: [the voices]

See: Collective Nouns

Revelation 18:23 (#4)

ἐν τῇ φαρμακείᾳ σου ἐπλανήθησαν πάντα τὰ ἔθνη

"all the nations were deceived by your sorcery"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [you deceived all the nations by your sorcery]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 18:23 (#2)

φωνὴ νυμφίου καὶ νύμφης οὐ μὴ ἀκουσθῇ

"the voice of a bridegroom and a bride will certainly not be heard"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [no one at all will hear the voice of a bridegroom and a bride]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 18:24 (#1)

εὑρέθη

"was found"

Here the expression **was found** means "could be found" or "was there." Alternate translation: [was]

See: Idiom

Revelation 18:24 (#3)

πάντων τῶν ἐσφαγμένων ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς

"of all the ones having been slain on the earth"

This could mean: (1) that the angel is saying **all** here as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [of ones having been slain throughout the earth]; (2) that the angel is using a passive verbal form (See: next note) to refer to all the other **ones**, besides **prophets** and **saints**, whom Babylon slew. Alternate translation: [of all the other ones she slew on the earth]

See: Hyperbole

Revelation 18:24 (#2)

ἐν αὐτῇ αἷμα προφητῶν καὶ ἁγίων εὑρέθη

"in her was found the blood of prophets and saints"

The implication is that this **blood** is evidence that Babylon is guilty of killing the **prophets and saints**. You can provide this information in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [she was clearly guilty of killing prophets and saints]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 18:24 (#4)

πάντων τῶν ἐσφαγμένων

"of all the ones having been slain"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [of all the ones she slew]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation - Chapter 19 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

- Verses 1–4 conclude the topic of the destruction of Babylon.
- Verses 5–10 introduce the topic of the wedding of the Lamb.
- Verses 11–21 describe the destruction of the beast and the false prophet.

Some translations set each line of poetry farther to the right than the rest of the text to make it easier to read. The ULT does this with verses 1–8.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Songs

The book of Revelation often describes heaven as a place where people sing. They worship God with songs. This illustrates that heaven is a place where God is always worshiped. (See: heaven, sky, heavens, heavenly)

Wedding celebration

The wedding celebration or feast is an important image in Scripture. Jewish culture often pictured paradise, or life with God after death, as a feast. Here, the wedding feast is for the Lamb, who is Jesus, and his bride, meaning all his people.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

"Hallelujah"
The word **Hallelujah** occurs in verses 1, 3, 4, and 6. This is a Hebrew word that John spells out using Greek letters so that his readers will know how it sounds. The word is a plural imperative that means, "Praise Yahweh!" In your translation, you could spell this word the way it sounds in your language, or you could translate its meaning by using a phrase such as, "Praise God." (See: Copy or Borrow Words)

"us/our"
In verses 1, 5, and 6, speakers say "our," and in verse 7 a speaker says "us." In each case the speaker is referring to himself and to his addressees, so use the inclusive form of those words in your translation if your language marks that distinction. (See: Exclusive and Inclusive 'We')

Revelation 19:1 (#2)

ἡμῶν

"our"

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, here and throughout the chapter it would be appropriate to use the inclusive form of **our** and "us" in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Exclusive and Inclusive 'We'

Revelation 19:1 (#1)

ἡ σωτηρία, καὶ ἡ δόξα, καὶ ἡ δύναμις, τοῦ Θεοῦ ἡμῶν

"Salvation and glory and power to our God"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **salvation**, **glory**, and **power**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [Worship God as the one who saves us and who is glorious and powerful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 19:2 (#3)

τῶν δούλων αὐτοῦ ἐκ χειρὸς αὐτῆς

"of his servants from her hand"

John is using one part of the **great prostitute**, her **hand**, to represent all of her in the act of killing or shedding the **blood** of God's **servants**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [of his servants, whom she killed]

See: Synecdoche

Revelation 19:2 (#1)

ἀληθιναὶ καὶ δίκαιαι

"are} true and righteous"

The terms **true** and **righteous** mean similar things. John may be using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [entirely righteous]

See: Doublet

Revelation 19:2 (#2)

τὸ αἷμα

"the blood"

John is referring to the death of God's **servants** by association with the **blood** that they shed when they were killed. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the death]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 19:3 (#2)

ὁ καπνὸς αὐτῆς

"the smoke of her"

See how you translated the similar expression in 18:9. Alternate translation: [the smoke from the fire that is burning her]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 19:3 (#3)

εἰς τοὺς αἰῶνας τῶν αἰώνων

"to the ages of the ages"

This expression refers to endless future time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for all eternity]

See: Idiom

Revelation 19:3 (#1)

δεύτερον

"a second {time"

John is using the adjective **second** as a noun to mean a certain time. ULT adds the word **time** to show that. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [again]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 19:4 (#1)

ἔπεσαν & καὶ προσεκύνησαν τῷ Θεῷ

“fell down and worshiped God”

Be sure that it is clear in your translation that the **elders** and **living creatures** did not fall down accidentally. Rather, bowing or lying down in front of God was a sign of humility and respect. Alternate translation: [bowed down in front of God to worship him]

See: Symbolic Action

Revelation 19:5 (#1)

πάντες οἱ δοῦλοι αὐτοῦ, καὶ οἱ φοβούμενοι αὐτόν

“all his servants and the ones fearing him”

The voice is actually not speaking in the third person about the people whom he wants to **Praise ... God**. The voice is using a vocative form. However, if your language does not have a vocative form and it might appear as if the voice is using the third person for people whom he is addressing, you could use the second person in your translation. Alternate translation: [you his servants and you who fear him]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Revelation 19:5 (#3)

οἱ μικροὶ καὶ οἱ μεγάλοι

“the small and the great”

The voice is speaking as if unimportant people were literally **small** and as if important people were literally large or **great**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the unimportant and the important]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 19:5 (#2)

οἱ φοβούμενοι αὐτόν

“the ones fearing him”

In this context, the word **fearing** does not mean to be afraid but to show respect and reverence. Alternate translation: [the ones who revere him] or [you who revere him]

See: Idiom

Revelation 19:5 (#4)

οἱ μικροὶ καὶ οἱ μεγάλοι

“the small and the great”

The voice is using the adjectives **small** and **great** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate these words with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [both unimportant people and important people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 19:5 (#5)

οἱ μικροὶ καὶ οἱ μεγάλοι

“the small and the great”

The voice is using two extremes of people, **small** and **great**, to mean them and everyone in between. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [whatever your status]

See: Merism

Revelation 19:6 (#3)

ἡμῶν

“our”

The person speaking here is likely continuing to address those who serve and fear God. So by **our**, the speaker means himself and them, so use the inclusive form of that word in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Exclusive and Inclusive ‘We’

Revelation 19:6 (#2)

ὑδάτων πολλῶν

“of many waters”

By **many waters**, John could mean a loud waterfall or raging floodwaters. See how you translated the similar expression in 1:15. Alternate translation: [of a waterfall] or [of raging floodwaters]

See: Idiom

Revelation 19:6 (#1)

ὡς φωνὴν ὄχλου πολλοῦ, καὶ ὡς φωνὴν ὑδάτων πολλῶν, καὶ ὡς φωνὴν βροντῶν ἰσχυρῶν

“as it were the sound of a great crowd and as it were the sound of many waters and as it were the sound of powerful thunder”

The point of this comparison is that the **sound** was very loud. If it would be helpful in your language, you

could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [a sound that was very loud, like the sound of a great crowd or many waters or powerful thunder]

See: Simile

Revelation 19:7 (#2)

δῶμεν τὴν δόξαν αὐτῷ

"give glory to him"

The expression **give glory to him** does not mean that God lacks glory in any way or that people have glory that they can give to God. It means to honor God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [honor him]

See: Idiom

Revelation 19:7 (#3)

ἦλθεν ὁ γάμος τοῦ Ἀρνίου

"the wedding of the Lamb has come"

If you would not speak in your language of an event as if it **has come**, you could express this in the way that is most natural in your language. Alternate translation: [it is time for the wedding of the Lamb]

See: Idiom

Revelation 19:7 (#1)

χαίρωμεν καὶ ἀγαλλιῶμεν

"Let us rejoice and exult"

The terms **rejoice** and **exult** mean similar things. The sound is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Let us rejoice greatly]

See: Doublet

Revelation 19:8 (#1)

ἐδόθη αὐτῇ ἵνα περιβάληται

"it has been granted to her that she might be dressed"

If your language does not use these passive forms, you could express the ideas in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who has done the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God has granted to her that she might dress]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 19:8 (#2)

τὸ γὰρ βύσσινον τὰ δικαιώματα τῶν ἁγίων ἐστίν

"For fine linen is the righteous acts of the saints"

Here John provides some background information about the symbolism in his vision in order to help his readers understand what he is describing. ULT shows that this is background information by putting it in parentheses. This information is helpful for understanding the symbolic significance of **fine linen** and for understanding the symbolism of the book generally. See what you did with the similar background information in 1:20. Alternate translation: [The bride in my vision dressed in fine linen because that bright, clean fabric symbolically represents the righteous acts of the saints]

See: Background Information

Revelation 19:9 (#1)

λέγει

"he says"

The pronoun **he** probably refers to the same angel who began to speak to John in 17:1. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The angel who told me he would show me the judgment of the great prostitute said]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 19:9 (#3)

οἱ & κεκλημένοι

"the ones having been called"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [the ones whom God has called]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 19:9 (#4)

οὗτοι οἱ λόγοι ἀληθινοὶ εἰσιν τοῦ Θεοῦ

"These are true words of God"

The angel is using the term **words** to mean the saying that he told John to **Write** by using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [This is something that God has truly said]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 19:9 (#2)

γράψον, μακάριοι οἱ εἰς τὸ δεῖπνον τοῦ γάμου τοῦ Ἀρνίου κεκλημένοι

"Write, 'Blessed {are} the ones having been called to the supper of the wedding of the Lamb"

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [Write that the ones having been invited to the wedding supper of the Lamb are blessed]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Revelation 19:10 (#5)

τῶν ἀδελφῶν σου

"your brothers"

Although the term **brothers** is masculine, here the word has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If you wish to retain the figurative expression in your translation, you could word it in a way that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [your brothers and sisters]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Revelation 19:10 (#4)

τῶν ἀδελφῶν σου

"your brothers"

The angel is using the term **brothers** figuratively to mean people who share the same faith. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your fellow believers]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 19:10 (#6)

τῶν ἐχόντων τὴν μαρτυρίαν Ἰησοῦ

"having the testimony of Jesus"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **testimony**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [who testify to their faith in Jesus]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 19:10 (#2)

ὅρα μή

"See not"

The angel is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [See that you do not do that]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 19:10 (#7)

τῶν ἐχόντων τὴν μαρτυρίαν Ἰησοῦ

"having the testimony of Jesus"

In this possessive form, **Jesus** is the object rather than the subject of **testimony**. That is, this does not mean testimony that Jesus himself gives; it means testimony that believers give about their faith in Jesus. Alternate translation: [who testify to their faith in Jesus]

See: Possession

Revelation 19:10 (#8)

ἡ & μαρτυρία Ἰησοῦ ἐστιν τὸ πνεῦμα τῆς προφητείας

"the testimony of Jesus is the spirit of prophecy"

The angel is speaking of **prophecy** as if it were a living thing that had a **spirit**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the impulse to testify to Jesus is what inspires prophecy]

See: Personification

Revelation 19:10 (#1)

ἔπεσα ἔμπροσθεν τῶν ποδῶν αὐτοῦ

"I fell before his feet"

Be sure that it is clear in your translation that John did not fall down accidentally. Rather, bowing or lying down in front of this angel was a sign of humility and respect. Alternate translation: [I bowed down at his feet] or [I bowed down to the ground in front of him]

See: Symbolic Action

Revelation 19:10 (#3)

ὅρα μή

"See not"

The angel is using the term **See** to mean by association that John should give careful attention to what he is doing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Watch out! Do not do that!] or [Be careful not to do that]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 19:11 (#4)

ὁ καθήμενος ἐπ᾽ αὐτὸν, Πιστὸς καλούμενος καὶ Ἀληθινός

“the one riding on it, being called Faithful and True”

This could mean: (1) that **Faithful** and **True** are two names by which people call Jesus. Alternate translation: [the one riding on it, two of whose names are Faithful and True]; (2) that “faithful” and “true” are two qualities that people ascribe to Jesus. Alternate translation: [the one riding on it, whom people acknowledge to be faithful and true]

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 19:11 (#3)

ὁ καθήμενος ἐπ᾽ αὐτὸν, Πιστὸς καλούμενος καὶ Ἀληθινός

“the one riding on it, being called Faithful and True”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the one whom people call Faithful and True riding on it]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 19:11 (#1)

εἶδον τὸν οὐρανὸν ἠνεῳγμένον

“I saw heaven having been opened”

When John says that **heaven** had been opened, he likely means by association that in his vision, God created some opening that allowed him to see into heaven. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God allowed me to look into heaven]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 19:11 (#2)

τὸν οὐρανὸν ἠνεῳγμένον

“heaven having been opened”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [that God had opened heaven]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 19:11 (#6)

ἐν δικαιοσύνῃ

“in righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [righteously]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 19:11 (#5)

Πιστὸς & καὶ Ἀληθινός

“Faithful and True”

The terms **Faithful** and **True** mean similar things. John is mentioning the two names together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Supremely Faithful] or [Entirely True]

See: Doublet

Revelation 19:12 (#2)

φλὸξ πυρός

“being} a flame of fire”

It might seem that the expression **a flame of fire** contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [flames]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Revelation 19:12 (#3)

γεγραμμένον

“written”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [in writing]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 19:12 (#1)

οἱ δὲ ὀφθαλμοὶ αὐτοῦ φλὸξ πυρός

“his eyes also {being} a flame of fire”

John is speaking as if the **eyes** of the one riding on the white horse were actually a **flame of fire**. This is something that could be taken literally within the world of the vision, but it is more likely that John

means this as a comparison, as in 1:14 and 2:18. In that case, the point of the comparison would be that Jesus has eyes that are so bright and lively that they resemble a burning flame. See how you translated this earlier in the book. Alternate translation: [whose eyes also glow like a flame of fire]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 19:12 (#4)

ὃ οὐδεὶς οἶδεν, εἰ μὴ αὐτός

“that no one knows except himself”

If it would appear in your language that John was contradicting himself by saying that **no one** knows this **name** and then saying that someone does know this name, you could reword this to avoid using an exception clause. Alternate translation: [that only he knows]

See: Connect — Exception Clauses

Revelation 19:12 (#5)

ὃ οὐδεὶς οἶδεν, εἰ μὴ αὐτός

“that no one knows except himself”

It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. This could mean: (1) that no one except Jesus **knows** the meaning of the **name**. Alternate translation: [Only he knows the meaning of that name]; (2) that no one except Jesus **knows** what the **name** is. Alternate translation: [Only he knows what that name is]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 19:13 (#3)

κέκληται τὸ ὄνομα αὐτοῦ

“his name is called”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [people call him]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 19:13 (#2)

κέκληται τὸ ὄνομα αὐτοῦ

“his name is called”

It might seem that the expression **his name is called** contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [his name is] or [he is called]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Revelation 19:13 (#1)

περιβεβλημένος ἱμάτιον βεβαμμένον αἵματι

“having been clothed with a robe dipped in blood”

If your language does not use these passive forms, you could express the ideas in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [wearing a robe that he had dipped in blood]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 19:14 (#1)

ἐνδεδυμένοι βύσσινον

“having been clothed in fine linen”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [wearing fine linen]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 19:15 (#1)

ἐκ τοῦ στόματος αὐτοῦ ἐκπορεύεται ῥομφαία ὀξεῖα

“from his mouth goes out a sharp sword”

Be sure it is clear in your translation, here and for the similar expression in verse 21, that this means that the blade of the **sword** was sticking out of **his mouth**. The sword itself was not in motion. See how you translated the similar phrase in 1:16.

See: Symbolic Language

Revelation 19:15 (#4)

τοῦ θυμοῦ τῆς ὀργῆς

“of the wrath of the fury”

The terms **wrath** and **fury** mean similar things. John is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [of the great wrath]

See: Doublet

Revelation 19:15 (#3)

αὐτὸς πατεῖ τὴν ληνὸν τοῦ οἴνου

“he tramples the winepress of the wine”

John is referring to the grapes in the winepress by association with the **winepress** itself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he tramples the grapes in the winepress to make the wine]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 19:15 (#2)

ἐν ῥάβδῳ σιδηρᾷ

"with an iron scepter"

See how you translated the similar phrase in 2:27 and 12:5. Alternate translation: [with great strength] or [with irresistible power]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 19:16 (#2)

ἐπὶ τὸ ἱμάτιον καὶ ἐπὶ τὸν μηρὸν αὐτοῦ

"on {his} robe and on his thigh"

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two phrases connected with **and**. The phrase **on his thigh** tells where **on his robe** this name is written. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase that does not use "and." Alternate translation: [on his robe at his thigh]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 19:16 (#1)

ἔχει & ὄνομα γεγραμμένον

"he has a name written"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [he has written a name]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 19:17 (#2)

συνάχθητε

"be gathered together"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [gather together]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 19:17 (#1)

ἐν τῷ ἡλίῳ

"in the sun"

John is referring to the light of the sun by association with **the sun** itself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in bright sunlight]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 19:18 (#2)

ἰσχυρῶν & ἐλευθέρων & μικρῶν & μεγάλων

"of the mighty & of free & of small & of great"

John is using these adjectives as nouns to mean a certain kinds of persons. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. (All of these adjectives are plural.) If not, you could translate these words with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [of mighty people ... of free people ... of small people ... of great people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 19:18 (#5)

μικρῶν καὶ μεγάλων

"of small and of great"

John is speaking as if unimportant people were literally **small** and as if important people were literally large or **great**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [of the unimportant and of the important] or [of unimportant people and of important people]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 19:18 (#1)

χιλιάρχων

"of chiliarchs"

The word **chiliarchs** describes officers in the Roman army who were in charge of groups of 1,000 soldiers. Alternate translation: [commanders]

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 19:18 (#3)

πάντων, ἐλευθέρων τε καὶ δούλων, καὶ μικρῶν καὶ μεγάλων

"of all, both of free and of slaves and of small and of great"

John is using two extremes of status, whether people are **free** or **slaves**, to mean people across the entire range of status. John is using two extremes of importance, whether people are **small** or **great**, to mean people across the entire range of importance. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use equivalent expressions or plain language. Alternate translation: [of all people, no matter what their status and no matter what their importance]

See: Merism

Revelation 19:18 (#4)

πάντων, ἐλευθέρων τε καὶ δούλων, καὶ μικρῶν καὶ μεγάλων

"of all, both of free and of slaves and of small and of great"

These two phrases mean similar things. John is using repetition to emphasize the idea that the phrases express. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them. Alternate translation: [of people of every different kind]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 19:19 (#1)

εἶδον τὸ θηρίον, καὶ τοὺς βασιλεῖς τῆς γῆς, καὶ τὰ στρατεύματα αὐτῶν, συνηγμένα

"I saw the beast and the kings of the earth and their armies having been gathered"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I saw that the beast and the kings of the earth and their armies had gathered]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 19:20 (#2)

ἐνώπιον αὐτοῦ

"before him"

Here the word **before** means "in front of" or "in the presence of" another person. Alternate translation: [in his presence]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 19:20 (#3)

ἐβλήθησαν οἱ δύο

"The two were thrown"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the one riding on the horse threw the two]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 19:20 (#1)

ἐπιάσθη τὸ θηρίον

"the beast was captured"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the army of the one sitting on the horse captured the beast]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 19:20 (#4)

οἱ δύο

"The two"

John is using the adjective **two** as a noun to mean two particular beings. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [The beast and the false prophet]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 19:21 (#3)

ἐχορτάσθησαν ἐκ τῶν σαρκῶν αὐτῶν

"were gorged with their flesh"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [gorged themselves on their flesh]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 19:21 (#1)

οἱ λοιποὶ ἀπεκτάνθησαν ἐν τῇ ῥομφαίᾳ τοῦ καθημένου ἐπὶ τοῦ ἵππου, τῇ ἐξελθούσῃ ἐκ τοῦ στόματος αὐτοῦ

"the rest were killed by the sword of the one sitting on the horse, coming out from his mouth"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the one sitting on the horse killed the rest with the sword coming out from his mouth]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 19:21 (#2)

οἱ λοιποὶ

"the rest"

By **the rest**, John implicitly means the rest of the beast's soldiers. You can provide this information in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the rest of the beast's soldiers]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation - Chapter 20 Introduction

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

The thousand-year reign of Christ
In this chapter, Jesus is said to reign for a thousand years, at the same time when Satan is bound. Some scholars believe that this refers to a future period of time, while others believe that it refers to Jesus reigning now from heaven. It is not necessary to decide between these options in order to translate this passage accurately. (See: prophet, prophecy, prophesy, seer, prophetess)

Final rebellion
This chapter also describes what happens after the thousand years. At that time, Satan and many people will attempt to rebel against Jesus. This will result in God's ultimate and final victory over sin and evil. (See: sin, sinful, sinner, sinning; and evil, wicked, wickedness, unpleasant; and eternity, everlasting, eternal, forever)

Great white throne
This chapter ends with a vision of God sitting on a "great white throne" and judging all the people who have ever lived. God separates people who believe in Jesus from those who do not believe in him. (See: judge, judgment; and heaven, sky, heavens, heavenly; and faith)

Translation Issues in This Chapter

The Book of Life
This symbolically represents eternal life. Those possessing eternal life are said to have their names written in this Book of Life. However, since this is something that John actually saw in his vision, it would be appropriate to preserve this image in your translation. (See: Metaphor)

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Hades and the lake of fire
These appear to be two distinct places. Hades appears to be the place where souls go after physical death, while the lake of fire appears to be the place where people experience spiritual death. The translator should be careful to choose appropriate language to describe each place, showing that these are not both the same place. (See: hell, lake of fire)

Revelation 20:2 (#1)

τὸν ὄφιν τὸν ἀρχαῖον, ὅς ἐστιν Διάβολος καὶ ὁ Σατανᾶς

"the ancient serpent, who is the devil and Satan"

John assumes that his readers will understand that the phrase **the ancient serpent** is an allusion to the way **the devil** appeared in the form of a serpent to Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden, as Genesis 3:1–15 describes. You can indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [who appeared in the form of a serpent to Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden, who is the devil and Satan]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 20:2 (#3)

Διάβολος καὶ ὁ Σατανᾶς

"the devil and Satan"

The word **devil** and the name **Satan** refer to the same person. John is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [the devil himself]

See: Doublet

Revelation 20:2 (#2)

τὸν ὄφιν τὸν ἀρχαῖον, ὅς ἐστιν Διάβολος καὶ ὁ Σατανᾶς

"the ancient serpent, who is the devil and Satan"

It may be easier for your readers to recognize the allusion that John is making if you put the information that the dragon represents **the devil and Satan** before the information that this is also **the ancient serpent**. Alternate translation: [who is the devil and Satan, who appeared in the form of a serpent to Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden]

See: Information Structure

Revelation 20:3 (#1)

ἄχρι τελεσθῇ τὰ χίλια ἔτη

“until the thousand years were ended”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [until the thousand years had ended]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 20:3 (#2)

δεῖ αὐτὸν λυθῆναι

“it is necessary for him to be released”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who will do the action, the context suggests that it may be the angel who has “the key to the abyss,” as 20:1 describes. Alternate translation: [God will command the angel to release him]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 20:4 (#6)

τὴν μαρτυρίαν Ἰησοῦ

“the testimony of Jesus”

In this possessive form, **Jesus** is the object rather than the subject of **testimony**. That is, this does not mean testimony that Jesus gives; it means testimony that people give about their faith in Jesus. Alternate translation: [testifying to Jesus]

See: Possession

Revelation 20:4 (#3)

κρίμα ἐδόθη αὐτοῖς

“judgment was given to them”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgment**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [God gave them authority to judge]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 20:4 (#8)

ἐπὶ τὸ μέτωπον, καὶ ἐπὶ τὴν χεῖρα αὐτῶν

“on the forehead or on their hand”

In this verse, the words **forehead** and **hand** are singular in form, but they refer to all of them as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could say this plainly. Alternate translation: [on their foreheads or on their hands]

See: Collective Nouns

Revelation 20:4 (#5)

διὰ τὴν μαρτυρίαν Ἰησοῦ, καὶ διὰ τὸν λόγον τοῦ Θεοῦ

“for the testimony of Jesus and for the word of God”

These two phrases mean similar things. John is using repetition to emphasize the idea that the phrases express. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them. Alternate translation: [for proclaiming the message from God about Jesus]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 20:4 (#4)

τῶν πεπελεκισμένων

“of the ones having been beheaded”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [of the ones whom the Roman government had beheaded]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 20:4 (#7)

τὸν λόγον τοῦ Θεοῦ

“the word of God”

John is using the term **word** to mean the message that these believers had shared by using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [sharing the message from God]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 20:4 (#1)

ἐκάθισαν ἐπ’ αὐτούς, καὶ κρίμα ἐδόθη αὐτοῖς

“they sat on them and judgment was given to them”

The pronouns **they** and **them** refer to people whom John describes in the rest of the verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and these are the ones who sat on them and to whom judgment was given:]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 20:4 (#2)

κρίμα ἐδόθη αὐτοῖς

"judgment was given to them"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God gave judgment to them]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 20:5 (#2)

οἱ λοιποὶ τῶν νεκρῶν οὐκ ἔζησαν, ἄχρι τελεσθῇ τὰ χίλια ἔτη

"The rest of the dead did not live until the thousand years were ended"

It may be more natural in your language to state this positively. Alternate translation: [The rest of the dead only lived again once the thousand years had ended]

Revelation 20:5 (#1)

οἱ λοιποὶ τῶν νεκρῶν οὐκ ἔζησαν, ἄχρι τελεσθῇ τὰ χίλια ἔτη

"The rest of the dead did not live until the thousand years were ended"

With this sentence, John is providing background information that will help readers understand what happens next in the story. ULT puts the sentence in parentheses to show that. In your translation, present this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

Revelation 20:5 (#4)

ἄχρι τελεσθῇ τὰ χίλια ἔτη

"until the thousand years were ended"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [until the thousand years had ended]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 20:5 (#3)

τῶν νεκρῶν

"of the dead"

John is using the adjective **dead** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the people who had died]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 20:5 (#5)

ἡ ἀνάστασις ἡ πρώτη

"the first resurrection"

If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you could use a cardinal number here or an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [resurrection number one]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 20:6 (#3)

ὁ δεύτερος θάνατος

"the second death"

If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you could use a cardinal number here or an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [death number two]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 20:6 (#1)

μακάριος καὶ ἅγιος ὁ ἔχων μέρος ἐν τῇ ἀναστάσει τῇ πρώτῃ

"Blessed and holy {is} the one having a part in the first resurrection"

Here, **the one having a part in the first resurrection** does not refer to a specific person. It refers to anyone whom God restores to life at this time. Express this in the way that would be most natural in your language. Since John says **these** in the next sentence, it may be helpful to use a plural form in this sentence as well. Alternate translation: [Blessed and holy are all those who have a part in the first resurrection]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Revelation 20:6 (#2)

ἐπὶ τούτων ὁ δεύτερος θάνατος οὐκ ἔχει ἐξουσίαν

"Over these the second death has no power"

John is speaking of **the second death** as if it were a living thing which could have **power** over someone, that is, as if it could make someone do what it wanted that person to do. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [These people will not experience the second death]

See: Personification

Revelation 20:7 (#2)

λυθήσεται ὁ Σατανᾶς

“Satan will be released”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. See how you translated the similar expression in 20:3. Alternate translation: [God will command the angel who has the key to the abyss to release Satan]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 20:7 (#1)

ὅταν τελεσθῇ τὰ χίλια ἔτη

“when the thousand years are ended”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [at the end of the thousand years]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 20:8 (#2)

τὰ ἐν ταῖς τέσσαρσι γωνίαις τῆς γῆς

“at the four corners of the earth”

John is using the most distant places on the earth to mean those places and everything between them and his location. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [everywhere in the world]

See: Merism

Revelation 20:8 (#3)

τὸν Γὼγ καὶ Μαγώγ

“Gog and Magog”

The word **Gog** is the name of a ruler whom the prophet Ezekiel addresses in Ezekiel 38:1–39:20. The word **Magog** is the name of the land that he ruled.

See: How to Translate Names

Revelation 20:8 (#4)

τὸν Γὼγ καὶ Μαγώγ

“Gog and Magog”

John is using the ruler named **Gog** and his land of **Magog** symbolically to represent the **nations** whom the devil will deceive. He means that these nations will form a great army together and attack the people of God, just as Ezekiel described Gog gathering a great coalition of peoples against Israel. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [forming a great coalition of peoples]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 20:8 (#6)

ὡς ἡ ἄμμος τῆς θαλάσσης

“will be} like the sand of the sea”

The point of this comparison is that the **number** of soldiers in this army will be very large, just as the number of grains of **sand** on the shore of the **sea** is very large. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [will be very large, like the number of grains of sand on the seashore]

See: Simile

Revelation 20:8 (#5)

ὧν ὁ ἀριθμὸς αὐτῶν

“of whom their number”

It might seem that the expression **of whom their number** contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [whose number]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Revelation 20:8 (#1)

τὰ ἐν ταῖς τέσσαρσι γωνίαις τῆς γῆς

“at the four corners of the earth”

John is speaking as if the **earth** literally had **four corners**. He means the most distant places on the earth. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [at the most distant places on the earth]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 20:9 (#2)

τὴν πόλιν τὴν ἠγαπημένην

“the beloved city”

John assumes that his readers will understand that by **the beloved city** he means Jerusalem. You can use that name in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the city of Jerusalem]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 20:9 (#1)

τὴν πόλιν τὴν ἠγαπημένην

"the beloved city"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation, as in UST: [the city that God loves]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 20:9 (#4)

κατέφαγεν αὐτούς

"devoured them"

John is speaking as if this **fire** literally **devoured** or ate up the nations that attacked the **saints**. He means that the fire destroyed them completely. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [destroyed them completely]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 20:9 (#3)

κατέβη πῦρ ἐκ τοῦ οὐρανοῦ καὶ κατέφαγεν αὐτούς

"fire came down from heaven and devoured them"

John is speaking of this **fire** as if it were a living thing that **came down from heaven** and **devoured** this army by itself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God sent fire down from heaven, and it devoured them]

See: Personification

Revelation 20:10 (#4)

βασανισθήσονται

"they will be tormented"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who will do the action, the context suggests that it will be God. Alternate translation: [God will torment them]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 20:10 (#2)

τοῦ πυρὸς καὶ θείου

"of fire and sulfur"

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two words connected with **and**. The word **fire** describes the state of the **sulfur**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase that does not use "and." Alternate translation: [of fiery sulfur]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 20:10 (#1)

ὁ διάβολος, ὁ πλανῶν αὐτοὺς, ἐβλήθη

"the devil deceiving them was thrown"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God threw the devil who was deceiving them]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 20:10 (#6)

εἰς τοὺς αἰῶνας τῶν αἰώνων

"to the ages of the ages"

This expression refers to endless future time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for all eternity]

See: Idiom

Revelation 20:10 (#5)

ἡμέρας καὶ νυκτὸς

"day and night"

John is using the two parts of a full day, **day** and **night**, to mean all the time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all the time]

See: Merism

Revelation 20:10 (#3)

αὐτοὺς

"them"

The pronoun **them** refers to the nations whom **the devil** deceived. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the nations]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 20:11 (#5)

τόπος οὐχ εὑρέθη αὐτοῖς

"no place was found for them"

This expression means "no place could be found for them" or "they were no longer there." Alternate translation: [they were no longer there]

See: Idiom

Revelation 20:11 (#2)

ἔφυγεν ἡ γῆ καὶ ὁ οὐρανός, καὶ τόπος οὐχ εὑρέθη αὐτοῖς

"earth and heaven fled, and no place was found for them"

These two phrases mean similar things. John is using repetition to emphasize the idea that the phrases express. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them. Alternate translation: [earth and heaven vanished entirely]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 20:11 (#3)

ἔφυγεν ἡ γῆ καὶ ὁ οὐρανός

"earth and heaven fled"

John is speaking of **earth and heaven** as if they were living things that **fled**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [earth and heaven disappeared]

See: Personification

Revelation 20:11 (#4)

τόπος οὐχ εὑρέθη αὐτοῖς

"no place was found for them"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [no one found a place for them]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 20:11 (#1)

οὗ ἀπὸ τοῦ προσώπου

"from whose face"

Here the word **face** represents the presence of a person by association with the way people can see the face of someone who is present. Alternate translation: [from whose presence]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 20:12 (#3)

καὶ μεγάλους καὶ τοὺς μικρούς

"both the great and the small"

The voice is using the adjectives **great** and **small** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate these words with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [both important people and unimportant people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 20:12 (#2)

καὶ μεγάλους καὶ τοὺς μικρούς

"both the great and the small"

The voice is speaking as if important people were literally large or **great** and as if unimportant people were literally **small**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [both the important and the unimportant]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 20:12 (#1)

τοὺς νεκρούς & οἱ νεκροὶ

"the dead & the dead"

John is using the adjective **dead** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the people who had died ... the people who had died]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 20:12 (#7)

τοὺς νεκρούς & οἱ νεκροὶ

"the dead & the dead"

John is using the adjective **dead** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the people who had died ... the people who had died]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 20:12 (#4)

καὶ μεγάλους καὶ τοὺς μικρούς

“both the great and the small”

The voice is using two kinds of people, **great** and **small**, to mean all kinds of people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [people of every status]

See: Merism

Revelation 20:12 (#6)

ἐκρίθησαν οἱ νεκροὶ ἐκ τῶν γεγραμμένων ἐν τοῖς βιβλίοις

“the dead were judged from the {things} written in the books”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God judged the dead from the things he had written in the books]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 20:12 (#5)

βιβλία ἠνοίχθησαν; καὶ ἄλλο βιβλίον ἠνεῴχθη

“books were opened, and another book was opened”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God opened books, and God opened another book]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 20:13 (#3)

ὁ θάνατος καὶ ὁ Ἅιδης ἔδωκαν τοὺς νεκροὺς τοὺς ἐν αὐτοῖς

“Death and Hades gave up the dead in them”

In this context, **Death** and **Hades** are two names for the same place. John is using the names together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [the underworld gave up every single person who had died who was in it] or [not a single person who had died who was in the underworld was able to hide there]

See: Doublet

Revelation 20:13 (#2)

τοὺς νεκροὺς τοὺς ἐν αὐτῇ & τοὺς νεκροὺς τοὺς ἐν αὐτοῖς

“the dead in it & the dead in them”

John is using the adjective **dead** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the people who had died who were in it ... the people who had died who were in them]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 20:13 (#1)

ἔδωκεν ἡ θάλασσα τοὺς νεκροὺς τοὺς ἐν αὐτῇ, καὶ ὁ θάνατος καὶ ὁ Ἅιδης ἔδωκαν τοὺς νεκροὺς τοὺς ἐν αὐτοῖς

“the sea gave up the dead in it, and Death and Hades gave up the dead in them”

John is speaking of the **sea** and of **Death** and **Hades** as if these were living things that actively **gave up** the people who had died and who were in them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people who had died who were in the sea and in Death and Hades were not able to hide in those places]

See: Personification

Revelation 20:13 (#4)

ἐκρίθησαν

“they were judged”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God judged them]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 20:14 (#2)

ὁ θάνατος καὶ ὁ Ἅιδης ἐβλήθησαν

“Death and Hades were thrown”

In this context, **Death** and **Hades** are two names for the same place. John is using the names together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers,

you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [the entire underworld was thrown] or [God threw the entire underworld]

See: Doublet

Revelation 20:14 (#3)

ὁ θάνατος ὁ δεύτερός

"the second death"

If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you could use a cardinal number here or an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [death number two]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 20:14 (#1)

ὁ θάνατος καὶ ὁ Ἅιδης ἐβλήθησαν

"Death and Hades were thrown"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God threw Death and Hades]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 20:15 (#1)

καὶ εἴ τις οὐχ εὑρέθη ἐν τῇ βίβλῳ τῆς ζωῆς γεγραμμένος, ἐβλήθη

"And if anyone was not found written in the Book of Life, he was thrown"

If your language does not use these passive forms, you could express the ideas in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that in each case it was God. Alternate translation: [if God did not find that he had written someone in the Book of Life, he threw him]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 20:15 (#2)

τις

"anyone"

John is using the term **anyone** by association to mean "anyone's name." If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [anyone's name] or [someone's name]

See: Metonymy

Revelation - Chapter 21 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter gives a detailed picture of the new Jerusalem.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Second death

Death is a type of separation. The first death is physically dying, when the soul is separated from the body. The second death is being eternally separated from God. (See: soul, self; and eternity, everlasting, eternal, forever)

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Book of Life

This is a metaphor for eternal life. Those possessing eternal life are said to have their names written in this Book of Life. (See: Metaphor)

Translation Issues in This Chapter

New heaven and new earth

It is unclear whether this is an entirely new heaven and earth or something remade out of the present heaven and earth. The same is also true of the new Jerusalem. It is possible that this will affect translation in some languages.

"her"

People in this culture conventionally referred to cities by using feminine pronouns. John says "her" throughout his description of the new Jerusalem in order to mean that city. Your language may use a different gender, for example, you might say "it" and "its" instead of "her." You could also use a noun and say "that city." (See: Pronouns — When to Use Them)

"every precious stone"

In verses 19 and 20, John lists the precious stones that were the foundations of the city. In some cases, it is not certain exactly which precious stones these names describe. When the reference of a name is uncertain, ULT spells out the name using English letters. If your readers would not be familiar with some of the precious stones listed here, or if you are not certain what stone a name describes, in your translation you can spell the names the way they sound in your language. (See: Copy or Borrow Words)

Revelation 21:1 (#2)

ἀπῆλθαν

"had gone away"

John is speaking of **the first heaven and the first earth** as if they were living things that **had gone away** on their own. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [no longer existed]

See: Personification

Revelation 21:1 (#1)

ὁ & πρῶτος οὐρανὸς καὶ ἡ πρώτη γῆ

"the first heaven and the first earth"

If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you could use cardinal numbers here or equivalent expressions. Alternate translation: [heaven number one and earth number one] or [the former heaven and the former earth]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 21:2 (#1)

ἡτοιμασμένην ὡς νύμφην, κεκοσμημένην τῷ ἀνδρὶ αὐτῆς

"prepared like a bride adorned for her husband"

If your language does not use these passive forms, you could express the ideas in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. Alternate translation: [God had prepared the city the way a bride adorns herself for her husband]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 21:2 (#2)

ἡτοιμασμένην ὡς νύμφην, κεκοσμημένην τῷ ἀνδρὶ αὐτῆς

"prepared like a bride adorned for her husband"

The point of this comparison is that the city looked beautiful, just as a bride makes herself beautiful to please her husband on their wedding day. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. Alternate translation: [God had made the city beautiful, just as a bride makes herself beautiful for her husband on their wedding day]

See: Simile

Revelation 21:3 (#1)

ἡ σκηνὴ τοῦ Θεοῦ μετὰ τῶν ἀνθρώπων, καὶ σκηνώσει μετ' αὐτῶν

"The dwelling of God {is} with men, and he will dwell with them"

These two phrases mean similar things. John is using repetition to emphasize the idea that the phrases express. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them. Alternate translation: [God will now tabernacle right in the midst of men]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 21:3 (#4)

αὐτὸς ὁ Θεὸς ἔσται μετ' αὐτῶν

"God himself will be with them"

Some ancient manuscripts read, **God himself will be with them**. ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts add "as their God." If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Revelation 21:3 (#3)

τῶν ἀνθρώπων

"men"

Although the term **men** is masculine, John is using the word in a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use a term in your language that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [people]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Revelation 21:3 (#2)

ἡ σκηνὴ τοῦ Θεοῦ μετὰ τῶν ἀνθρώπων, καὶ σκηνώσει μετ' αὐτῶν

"The dwelling of God {is} with men, and he will dwell with them"

John is using a noun and a verb from the same root together for emphasis. You may be able to do the same thing in your own language. Alternate translation: [The house of God is with men, and he will house with them]

See: Poetry

Revelation 21:4 (#5)

ἀπῆλθαν

"have gone away"

John is speaking of **the first things** as if they were living things that **have gone away** on their own. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [no longer exist]

See: Personification

Revelation 21:4 (#4)

τὰ πρῶτα

"the first {things"

If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you could use a cardinal number here or an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [the former things]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 21:4 (#3)

τὰ πρῶτα

"the first {things"

John is using the adjective **first** as a noun to mean a certain kind of thing. ULT adds the word **things** to show that. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the things that existed first]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 21:4 (#2)

ὁ θάνατος οὐκ ἔσται ἔτι, οὔτε πένθος, οὔτε κραυγὴ, οὔτε πόνος

"death will not be any longer, nor grieving, nor crying, nor pain"

John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [death will not be any longer, and grieving will not be any longer, and crying will not be any longer, and pain will not be any longer]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 21:4 (#1)

ἐξαλείψει πᾶν δάκρυον ἐκ τῶν ὀφθαλμῶν αὐτῶν

"he will wipe away every tear from their eyes"

By using one thing that a person might do to console another person, John is representing all that someone might do to console someone else. If it would be helpful in your language, you could name something that someone might do similarly in your culture, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God will console them]

See: Synecdoche

Revelation 21:5 (#2)

πιστοὶ καὶ ἀληθινοί

"trustworthy and true"

The terms **trustworthy** and **true** mean similar things. God on the throne is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [entirely trustworthy]

See: Doublet

Revelation 21:5 (#1)

οὗτοι οἱ λόγοι & εἰσιν

"these words are"

God is using the term **word** to mean the statement that he has just made by using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what I have just said is]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 21:6 (#3)

τὸ Ἄλφα καὶ τὸ Ὦ

"the Alpha and the Omega"

God is speaking as if he were literally two letters of the alphabet. **Alpha** is the first letter of the Greek alphabet and **Omega** is the last letter, so God means that he has existed from all eternity and will exist to all eternity. If your language uses figures of speech, you could use the first and last letters of your own alphabet. Alternatively, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the A and the Z] or [the First and the Last]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 21:6 (#4)

ἐγὼ τῷ διψῶντι δώσω ἐκ τῆς πηγῆς τοῦ ὕδατος τῆς ζωῆς δωρεάν

"To the one thirsting I will give freely from the spring of the water of life"

God is speaking as if he would literally give **water** to someone who was **thirsting**. He is using thirst to represent a person's desire for everlasting life and he is using drinking life-giving water to represent that

person receiving everlasting life. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will give everlasting life to the one who eagerly desires to have it]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 21:6 (#2)

τὸ Ἄλφα καὶ τὸ Ὦ, ἡ ἀρχὴ καὶ τὸ τέλος

"the Alpha and the Omega, the beginning and the end"

God is using two pairs of extremes, the **Alpha** and the **Omega** and the **beginning** and the **end**, to mean those extremes and everything in between. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the one who began everything and who will finish everything]

See: Merism

Revelation 21:6 (#1)

τὸ Ἄλφα καὶ τὸ Ὦ, ἡ ἀρχὴ καὶ τὸ τέλος

"the Alpha and the Omega, the beginning and the end"

These two phrases mean similar things. John is using repetition to emphasize the idea that the phrases express. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them. Alternate translation: [the very beginning and the very end]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 21:7 (#2)

ἔσομαι αὐτῷ Θεὸς, καὶ αὐτὸς ἔσται μοι υἱός

"I will be his God, and he will be my son"

Although the term **son** is masculine, God is using the word in a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use a term in your language that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [I will be the God of that person, and that person will be my child]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Revelation 21:7 (#1)

ὁ νικῶν

"The one conquering"

The one conquering does not refer to a specific person. It refers to anyone who conquers in the sense that Jesus uses that term in the letters to the seven churches and as John uses it in 20:11. Express this in the way that would be most natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Everyone who conquers]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Revelation 21:8 (#2)

ἐβδελυγμένοις

"the abhorred"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [those who do things that make God abhor them]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 21:8 (#4)

ὁ θάνατος ὁ δεύτερος

"the second death"

If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you could use a cardinal number here or an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [death number two]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 21:8 (#1)

τοῖς δὲ δειλοῖς, καὶ ἀπίστοις

"But for the cowardly and the unbelieving"

John is using the adjectives **cowardly** and **unbelieving** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate these words with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [for cowardly people and unbelieving people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 21:8 (#3)

πυρὶ καὶ θείῳ

"with fire and sulfur"

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two words connected with **and**. The word **fire** describes the state of the **sulfur**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase that does not use "and." Alternate translation: [with fiery sulfur]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 21:9 (#1)

τὴν νύμφην, τὴν γυναῖκα τοῦ Ἀρνίου

“the bride, the wife of the Lamb”

The angel is speaking as if the new Jerusalem were literally a **bride** who was going to marry the **Lamb**. He means that God’s people will now be united forever with Jesus their Savior. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [how the people of God will be united forever with Jesus]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 21:10 (#2)

μέγα καὶ ὑψηλόν

“great and high”

The terms **great** and **high** mean similar things. John is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation, as in UST: [very high]

See: Doublet

Revelation 21:10 (#1)

ἀπήνεγκέν με ἐν Πνεύματι ἐπὶ ὄρος μέγα καὶ ὑψηλόν

“he carried me away in the Spirit to a great and high mountain”

See how you translated the expression **in the Spirit** in 1:10 and 4:2. Alternate translation: [as he carried me away to a great and high mountain, the Holy Spirit inspired me so that I could receive further revelation]

See: Idiom

Revelation 21:11 (#3)

ἰάσπιδι κρυσταλλίζοντι

“of jasper shining like crystal”

See how you translated the word **jasper** in 4:3 and the word **crystal** in 4:6.

See: Translate Unknowns

Revelation 21:11 (#2)

ὅμοιος λίθῳ τιμιωτάτῳ, ὡς λίθῳ ἰάσπιδι

“being} like a most precious stone, like a stone of jasper”

These two phrases mean the same thing. The first is a general statement and the second is a specific example. John is using repetition to emphasize the idea that the phrases express. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them. Alternate translation: [like a very precious jasper stone]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 21:11 (#1)

ὁ φωστὴρ αὐτῆς ὅμοιος λίθῳ τιμιωτάτῳ

“its brilliance {being} like a most precious stone”

The point of this comparison is that the **brilliance** or luster of the city was bright and beautiful. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [its brilliance was bright and beautiful, like that of a most precious stone]

See: Simile

Revelation 21:12 (#3)

ὀνόματα ἐπιγεγραμμένα

“names having been written”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [names that God had written]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 21:12 (#1)

ἔχουσα τεῖχος μέγα καὶ ὑψηλόν

“Having a great and high wall”

The terms **great** and **high** mean similar things. John is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. Alternate translation: [The city had a very high wall]

See: Doublet

Revelation 21:12 (#2)

ὀνόματα ἐπιγεγραμμένα, ἅ ἐστιν τῶν δώδεκα φυλῶν

“names having been written that are the 12 tribes”

John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate

translation: [names having been written on the gates that are the names of the 12 tribes]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 21:12 (#4)

υἱῶν Ἰσραήλ

“of the sons of Israel”

Here, **sons** figuratively means “descendants.” John is identifying the Israelites as descendants of their ancestor Israel (who was also known as Jacob). If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [of the people of Israel]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 21:15 (#1)

τοὺς πυλῶνας αὐτῆς, καὶ τὸ τεῖχος αὐτῆς

“her gates and her wall”

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, people in this culture conventionally referred to cities by using feminine pronouns. Your language may use a different gender. You could also use a noun and say “that city.” Alternate translation: [its gates and its wall] or [the gates and wall of that city]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 21:16 (#1)

σταδίων δώδεκα χιλιάδων

“12,000 stadia”

The word **stadia** is the plural form of “stadium,” which was a distance of about 185 meters. If it would be helpful in your language, you could give the equivalent in modern measurements. However, you might also wish to retain the ancient measurement, since there may be some symbolic significance to the number 12,000. Alternate translation: [about 2,200 kilometers] or [about 1,300 miles]

See: Biblical Distance

Revelation 21:17 (#3)

ἑκατὸν τεσσεράκοντα τεσσάρων πηχῶν

“144 cubits”

A **cubit** was the measurement of the distance from a person’s elbow to his longest fingertip, typically about half a meter or about 18 inches. If it would be helpful in your language, you could give the equivalent in modern measurements. However, you might also wish to retain the ancient measurement, since there may be some symbolic significance to the number 144. Alternate translation: [about 70 meters] or [about 200 feet]

See: Biblical Distance

Revelation 21:17 (#4)

μέτρον ἀνθρώπου ὅ ἐστιν ἀγγέλου

“by the measurement of a man, which is of an angel”

Since **cubits** were the distance from an elbow to a fingertip, John needs to specify from what size person the angel determined this measurement. This could mean: (1) that the angel appeared to John in human form and so the distance from his elbow to his fingertip was the same as that of a human. It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. Alternate translation: [The angel appeared in human form, and so he used an ordinary human cubit to measure]; (2) that the angel may have been a giant compared with humans, but the angel still used a human-sized cubit. Alternate translation: [The angel used the cubit measure that people ordinarily use]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 21:17 (#1)

ἐμέτρησεν τὸ τεῖχος αὐτῆς, ἑκατὸν τεσσεράκοντα τεσσάρων πηχῶν

“he measured her wall, 144 cubits”

John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [he measured her wall and found it to be 144 cubits]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 21:17 (#2)

ἑκατὸν τεσσεράκοντα τεσσάρων πηχῶν

“144 cubits”

This could be the measurement: (1) of the height of the wall. Alternate translation: [144 cubits high]; (2) of the thickness of the wall. Alternate translation: [144 cubits thick]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 21:18 (#1)

χρυσίον καθαρὸν, ὅμοιον ὑάλῳ καθαρῷ

“is} pure gold, like pure glass”

The point of this comparison is that the **gold** from which the city was made was clear and bright, just as **pure glass** has no imperfections that keep it from reflecting light or letting light through. Alternate translation: [is gold that is as clear and bright as pure glass]

See: Simile

Revelation 21:19 (#3)

ὁ δεύτερος σάπφειρος, ὁ τρίτος χαλκηδών, ὁ τέταρτος σμάραγδος

“the second sapphire, the third chalcedony, the fourth emerald”

John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [the second foundation was sapphire, the third foundation was chalcedony, the fourth foundation was emerald]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 21:19 (#1)

οἱ θεμέλιοι τοῦ τείχους τῆς πόλεως & κεκοσμημένοι

“The foundations of the wall of the city were adorned”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [God had adorned the foundations of the wall of the city]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 21:19 (#5)

ἴασπις & σάπφειρος & χαλκηδών & σμάραγδος

“was} jasper & sapphire & chalcedony & emerald”

As the introduction to this chapter discusses, in some cases it is not certain what precious stones the names in this verse and the next verse describe. When the reference of a name is uncertain, ULT spells out the name using English letters. If your readers would not be familiar with some of the precious stones listed here, in your translation you can spell their names the way they sound in your language.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Revelation 21:19 (#2)

παντὶ λίθῳ τιμίῳ

“with every precious stone”

John says **every** here as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [with many different precious stones]

See: Hyperbole

Revelation 21:19 (#4)

ὁ θεμέλιος ὁ πρῶτος ἴασπις, ὁ δεύτερος σάπφειρος, ὁ τρίτος χαλκηδών, ὁ τέταρτος σμάραγδος

“The first foundation {was} jasper, the second sapphire, the third chalcedony, the fourth emerald”

If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you could use cardinal numbers here or equivalent expressions. Alternate translation: [Foundation number one was jasper, foundation number two was sapphire, foundation number three was chalcedony, foundation number four was emerald]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 21:20 (#1)

ὁ πέμπτος σαρδόνυξ, ὁ ἕκτος σάρδιον, ὁ ἕβδομος χρυσόλιθος, ὁ ὄγδοος βήρυλλος, ὁ ἔνατος τοπάζιον, ὁ δέκατος χρυσόπρασος, ὁ ἑνδέκατος ὑάκινθος, ὁ δωδέκατος ἀμέθυστος

“the fifth sardonyx, the sixth carnelian, the seventh chrysolite, the eighth beryl, the ninth topaz, the tenth chrysoprase, the eleventh jacinth, the twelfth amethyst”

John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [the fifth foundation was sardonyx, the sixth foundation was carnelian, the seventh foundation was chrysolite, the eighth foundation was beryl, the ninth foundation was topaz, the tenth foundation was chrysoprase, the eleventh foundation was jacinth, the twelfth foundation was amethyst]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 21:20 (#2)

ὁ πέμπτος σαρδόνυξ, ὁ ἕκτος σάρδιον, ὁ ἕβδομος χρυσόλιθος, ὁ ὄγδοος βήρυλλος, ὁ ἔνατος τοπάζιον, ὁ δέκατος χρυσόπρασος, ὁ ἑνδέκατος ὑάκινθος, ὁ δωδέκατος ἀμέθυστος

“the fifth sardonyx, the sixth carnelian, the seventh chrysolite, the eighth beryl, the ninth topaz, the tenth chrysoprase, the eleventh jacinth, the twelfth amethyst”

If your language does not use ordinal numbers, you could use cardinal numbers here or equivalent expressions. Alternate translation: [foundation number five was sardonyx, foundation number six was carnelian, foundation number seven was chrysolite, foundation number eight was beryl, foundation number nine was topaz, foundation number ten was chrysoprase, foundation number eleven was jacinth, foundation number twelve was amethyst]

See: Ordinal Numbers

Revelation 21:21 (#2)

χρυσίον καθαρὸν ὡς ὕαλος διαυγής

“was} pure gold, like transparent glass”

See how you translated the similar expression in 21:18. Alternate translation: [was gold that was as clear and bright as transparent glass]

See: Simile

Revelation 21:21 (#1)

ἀνὰ εἷς ἕκαστος τῶν πυλώνων

“each one of the gates individually”

It might seem that this phrase contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [each of the gates]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Revelation 21:22 (#1)

ὁ & Κύριος ὁ Θεός ὁ Παντοκράτωρ ναὸς αὐτῆς ἐστιν, καὶ τὸ Ἀρνίον

“the Lord God, the Ruler of All, is her temple, and the Lamb”

It may be more natural to put the information about the **Lamb** with the information about the **Lord God**. Alternate translation: [the Lord God, the Ruler of All, and the Lamb are her temple]

See: Information Structure

Revelation 21:22 (#2)

ὁ & Κύριος ὁ Θεός ὁ Παντοκράτωρ ναὸς αὐτῆς ἐστιν, καὶ τὸ Ἀρνίον

“the Lord God, the Ruler of All, is her temple, and the Lamb”

Since John has just said that there is **no temple** in the city, he does not mean that the **Lord God** and the **Lamb** are literally a temple. Rather, he means that the people in the city can be in God’s presence all the time without having to go to a temple. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the Lord God, the Ruler of All, and the Lamb are always present in the city]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 21:23 (#2)

ὁ λύχνος αὐτῆς τὸ Ἀρνίον

“her lamp {is} the Lamb”

John is speaking as if the **Lamb** were literally a **lamp** that lit up the city. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [her light is the Lamb] or [its light is the Lamb] or [the light of that city is the Lamb]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 21:23 (#1)

οὐδὲ τῆς σελήνης

“nor of the moon”

John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [nor does the city have need of the moon]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 21:24 (#2)

τὰ ἔθνη

“the nations”

Some ancient manuscripts read **the nations**. ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts read “the nations that are saved.” If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Revelation 21:24 (#1)

περιπατήσουσιν τὰ ἔθνη διὰ τοῦ φωτὸς αὐτῆς

“the nations will walk by the light of her”

John is speaking as if the **nations** would literally know where to **walk** because they would see well by the **light** from the city. In this context, the word **walk** figuratively means how people live and behave, and so the word **light** represents good guidance about how to live and behave. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people in the city will live in such a way as to guide the nations about how to live as God wishes]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 21:24 (#3)

οἱ βασιλεῖς τῆς γῆς φέρουσιν τὴν δόξαν αὐτῶν εἰς αὐτήν

"the kings of the earth bring their glory into her"

By **their glory**, John may mean by association symbols of royal power, such as crowns, scepters, and robes. He may be describing a situation like the one in 4:10, where he saw the 24 elders "lay their crowns before the throne" to acknowledge God as the Supreme Ruler. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the kings of the earth will come into the city and lay their royal crowns, scepters, and robes before God's throne to acknowledge him as the Supreme Ruler]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 21:25 (#1)

οἱ πυλῶνες αὐτῆς οὐ μὴ κλεισθῶσιν

"her gates will certainly not be shut"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [no one at all will shut her gates]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 21:25 (#2)

οἱ πυλῶνες αὐτῆς οὐ μὴ κλεισθῶσιν

"her gates will certainly not be shut"

If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this double negative that consists of the negative particle **not** and the negative verb **shut**. Alternate translation: [her gates will always be open]

See: Double Negatives

Revelation 21:26 (#3)

τὴν δόξαν καὶ τὴν τιμὴν

"the glory and the honor"

The terms **glory** and **honor** mean similar things. John is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [the splendor]

See: Doublet

Revelation 21:26 (#1)

οἴσουσιν τὴν δόξαν καὶ τὴν τιμὴν τῶν ἐθνῶν

"they will bring the glory and the honor of the nations"

The pronoun **they** seems to refer to people from the **nations**. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the people of the nations will bring their glory and honor]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 21:26 (#2)

οἴσουσιν τὴν δόξαν καὶ τὴν τιμὴν τῶν ἐθνῶν

"they will bring the glory and the honor of the nations"

John is likely referring to wealth, by association with the way wealth is stored in things that are considered to have **glory** and **honor**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. This could mean: (1) that the nations will send valuable gifts to God in the city as expressions of their devotion. Alternate translation: [they will bring valuable gifts from the nations]; (2) that the nations will send tribute payments to God. Alternate translation: [they will bring tribute from the nations]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 21:27 (#5)

οἱ γεγραμμένοι

"the ones having been written"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, the context suggests that it was God. Alternate translation: [the ones whom God has written] or [the ones whose names God has written]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 21:27 (#2)

ὁ ποιῶν βδέλυγμα καὶ ψεῦδος

“the one doing abomination and falsehood”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **abomination** and **falsehood**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [anyone who does abominable things and tells lies]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 21:27 (#4)

οἱ γεγραμμένοι

“the ones having been written”

John is referring to the names of people by association with the people themselves. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the ones whose names have been written]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 21:27 (#1)

οὐ μὴ εἰσέλθῃ εἰς αὐτὴν πᾶν κοινὸν, καὶ ὁ ποιῶν βδέλυγμα καὶ ψεῦδος

“everything unclean will certainly not enter into her and the one doing abomination and falsehood”

It may be more natural to put the information about **the one doing abomination and falsehood** with the information about the **everything unclean**. Alternate translation: [everything unclean and the one doing abomination and falsehood will not at all enter into her]

See: Information Structure

Revelation 21:27 (#3)

εἰ μὴ

“if not”

This expression limits the meaning of **enter** to the people it introduces. Your language may have its own way of expressing this idea. Alternate translation: [but only]

See: Idiom

Revelation - Chapter 22 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter emphasizes that Jesus is coming soon.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Tree of life

There is probably an intended connection between the tree of life in the Garden of Eden and the tree of life mentioned in this chapter. The curse that began in Eden will end at this time.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Alpha and omega

These are the names of the first and last letters in the Greek alphabet. The ULT spells out their names in English. This strategy can serve as a model for translators. Some translators, however, may decide to use the first and last letters in their own alphabet. That would be A and Z in English.

Revelation 22:1 (#1)

ἔδειξέν

“he showed”

The pronoun **he** refers to the angel who had one of the seven bowls, who began speaking to John in 21:9 and who was showing him the new Jerusalem. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the angel who had been showing me the city showed]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 22:1 (#2)

ἐκ τοῦ θρόνου τοῦ Θεοῦ καὶ τοῦ Ἀρνίου

“from the throne of God and of the Lamb”

John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. That may help clarify that **God** and **the Lamb** do not share a single throne. Alternate translation: [from the throne of God and from the throne of the Lamb]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 22:2 (#1)

ἐν μέσῳ τῆς πλατείας αὐτῆς καὶ

“in the middle of its public square. And”

This phrase could refer implicitly to: (1) where the river flowed. That is the interpretation that ULT and UST follow. (2) where the tree of life was. In that case this would be the beginning of a new sentence. Alternate translation: [In the middle of its public square and]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 22:3 (#1)

ὁ θρόνος τοῦ Θεοῦ καὶ τοῦ Ἀρνίου

“the throne of God and of the Lamb”

John is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. That may help clarify that **God** and **the Lamb** do not share a single throne. Alternate translation: [the throne of God and the throne of the Lamb]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 22:4 (#1)

τὸ πρόσωπον αὐτοῦ

“his face”

John is using one part of God, his **face**, to represent all of God as his servants see him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [him]

See: Synecdoche

Revelation 22:5 (#1)

εἰς τοὺς αἰῶνας τῶν αἰώνων

“to the ages of the ages”

This expression refers to endless future time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for all eternity]

See: Idiom

Revelation 22:6 (#3)

πιστοὶ καὶ ἀληθινοί

“trustworthy and true”

The terms **trustworthy** and **true** mean similar things. The angel is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [entirely trustworthy]

See: Doublet

Revelation 22:6 (#1)

εἶπέν

“he said”

The pronoun **he** refers to the same angel as in verse 1. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the angel said]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 22:6 (#2)

οὗτοι οἱ λόγοι

“These words {are”

The angel is using the term **words** to mean what he has been telling John by using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [What I have been telling you is]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 22:7 (#1)

καὶ ἰδοὺ

“And behold”

John assumes that his readers will understand that Jesus is speaking in this verse. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Then Jesus said, “And behold]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 22:7 (#2)

τοὺς λόγους τῆς προφητείας τοῦ βιβλίου τούτου

“the words of the prophecy of this book”

Jesus is using the term **words** to mean what John has written in this **book**, using words, to describe the **prophecies** that God gave to him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what you have said in this book about the prophecies God gave you]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 22:8 (#1)

ἔπεσα

“I fell down”

This expression means that John lay down facing the ground. See how you translated the similar expression in 7:11. Alternate translation: [I bowed down]

See: Idiom

Revelation 22:9 (#3)

τῶν ἀδελφῶν σου, τῶν προφητῶν

“of your brothers the prophets”

The angel is using the term **brothers** figuratively to mean fellow prophets. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [of your fellow prophets]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 22:9 (#1)

ὅρα μή

“See not”

The angel is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [See that you do not do that]

See: Ellipsis

Revelation 22:9 (#4)

τῶν ἀδελφῶν σου, τῶν προφητῶν

“of your brothers the prophets”

Although the term **brothers** is masculine, here the word has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If you wish to retain the figurative expression in your translation, you could word it in a way that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [of your brothers and sisters the prophets]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Revelation 22:9 (#5)

τοὺς λόγους τοῦ βιβλίου τούτου

“the words of this book”

The angel is using the term **words** to mean what John has said in **this book** by using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what you have said in this book]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 22:9 (#2)

ὅρα μή

“See not”

The angel is using the term **See** to mean by association that John should give careful attention to what he is doing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Watch out! Do not do that!] or [Be careful not to do that]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 22:10 (#2)

μὴ σφραγίσῃς

“Do not seal”

The angel is speaking as if John might literally **seal** his **book** closed once he has written it. The angel means that John should tell others what he has written in the book and not keep those things to himself. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Widely proclaim]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 22:10 (#3)

τοὺς λόγους τῆς προφητείας τοῦ βιβλίου τούτου

“the words of the prophecy of this book”

The angel is using the term **words** to mean what John has said in **this book** by using words to describe the **prophecy** that God gave him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what you have said in this book about the prophecy God gave you]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 22:10 (#1)

μὴ σφραγίσῃς

“Do not seal”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this double negative that consists of the negative particle **not** and the negative verb **seal**. Alternate translation: [Leave open]

See: Double Negatives

Revelation 22:11 (#3)

ὁ ἀδικῶν & ὁ ῥυπαρὸς & ὁ δίκαιος & ὁ ἅγιος

“the one being unrighteous & the filthy {one & the righteous {one & the holy {one”

These phrases do not refer to specific people. They refer to anyone who has the quality that they name. Express this in the way that would be most natural in your language. Alternate translation: [anyone who is unrighteous ... anyone who is filthy ... anyone who is righteous ... anyone who is holy]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Revelation 22:11 (#4)

ὁ ῥυπαρὸς & ὁ δίκαιος & ὁ ἅγιος

“the filthy {one & the righteous {one & the holy {one”

John is using the adjectives **filthy**, **righteous**, and **holy** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. ULT adds **one** in each case to show that. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate these words with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [the person who is filthy ... the person who is righteous ... the person who is holy]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 22:11 (#5)

ὁ ῥυπαρὸς, ῥυπανθήτω ἔτι

“let the filthy {one} still be filthy”

The angel is speaking as if someone who does wrong were literally **filthy** or dirty. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [let the person who is wicked still be wicked]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 22:11 (#1)

ὁ ἀδικῶν, ἀδικησάτω ἔτι; καὶ ὁ ῥυπαρὸς, ῥυπανθήτω ἔτι; καὶ ὁ δίκαιος, δικαιοσύνην ποιησάτω ἔτι; καὶ ὁ ἅγιος, ἁγιασθήτω ἔτι

“Let the one being unrighteous still be unrighteous, and let the filthy {one} still be filthy, and let the righteous {one} still do righteousness, and let the holy {one} still be holy”

If your language does not use third-person imperatives in this way, you make these statements in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [May the one being unrighteous still be unrighteous, and may the filthy one still be filthy, and may the righteous one still do righteousness, and may the holy one still be holy] or [The one being unrighteous should still be unrighteous, and the filthy one should still be filthy, and the righteous one should do righteousness, and the holy one should still be holy]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Revelation 22:11 (#6)

δικαιοσύνην

“righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is right]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 22:11 (#2)

ὁ ἀδικῶν, ἀδικησάτω ἔτι

“Let the one being unrighteous still be unrighteous”

In this verse, the angel is using a series of similar phrases in order to emphasize the idea that the phrases express. Try to translate each of these phrases in such a way as to show their similarity. You may also wish to summarize the idea behind the phrases beforehand, if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [The time is so near that it is too late for people to change the way they are living. So let the one being unrighteous still be unrighteous]

See: Litany

Revelation 22:12 (#1)

ἰδοὺ

“Behold”

John assumes that his readers will understand that Jesus continues speaking in this verse and continues speaking through verse 16. You could indicate that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Then Jesus said, “Behold]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 22:13 (#3)

τὸ Ἄλφα καὶ τὸ Ὦ

“the Alpha and the Omega”

See how you translated this in 21:6.

See: Metaphor

Revelation 22:13 (#2)

τὸ Ἄλφα καὶ τὸ Ὦ, ὁ πρῶτος καὶ ὁ ἔσχατος, ἡ ἀρχὴ καὶ τὸ τέλος

“the Alpha and the Omega, the first and the last, the beginning and the end”

Jesus is using three pairs of extremes, the **Alpha** and the **Omega**, the **first** and the **last**, and the **beginning** and the **end**, to mean those extremes and everything

in between. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the one who began everything and who will finish everything]

See: Merism

Revelation 22:13 (#1)

τὸ Ἄλφα καὶ τὸ Ὦ, ὁ πρῶτος καὶ ὁ ἔσχατος, ἡ ἀρχὴ καὶ τὸ τέλος

"the Alpha and the Omega, the first and the last, the beginning and the end"

These three phrases mean similar things. Jesus is using repetition to emphasize the idea that the phrases express. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them. Alternate translation: [the very beginning and the very end]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 22:14 (#2)

οἱ πλύνοντες τὰς στολὰς αὐτῶν

"the ones washing their robes"

Some ancient manuscripts read **the ones washing their robes**. ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts read "the ones doing his commandments." If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Revelation 22:14 (#3)

ἔσται ἡ ἐξουσία αὐτῶν ἐπὶ τὸ ξύλον τῆς ζωῆς

"their authority over the tree of life will be"

If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning of this expression plainly. Alternate translation: [they will have the right to eat from the tree of life]

See: Idiom

Revelation 22:14 (#1)

οἱ πλύνοντες τὰς στολὰς αὐτῶν

"the ones washing their robes"

Jesus is speaking as if people who repent of their sins and start living in a way that pleases God are literally **washing their robes**. See how you translated the similar expression in 7:14.

See: Metaphor

Revelation 22:15 (#2)

οἱ κύνες

"dogs"

Jesus is speaking as if wicked people were literally **dogs**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [wicked people]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 22:15 (#3)

οἱ πόρνοι

"the sexually immoral"

Jesus is using the adjective **sexual immoral** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [people who are sexually immoral]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Revelation 22:15 (#1)

οἱ κύνες

"dogs"

In this culture, people considered **dogs** to be dirty and bothersome animals. So this is not a positive statement, as it would be in some other cultures where dogs are cherished as household pets and as helpful workers and companions. It may be helpful to use an expression in your translation that will clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [dirty animals]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 22:15 (#5)

ψεῦδος

"falsehood"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **falsehood**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is false] or [what is wrong]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 22:15 (#4)

φιλῶν καὶ ποιῶν

"loving and doing"

This phrase expresses a single idea by using two words connected with **and**. The word **loving** tells in what way these people are **doing** falsehood. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning with an equivalent phrase that does not use "and." Alternate translation: [eagerly doing]

See: Hendiadys

Revelation 22:16 (#1)

μαρτυρῆσαι ὑμῖν ταῦτα ἐπὶ ταῖς ἐκκλησίαις

"to testify these things to you concerning the churches"

Here the word **you** is plural. Alternate translation: [to testify to all of you in the churches about these things that concern you]

See: Forms of You

Revelation 22:16 (#3)

ὁ ἀστὴρ ὁ λαμπρός, ὁ πρωϊνός

"the bright morning star"

Jesus is also speaking of himself as if he were the bright **star** that sometimes appears early in the **morning** and indicates that a new day is about to begin. Alternate translation: [the sign that God is beginning a new era]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 22:16 (#2)

ἡ ῥίζα καὶ τὸ γένος Δαυείδ

"the root and the offspring of David"

Jesus is speaking as if here were literally the **root** of a tree. He means that David came from him, just as a tree comes from its roots. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [both the source and the offspring of David]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 22:17 (#3)

ἔρχου & ἔρχου

"Come & Come"

These are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than commands. For each instance, use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please." Alternate translation: [Please come ... Please come]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Revelation 22:17 (#1)

ἡ νύμφη

"the Bride"

In keeping with the symbolism of his vision, John is speaking of the church as if it were literally the **Bride** of Jesus. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the church]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 22:17 (#7)

καὶ ὁ διψῶν ἐρχέσθω; ὁ θέλων λαβέτω ὕδωρ ζωῆς δωρεάν

"And the one thirsting, let him come. The one desiring, let him take the water of life freely"

These two sentences mean basically the same thing. John is speaking in something like Hebrew poetry, which was based on this kind of repetition. It would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if such repetition would not be natural in your language, you could connect the clauses with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second clause is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Let the one who is thirsting come, yes, let the one desiring take the water of life freely] or [Let the one who wants to have everlasting life come, yes, let the one who desires everlasting life receive it freely]

See: Parallelism

Revelation 22:17 (#6)

καὶ ὁ διψῶν ἐρχέσθω; ὁ θέλων λαβέτω ὕδωρ ζωῆς δωρεάν

"And the one thirsting, let him come. The one desiring, let him take the water of life freely"

In 21:6, God spoke as if he would literally give "water" to someone who was "thirsting." He was using thirst to represent a person's desire for everlasting life and he was using drinking life-giving water to represent that person receiving everlasting life. John is echoing the same image here. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Let the one who wants to have everlasting life come. Let the one who desires everlasting life receive it freely]

See: Metaphor

Revelation 22:17 (#2)

λέγουσιν, ἔρχου & ὁ ἀκούων εἰπάτω, ἔρχου

“say, “Come & let the one hearing say, “Come”

In both cases, the implied “you” in the imperative **Come** is singular, so use a singular form if your language marks that distinction. If it does not, you could indicate the addressee in another way. The addressee could be: (1) Jesus, who says in verses 12 and 20, “I am coming quickly,” and to whom John says explicitly in v. 20, “Come, Lord Jesus!” Alternate translation: [say to Jesus, “Come!” ... let the one hearing say to Jesus, “Come!”]; (2) the **one thirsting**, whom John mentions in the next sentence. Alternate translation: [say to the one thirsting, “Come!” ... let the one hearing say to the one thirsting, “Come!”]

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Revelation 22:17 (#5)

ὁ ἀκούων & ὁ διψῶν & ὁ θέλων

“the one hearing & the one thirsting & The one desiring”

These phrases do not refer to specific people. They refer to anyone who has the quality that they name. Express this in the way that would be most natural in your language. Alternate translation: [anyone who hears ... anyone who thirsts ... anyone who desires]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Revelation 22:17 (#4)

ὁ ἀκούων εἰπάτω & ὁ διψῶν ἐρχέσθω; ὁ θέλων λαβέτω

“let the one hearing say & the one thirsting, let him come. The one desiring, let him take”

If your language does not use the third-person imperative in this way, you could state this in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [may the one hearing say ... may the one thirsting come ... may the one desiring take] or [the one hearing should say ... the one thirsting should come ... the one desiring should take]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Revelation 22:18 (#1)

ἐγὼ

“I”

The pronoun **I** refers to John. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [I, John,]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Revelation 22:18 (#2)

τῷ ἀκούοντι τοὺς λόγους τῆς προφητείας τοῦ βιβλίου τούτου & ἐπ’ αὐτά

“hearing the words of the prophecy of this book & to them”

John is using the term **words** to mean what he has written about in **this book** by using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the prophecy I have written about in this book ... to what I have written]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 22:18 (#3)

τὰς γεγραμμένας

“written”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [that I have written about]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 22:19 (#2)

τοῦ ξύλου τῆς ζωῆς

“the tree of life”

Some ancient manuscripts read **the tree of life**. ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts read “the Book of Life.” If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Revelation 22:19 (#1)

τῶν λόγων τοῦ βιβλίου τῆς προφητείας ταύτης

“the words of the book of this prophecy”

John is using the term **words** to mean what he has written about in **this book** by using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the prophecy I have written about in this book]

See: Metonymy

Revelation 22:19 (#3)

τῶν γεγραμμένων

“written”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [that I have written about]

See: Active or Passive

Revelation 22:20 (#1)

ὁ μαρτυρῶν ταῦτα

“The one testifying these {things”

John assumes that his readers will understand that by **the one testifying** he means Jesus. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Jesus, the one who testifies these things,]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Revelation 22:20 (#2)

ἀμήν

“Amen”

See how you translated the term **Amen** in 1:6.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Revelation 22:21 (#2)

ἡ χάρις τοῦ Κυρίου Ἰησοῦ μετὰ

“The grace of the Lord Jesus {be} with”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **grace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [May the Lord Jesus be gracious to]

See: Abstract Nouns

Revelation 22:21 (#1)

ἡ χάρις τοῦ Κυρίου Ἰησοῦ μετὰ τῶν ἁγίων

“The grace of the Lord Jesus {be} with the saints”

John is ending the book of Revelation by asking God to bless the **saints**, that is, the people who belong to God. In your translation, use a form that speakers of your language would recognize as a blessing. Alternate translation: [May the Lord Jesus bless all of you who belong to God by giving you his grace]

See: Blessings